



International
Labour
Organization

► **Labour market supply
and demand for
Sri Lankan migrant workers**

- ▶ **Labour market supply and demand for Sri Lankan migrant workers**

Copyright © International Labour Organization 2023

First published 2023



This is an open access work distributed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>). Users can reuse, share, adapt and build upon the original work, as detailed in the License. The ILO must be clearly credited as the owner of the original work. The use of the emblem of the ILO is not permitted in connection with users' work.

Attribution – The work must be cited as follows: *Labour Market Demand and Supply for Sri Lankan Migrant Workers*, Colombo: International Labour Office, 2023]

Translations – In case of a translation of this work, the following disclaimer must be added along with the attribution: *This translation was not created by the International Labour Organization (ILO) and should not be considered an official ILO translation. The ILO is not responsible for the content or accuracy of this translation.*

Adaptations – In case of an adaptation of this work, the following disclaimer must be added along with the attribution: *This is an adaptation of an original work by the International Labour Organization (ILO). Responsibility for the views and opinions expressed in the adaptation rests solely with the author or authors of the adaptation and are not endorsed by the ILO.*

This CC license does not apply to non-ILO copyright materials included in this publication. If the material is attributed to a third party, the user of such material is solely responsible for clearing the rights with the right holder.

Any dispute arising under this license that cannot be settled amicably shall be referred to arbitration in accordance with the Arbitration Rules of the United Nations Commission on International Trade Law (UNCITRAL). The parties shall be bound by any arbitration award rendered as a result of such arbitration as the final adjudication of such a dispute.

All queries on rights and licensing should be addressed to the ILO Publishing Unit (Rights and Licensing), 1211 Geneva 22, Switzerland, or by email to rights@ilo.org.

ISBN 978-922-0399-15-6 (Print)

ISBN 978-922-0399-16-3 (web PDF)

The designations employed in ILO publications, which are in conformity with United Nations practice, and the presentation of material therein do not imply the expression of any opinion whatsoever on the part of the ILO concerning the legal status of any country, area or territory or of its authorities, or concerning the delimitation of its frontiers.

The responsibility for opinions expressed in signed articles, studies and other contributions rests solely with their authors, and publication does not constitute an endorsement by the ILO of the opinions expressed in them.

Reference to names of firms and commercial products and processes does not imply their endorsement by the ILO, and any failure to mention a particular firm, commercial product or process is not a sign of disapproval.

Reference to names of firms and commercial products and processes does not imply their endorsement by the ILO, and any failure to mention a particular firm, commercial product or process is not a sign of disapproval.

Information on ILO publications and digital products can be found at: www.ilo.org/publns.

Printed in Sri Lanka

► Foreward

Since early 2022, Sri Lanka has been faced with one of the most severe political and economic crises in recent history. A critical issue has been the acute shortage of foreign currency within the country. This scarcity has compelled the Government to actively promote migration and foreign employment as a means of alleviating economic pressures facing households. This multifaceted crisis has cast a significant shadow over the Sri Lankan labor market and the foreign employment industry. It is worth noting that between 2020 and 2021, Sri Lanka witnessed a surge in returning migrant workers due to the global COVID-19 pandemic. This sudden influx further exacerbated the situation of unemployment and provision of welfare, with a substantial portion of returnees facing difficulties in reintegrating effectively. This struggle primarily stemmed from the lack of income and employment opportunities available to them.

In an ideal scenario of labor migration, aspiring migrant workers make informed decisions when deciding to seek employment abroad. They consider available labor categories, foreign job opportunities, acquire relevant skills certifications, and then travel abroad to work, utilizing these acquired skills. However, given the evolving circumstances, especially concerning this new category of migrant workers and the potential role of labor migration in supporting Sri Lanka's development, it has become increasingly necessary to conduct additional labor market analyses and skills mapping for foreign job placements.

Diverse factors must be considered when conducting foreign job market analysis, including variations in economic growth, job demand, and wage levels across different countries. This analysis supports the Government to pinpoint regions or countries where Sri Lankans can potentially secure higher salaries or access more promising job prospects. Moreover, it helps individuals identify regions with specific skill shortages or surpluses, enabling them to align their career choices with market demand. Equally important, this analysis assists Governments in establishing focused skills development mechanisms to align with migration trends.

The Safe Labour Migration Project of the International Labour Organization Country Office for Sri Lanka and the Maldives initiated this research study to bridge a knowledge gap in the foreign employment landscape. This study was carried out by the reputable research firm Nielsen IQ Lanka (Pvt) Ltd in close collaboration with the Ministry of Labour & Foreign Employment, Ministry of Foreign Affairs, and the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment (SLBFE).

I extend my thanks to all members of the review committee chaired by the Hon. Minister of Labour & Foreign Employment for their invaluable guidance and feedback during the course of this study. The study's realization was made possible through the generous support extended by the Swiss Agency for Development and Cooperation (SDC). I appreciate the dedicated efforts of the ILO Sri Lanka Safe Labour Migration Programme team for their tireless commitment to bringing this timely study to the public and policy makers. I hope that the findings and recommendations from this research study will serve as a blueprint for shaping a more dignified and rewarding foreign employment labour market for Sri Lankan women and men.

Simrin C. Singh

Director

ILO Country Office for Sri Lanka and the Maldives

► Contents

► Abbreviations	xi
► 1. Introduction	1
► 2. Desk research findings	5
► 3. Qualitative research findings	67
► 4. Country profiles, with recommendations	81
► 5. Recommendations	148
► References	153

► Tables

Table 1	Scoring method	3
Table 2	Sri Lanka-based interviews (component 1)	4
Table 3	International informant interviews (component 2)	4
Table 4	Top-five migrant-sending countries to Saudi Arabia, 2020	7
Table 5	Projected occupational categories of low-skilled or semi-skilled workers in the medium-term demand, up to 2025	8
Table 6	International migrants in the United Arab Emirates, 2010, 2015 and 2020	11
Table 7	No. of international migrants in the United Arab Emirates, 2020	12
Table 8	Percentage distribution of employed non-United Arab Emirati nationals, by main groups of occupations, 2019	12
Table 9	Occupation categories for low-skilled and semi-skilled workers, up to 2025	13
Table 10	Top-five migrant-sending countries to Qatar, 2020	16
Table 11	Projected occupational categories of low-skilled or semi-skilled workers for medium-term demand, up to 2025	18
Table 12	Net migration rate in Kuwait, 2020–23	20
Table 13	Share of international in Kuwait, by origin region, 2020	21
Table 14	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Kuwait, by skill category, 2021	24
Table 15	Top-five migrant-sending countries to the United States, 2020	25
Table 16	Ten-fastest growing occupations and median annual wages in the United States, 2021–31 (US\$)	26
Table 17	International migrants in Oman, by country of citizenship, 2018	28
Table 18	Top-five migrant-sending countries to the United Kingdom, 2020	31
Table 19	The 13 trends with great influence on jobs and skills in the United Kingdom, to 2030	33
Table 20	Top-ten shortage occupations in the United Kingdom, as of June 2023	33
Table 21	International migrants in Germany, by age category, as of mid-2020	35
Table 22	Sectors considered particularly hard hit with skilled labour shortages in Germany, 2021	37
Table 23	Top-five migrant-sending countries to Japan, 2020	39
Table 24	Jobs most in demand in Japan, 2020	41
Table 25	Hard and soft skills most in demand by employers in Japan, 2020	42
Table 26	Top-five migrant-sending countries to Canada, 2020	44

Table 27	Growth sectors and sectors with decline in labour in Canada, 2019–22 (%)	46
Table 28	Top-five industries with increased wages in Canada, 2019 Q1–2022 Q1 (%)	46
Table 29	Net migration rate in Australia, 2020–23	49
Table 30	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Australia, 2021	52
Table 31	Immigrants in France, by country of birth, 2020	53
Table 32	Most-in-demand jobs in France and highly paid jobs, 2023	53
Table 33	Occupations with labour shortages in France, 2023	54
Table 34	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants to Singapore, by skill category, 2021	57
Table 35	Top-five migrant-sending countries to Italy, 2020	58
Table 36	Most difficult-to-fill categories per each education attainment level in Italy, 2022	60
Table 37	Sectors in Italy that could generate high demand for workers with green economy skills	60
Table 38	Net migration rate in the Republic of Korea, 2020–23	63
Table 39	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the Republic of Korea, by gender, 2021	66
Table 40	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the Republic of Korea, by their skill category, 2021	66

► Figures

Figure 1	Criteria for selecting countries with high potential for Sri Lankan migrants	2
Figure 2	Saudi Arabia migrant population, by gender, 2020	5
Figure 3	Saudi Arabia migrant population, by age category, 2020	5
Figure 4	Share of non-Saudi nationals, by occupation	6
Figure 5	Average Saudi and non-Saudi wages, by sector, 2011	6
Figure 6	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Saudi Arabia, 2018, 2019 and 2021	9
Figure 7	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Saudi Arabia, by gender, 2021	10
Figure 8	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Saudi Arabia, by skill category, 2021	10
Figure 9	International migrants in the United Arab Emirates, by age and gender, 2020	11
Figure 10	Top-ten migrant origin countries to the United Arab Emirates, 2020	12
Figure 11	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in United Arab Emirates, by skill category, 2021	15
Figure 12	International migrants in Qatar, by gender, 2020	15
Figure 13	International migrants in Qatar, by age category, 2020	15
Figure 14	Percentage of non-Qatari nationals, by occupation	16
Figure 15	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Qatar, 2021	18
Figure 16	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Qatar, by gender, 2021	19
Figure 17	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Qatar, by skill category, 2021	19
Figure 18	International migrants in Kuwait, by gender, 2020	20
Figure 19	International migrants in Kuwait, by gender and age, 2020	20
Figure 20	Proportions of non-Kuwaiti jobs in the public sector, 2019	22
Figure 21	Qualification mismatch in Kuwait, by nationality and type, 2020	22
Figure 22	International migrants in the United States, by gender, 2020	25
Figure 23	International migrants in the United States, by age category, 2020	25
Figure 24	International migrants in Oman, by age and gender, 2020	27
Figure 25	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Oman, by skill category, 2021	29
Figure 26	International migrants in the United Kingdom, by gender, 2020	30

Figure 27	International migrants in the United Kingdom, by age, 2020	30
Figure 28	Percentage of foreign-born population in the United Kingdom, by occupation, 2011	31
Figure 29	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the United Kingdom, 2018, 2019 and 2021	34
Figure 30	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the United Kingdom, by gender, 2021	35
Figure 31	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the United Kingdom, by skill level, 2021	35
Figure 32	International migrants in Germany, by age and gender, 2020	36
Figure 33	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Germany, by skill level, 2021	38
Figure 34	International migrants in Japan, by gender, 2020	39
Figure 35	International migrants in Japan, by age category, 2020	39
Figure 36	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants to Japan, 2021	42
Figure 37	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants to Japan, by gender, 2021	42
Figure 38	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants to Japan, by skill category, 2021	43
Figure 39	International migrants in Canada, by gender, 2020	43
Figure 40	International migrants in Canada, by age category, 2020	43
Figure 41	Percentage of foreign-born population in Canada, by occupation, 2016	44
Figure 42	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Canada, 2021	47
Figure 43	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Canada, by gender, 2021	47
Figure 44	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants to Canada, by skill category, 2021	48
Figure 45	International migrants in Australia, by gender, 2020	48
Figure 46	International migrant population in Australia, by age and gender, 2020	49
Figure 47	Australian-born population compared with migrants born overseas, 2021	50
Figure 48	Australia's overseas-born population, by top-ten countries of birth, 2021 (thousands)	50
Figure 49	International migrants in France, by age, 2020	52
Figure 50	Foreign workers in Singapore by work permit, 2021	56
Figure 51	International migrants in Italy, by gender, 2020	58
Figure 52	International migrants in Italy, by age category, 2020	58
Figure 53	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Italy, 2021	61

Figure 54	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Italy, by gender, 2021	61
Figure 55	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Italy, by skill category, 2021	61
Figure 56	International migrants in the Republic of Korea, by gender, 2020	62
Figure 57	International migrants in the Republic of Korea, by age category, 2020	62
Figure 58	Number of migrants living in the Republic of Korea, by country of origin, 2021	63
Figure 59	Profile of aspiring and returned migrants interviewed in the study	67
Figure 60	Primary reasons for deciding to seek overseas employment opportunities (all categories including, professional, skilled and semi-skilled)	68
Figure 61	Preferred countries for foreign employment, as described by aspiring migrants	69
Figure 62	Process of job selection through a local foreign employment agent	73
Figure 63	Process of direct application for foreign employment opportunity	74
Figure 64	Process of direct application for skilled migration to Australia and New Zealand	74
Figure 65	Process of matching the qualifications, skills and work experience during the recruitment process	75

► Abbreviations

ICT	information and communication technology
IELTS	International English Language Testing System
ILO	International Labor Organization
MOU	memorandum of understanding
NVQ	National Vocational Qualification
OECD	Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development
TVET	technical and vocational education and training
UN DESA	United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs

► 1. Introduction

The International Labor Organization (ILO) in Sri Lanka is “promoting decent work through good governance, protection and empowerment of migrant workers: contributing towards the effective implementation of the Sri Lanka National Labour Migration Policy” under the Safe Labour Migration Project. The project’s fourth phase is structured around three objectives, the third of which is: “policymakers, public officials and other stakeholders are provided with an evidence base for their informed participation in policy, dialogue and action on labour migration”.

In line with the findings of the desk research conducted under the third objective, a research study on labour market supply and demand for Sri Lankan migrant workers was commissioned. This document presents those findings.

Study objectives

The researchers were asked to look in depth at the following issues and to map out the supply and demand for skills and labour and highlight the gaps and opportunities that would allow them to make recommendations for improving the foreign employment options for women and men seeking to migrate out of Sri Lanka.

1. The current mid-term and long-term labour demand in countries of the Gulf Cooperation Council, the Middle East, Europe, North America and South and South-East Asia for women and men migrant workers.
2. The similarities and overlap in labour demand across the different migration corridors.
3. The current labour supply in Sri Lanka, including profiles of aspiring women and men migrant workers, their skills and qualifications and the available skills training and qualifications facilities in Sri Lanka.

These objectives were further broken down into the following research questions.

Labor market demand

- What are the immediate, medium-term and long-term labour market demands in the Middle East, Europe and South and South-East Asia for women and men migrant workers from Sri Lanka?
- What are the labour and employment sectors that are most in demand and for most countries and regions in the immediate, medium and long term, disaggregated according to gender, skill category and earning potential?
- What are the employment and recruitment pathways (processes) for the in-demand labour sectors?
- What are the labour and employment sectors in countries and regions of destination that best align with the national economic and development strategies in Sri Lanka (with a view to the sustainable reintegration of migrant workers)?

Labor market supply

- What is the profile of aspiring migrant workers from Sri Lanka, disaggregated by age, gender and skill category?
- What are the existing expertise and skills within this population of aspiring women and men migrant workers?
- What are the qualification and certification opportunities available to aspiring women and men migrant workers, including the time and cost implications of completing additional certifications?

Skills mapping

- Are the existing populations of aspiring women and men migrant workers sufficiently qualified or certified to meet the requirements of the in-demand foreign employment labour sectors? If not, how could they be improved?

- Do the existing qualifications and certification opportunities available in Sri Lanka sufficiently cater to the requirements of the in-demand foreign employment sectors? What are the gaps and how could they be addressed?
- Are the existing qualifications and certification opportunities in Sri Lanka adequately recognized in the targeted countries and regions of destination by potential employers and do they result in sufficient wage increases?
- What are the areas that the Government of Sri Lanka should focus on for investment, particularly regarding skills training and certifications that would result in improved employment opportunities for migrant workers?

The overarching objective of the research study was to identify and map the demand for migrant workers in destination countries and the supply from Sri Lanka. After further discussions with the Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment, it was decided that the research would give more emphasis to identifying demand and then mapping the current supply against it, as opposed to more emphasis on supply. This was with the expectation that the Ministry would use the findings of this research to develop and implement the short-term and long-term policies and actions to equip Sri Lankan migrant workers to meet the demand of global

migrant worker market and take the necessary steps to facilitate labour migration that would be conducive to the country's further development. It was also emphasized that exploration of migration corridors that are not in the current radar for Sri Lanka is also needed.

Research methods

The study comprised:

- desk research;
- local qualitative data collection; and
- international data collection.

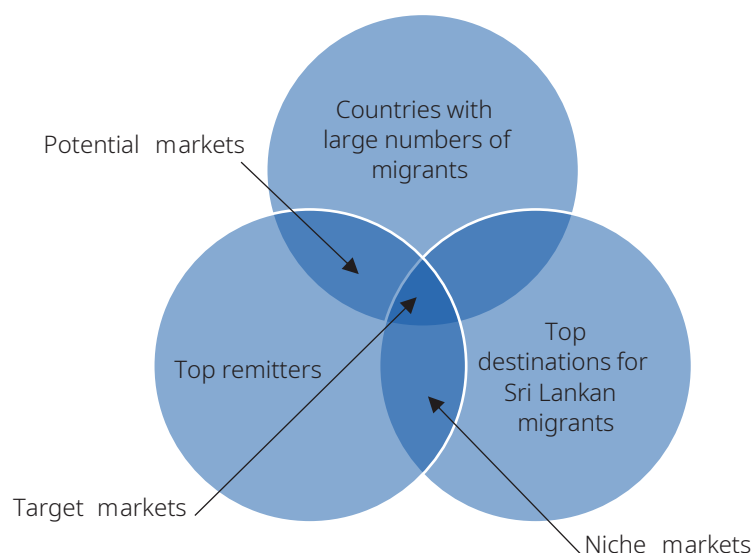
Desk research methodology

The desk research was used to identify current trends in the global foreign labour market. With that information, 15 countries emerged as having the most potential as migrant labour destinations that would serve Sri Lanka's development interests. Three criteria were used:

- current migrant population;
- remittance outflow; and
- migrant outflow from Sri Lanka based on Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment data.

Figure 1 illustrates the categories used to arrive at the top 15 countries with high potential for Sri Lankan migrants.

Figure 1. Criteria for selecting countries with high potential for Sri Lankan migrants



The countries were ranked using the following scoring method (table 1) for each category.

Table 1. Scoring method

Criteria	Weight		
	Target markets	Niche markets	Potential markets
Migrant population	0.3		0.3
Top remitters (world)	0.4		0.4
Top remitters (to Sri Lanka)	0.2	0.2	
Migrant outward flow (from the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment)	0.1	0.1	

The top countries identified under these categories as per the scoring system:

Target markets	Potential markets	Niche markets
Saudi Arabia	United States	Saudi Arabia
United Arab Emirates	Saudi Arabia	Qatar
United States	Germany	United Arab Emirates
Germany	United Arab Emirates	Kuwait
United Kingdom	United Kingdom	Oman
Canada	Russian Federation	Republic of Korea
France	Canada	Bahrain
Australia	France	Japan
Kuwait	Spain	Singapore
Italy	Australia	Jordan

The countries were then compiled, with the following top 15 countries singled out for analysis in this report.

1. Saudi Arabia
2. United Arab Emirates
3. United States
4. Germany
5. United Kingdom
6. Canada
7. France
8. Australia
9. Kuwait
10. Italy
11. Qatar
12. Japan

13. Oman
14. Singapore
15. Republic of Korea

Qualitative research methodology

The qualitative methodology was designed to identify destination countries and sectors that would be of good potential for the near- and long-term future for skilled and professional migrant workers. It was intended to understand the current demand and supply of labour in the foreign employment market and to determine the prevailing gaps through the exploratory qualitative research. The main objective was to identify new opportunities for labour migration. In-depth interviews with migrants and officials in Sri Lanka and in destination countries were conducted to gather qualitative research requirements.

Target group for interviews

The target group for the research study comprised a cross-section of the following:

1. Aspiring migrant workers, returned migrant workers and recent graduates of the National Vocational Qualification (NVQ) technical and vocational education and training (TVET);
2. Officials representing local foreign employment agencies and the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment;
3. Officials of Sri Lankan Missions in destination countries (labour welfare officers and trade counsellors and commercial officers); and

4. Officials representing foreign employment agencies in selected countries.

Local data collection

The primary data collection in the local context was carried out through in-depth interviews with the segments of aspiring and returned migrants and TVET-qualified students. The informant interviews were conducted with officials working on labour migration sector.

A total of 39 persons were interviewed in the local data collection (table 2), with ten persons per segment. These in-depth interviews were conducted through the Nielsen IQ online platform.

Table 2. Sri Lanka-based interviews (component 1)

Target group	Informant interviews
Aspiring migrants	10
Returned migrants	10
TVET graduates	10
Local foreign employment agencies and Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment	9
Total	39

Informants from skilled and professional categories were selected for the aspiring and returned migrant categories. In the TVET-graduate informant interviews, persons who had obtained a NVQ level 6 were considered. Two officials from the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, one representative of the Association of Local Foreign Employment Agencies and six representatives of local foreign employment agencies were interviewed.

International data collection

The second component involved collecting data from 30 informants in destination countries (table

3). The segments of informants representing ten of the 15 countries with promising potential were selected and interviewed through the Nielsen IQ online platform. The international data collection was carried out with officials of Sri Lanka foreign missions; labour relations officers and commercial or trade officers (table 3). These segments were covered to assess the demand side for Sri Lankan skilled and professional migrants. Even though it was planned to interview ten representatives from overseas employment agencies, these agencies did not agree to participate in direct interviews. Instead, they provided weblinks to the required information.

Table 3. International informant interviews (component 2)

Target group	Informant interviews
Commercial or trade officers	11
Labour relations officers	11
Total	22

► 2. Desk research findings

The 15 countries highlighted in this report are based on the three-criteria scoring that was determined through the desk research, as follows.

1. Saudi Arabia

a. Migrant population in Saudi Arabia

In the scoring system adopted for this study, Saudi Arabia placed in the top-five countries in all three criteria: global migrant population, remittances to Sri Lanka and popular destination country for migrants from Sri Lanka. Overall, Saudi Arabia led the top-15 countries.

Of the global migrant population in 2020 (figures 2 and 3), 38.4 per cent, or 13,454,842 migrants, were in Saudi Arabia (9,235,130 men and 4,219,712 women).

Figure 2. Saudi Arabia migrant population, by gender, 2020

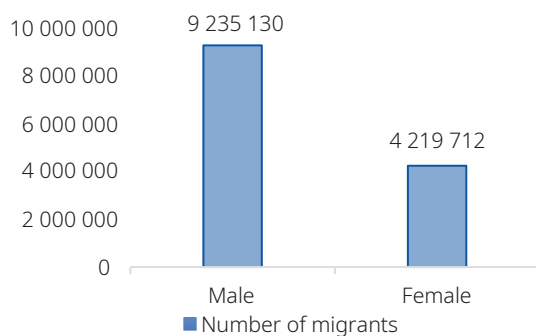
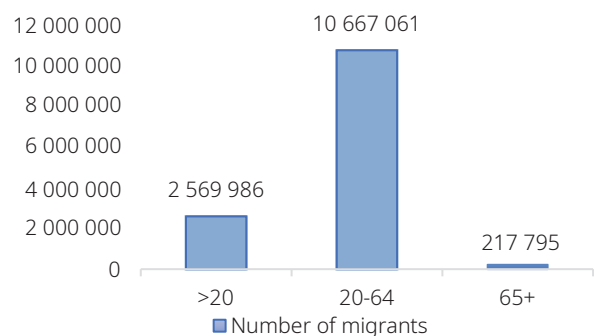


Figure 3. Saudi Arabia migrant population, by age category, 2020

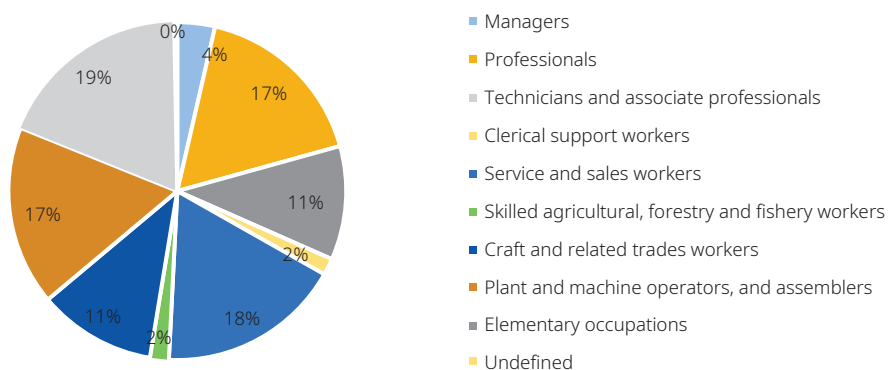


Source: UN DESA, Population Division, “International Migration Stock 2020”.

According to the 2022 labour market survey statistics for Saudi Arabia, 74.5 per cent of non-Saudi nationals were in the labour force. Among the employed non-Saudi nationals, nearly 50 per cent had a bachelor’s degree or equivalent qualification

or had qualified with an upper-secondary education. The main groups of occupation were service and sales workers. Employed professionals accounted for the second-largest portion (figure 4).

Figure 4. Share of non-Saudi nationals, by occupation

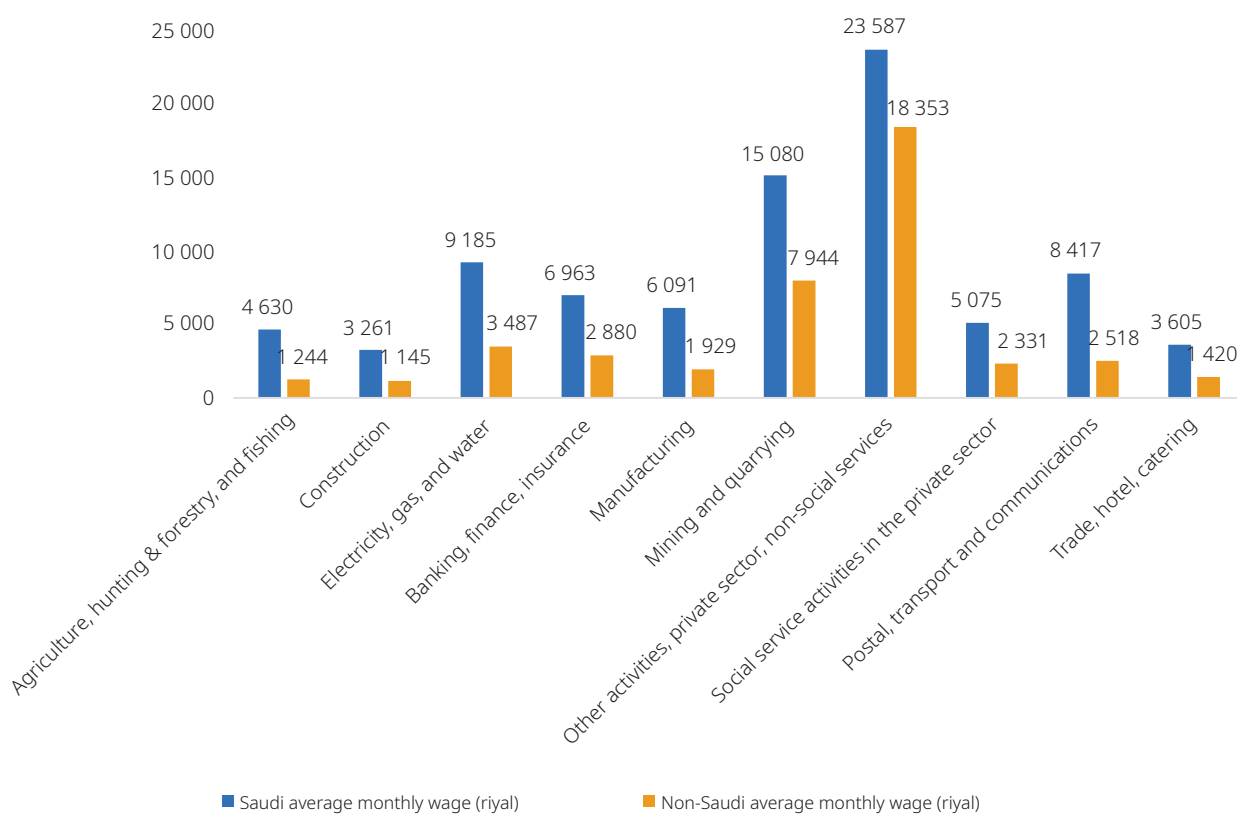


Source: Labour market statistics of Saudi Arabia, 2022 fourth quarter, General Authority for Statistics.

Wage levels between Saudi nationals and non-Saudi nationals vary considerably (figure 5). The data, albeit more than a decade old, suggest that nationalization of the labour market may rely on high labour costs. Thus, in the long term, it may

lead to a diminishing number of migrant workers in productive labour, while it may lead to a high demand for foreign workers with low skills in the short to medium term.

Figure 5. Average Saudi and non-Saudi wages, by sector, 2011



Source: ILO, Labour Market Trends Analysis and Labor Migration from South Asia to Gulf Cooperation Council Countries, India and Malaysia, 2015.

The literature points out that non-Saudi nationals make up a majority of the workforce in the private sector and predicts this trend to continue. According to the Central Department for Statistics and Information, foreign labour in 2011 (latest available data) accounted for 89.1 per cent of the private sector workforce.¹

According to the *World Migration Report 2022*, Saudi Arabia was the third-largest destination country for international migrants. In 2020, the top-five countries of migrant origin (in Saudi Arabia) were India (by far, at more than 2.5 million persons), Indonesia, Pakistan, Bangladesh and Egypt (table 4).

Table 4. Top-five migrant-sending countries to Saudi Arabia, 2020

Country	Migrant population
India	2 502 337
Indonesia	1 709 318
Pakistan	1 483 737
Bangladesh	1 277 624
Egypt	962 432

Source: IOM, *World Migration Report 2022*, 2022.

b. Migration policy in Saudi Arabia²

In general, Saudi Arabia facilitates migrant recruitment through South and South-East Asia and Africa.

The controversial *kafala* system is the main method for sponsoring migrant workers in Saudi Arabia.³ It provides the legal framework for relationships between employees and employers in most of the Gulf corridor countries, including Saudi Arabia. The literature is full of documentation on how this system creates labour exploitation, poor working conditions and discrimination by targeting cheap labour from other countries to support the emerging economies of the Gulf region.

The *kafala* system has been subjected to several reforms. With effect as of June 2021, it was reformed to allow migrant employees the freedom to change their job without their previous employer's permission and it gives foreign workers the right to leave the country without their employer's

permission. The reforms aimed to improve Saudi Arabia's labour market attractiveness, especially after heightened media and activists' attention on human rights abuses among the migrant population. For instance, when recruiting domestic workers and low-skilled labour in small numbers, recruiting agencies now act as sponsors. For the mega recruitment agencies that hire low- or semi-skilled workers in large numbers for manufacturing plants or construction companies, it is difficult to act as the sponsor. The *kafala* system remains important and practised.

The literature also stresses that these reforms have been significant steps to improve the migrant labour conditions and enhance labour market attractiveness, but they have not abolished the traditional system or unfair and inhuman treatment of migrants.

The Government of Saudi Arabia signed a memorandum of understanding (MOU) with India in 2014 regarding domestic workers that specifies

¹ GIZ and ILO, *Labour Market Trends Analysis and Labour Migration from South Asia to Gulf Cooperation Council Countries, India and Malaysia*, 2015.

² Source of information for this section: see Council on Foreign Relations, "Al Jazeera, "Saudi Arabia announces changes to Kafala system, 14 March 2021; and GIZ and ILO, *Labour Market Trends Analysis and Labour Migration from South Asia to Gulf Cooperation Council Countries, India and Malaysia*, 2015.

³ Each foreign employee who enters the country must have a sponsorship from an employer. This sponsor can be an individual or a company. In this system, every employee is tied to their sponsor (called *kafeel*) for a specific contract period, and the employees are not allowed to change their job or change the destination country without the consent of their sponsor (employer).

their protection during the recruitment process, prior to departure, in the content of contracts with employers and through the provision of salaries.

Another main policy implication is the Nitaqat Law, which the Ministry of Labour introduced in 2011 to specify a system of categorization of firms by their main economic activity and size and sets targets based on the ratio of national and foreign workers. This practice, however, has led to the “Saudization” of the workforce, whereby nationals receive more opportunities. Although introduced as a long-term plan, the literature reveals that in the foreseeable future, Saudi Arabia will continue to depend on foreign labour, especially in the labour-intensive sectors. Rapidly changing labour policies, revenue from oil and the expansion or merging of recruitment and migration institutions in origin and destination countries are creating many migrant-related uncertainties.

c. Current and upcoming labour demand trend in Saudi Arabia

As with other Gulf Cooperation Council countries, Saudi Arabia has been targeting economic diversification. Instead of depending on oil and gas revenues, the Government is looking to expand the economy in terms of trading, hospitality,

human services and construction to create more employment opportunities for both nationals and foreigners.

In line with the Gulf Cooperation Council objective to create a knowledge-based economy, Saudi Arabia seeks more skilled and productive labour than low-skilled labour, which should reduce the recruitment costs. Skilled and vocationally qualified labourers are preferred in the emerging sectors, such as automobile manufacturing and the green construction and production process. However, as stressed in the literature, the foreseeable migrant labour demand response will be led by the demand for low-skilled labour.

The manufacturing and wholesale and retail trade sectors are also considered as growing sectors that may create more opportunities for low- and semi-skilled workers. The automobile manufacturing and green construction (advanced water treatment systems and solar panel projects) sectors may require high-skilled or specific technical and vocationally skilled labourers.

Saudi Arabia has an initiative to shift from individual sponsorships to large-scale recruitment agencies. Table 5 depicts the projected occupational categories for low- and semi-skilled workers in the medium-term demand in Gulf Cooperation Council countries.

Table 5. Projected occupational categories of low-skilled or semi-skilled workers in the medium-term demand, up to 2025

Construction and maintenance of buildings	Sales and services	Domestic work	Education and health
• Construction supervisor or foreperson • Construction worker • Welder • Plumber • Electrician • Air-conditioning technician • Tiler • Mason • Carpenter • Crane operator • Maintenance engineer • Civil engineer	• Driver • Cook • Waiter • Other hotel service staff • Cleaning labour • Private service • Security guard • Gardner • Foreperson	• Domestic worker • Housekeeper	• Nurse • Paramedic • Teacher

Source: GIZ and ILO, *Labour Market Trends Analysis and Labor Migration from South Asia to Gulf Cooperation Council Countries, India and Malaysia*, 2015.

The share of migrant workers who are women is considerably small in all sectors in Saudi Arabia except households (domestic workers). But trend forecasts indicate that increasingly female labour will be required within the country's economic expansion, and there will be high demand for women with low-skill or semi-skill levels. And when more national women take up employment, there will be increased demand for domestic workers from foreign countries as well as other Gulf Cooperation Council countries.

Saudi Arabia's ambitious construction endeavors in the planned NEOM region, encompassing projects like THE LINE, Trojena, Sindalah, Oxagon, and more, are aligned with their 2030 vision. They have expressed a need for Sri Lankan workers in engineering categories, quantity surveyors, and

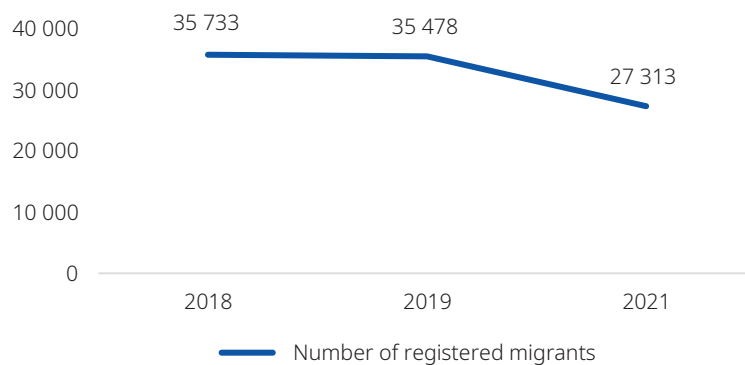
architects to contribute to these projects. This presents promising opportunities for Sri Lankans.

d. Migration to Saudi Arabia from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, 27,313 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in Saudi Arabia in 2021, with the largest portion in semi-skill jobs. This was a decrease from the 35,733 migrants in 2018 and 35,478 migrants in 2019, although Saudi Arabia was among the top-three labour destinations for Sri Lankans for all three years (figures 6 and 8).

Among the total registered migrants in 2021, more than 60 per cent were men, with only 1 per cent women (figure 7). The other portion (nearly 30 per cent) did not define their gender in the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics.

Figure 6. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Saudi Arabia, 2018, 2019 and 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

Figure 7. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Saudi Arabia, by gender, 2021

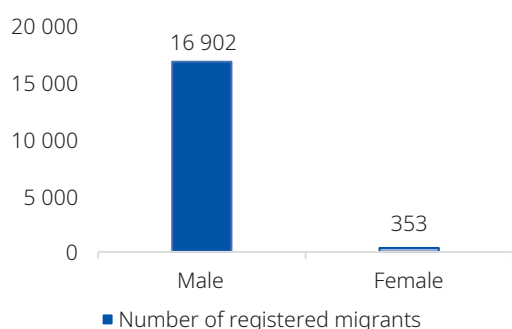
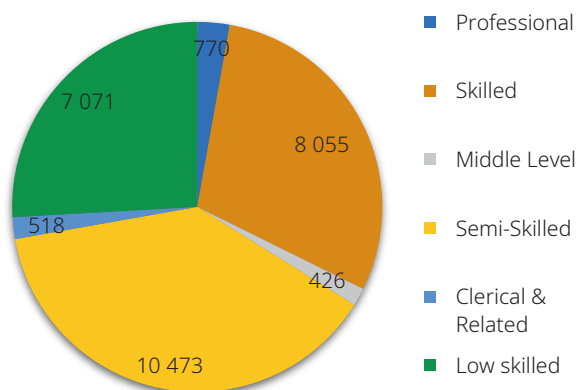


Figure 8. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Saudi Arabia, by skill category, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

The Middle East was the top region for remittances to Sri Lanka from 2016 to 2021.⁴ According to the bilateral remittance matrix, Saudi Arabia reported the largest volume of remittances in 2021 (latest available data) among all other countries, at US\$1,476 million.⁵

Saudi Arabia has invited Sri Lankans to apply for 207,883 vacancies in 482 occupation types. According to the latest Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment data, 168,383 vacancies remain available.⁶

2. United Arab Emirates

a. Migrant population in the United Arab Emirates

According to the *World Migration Report 2022*, the United Arab Emirates is the sixth-largest destination country for international migrants.

In the scoring system for this study, the United Arab Emirates placed seventh among the top remitters to Sri Lanka and third among destination countries for Sri Lankan migrant workers. After evaluation of the study's criteria, the United Arab Emirates ranked second of countries with potential for Sri Lankan semi-skilled and professional migrant workers.

As of July 2020, there were 8,716,332 international migrants in the country, accounting for 88 per cent of the total resident population – nationals numbered 570,957, making them a minority in their own country (table 6). The United Arab Emirates thus has the largest number of migrants in relation to population. Of the foreign migrants in the country in 2020, 6,419,792 (73.7 per cent) were men and 2,296,540 (26.4 per cent) were women, at a ratio of almost 3:1 (figure 9).

⁴ SLBFE, "Annual Statistics of Foreign Employment 2021", 2021.

⁵ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

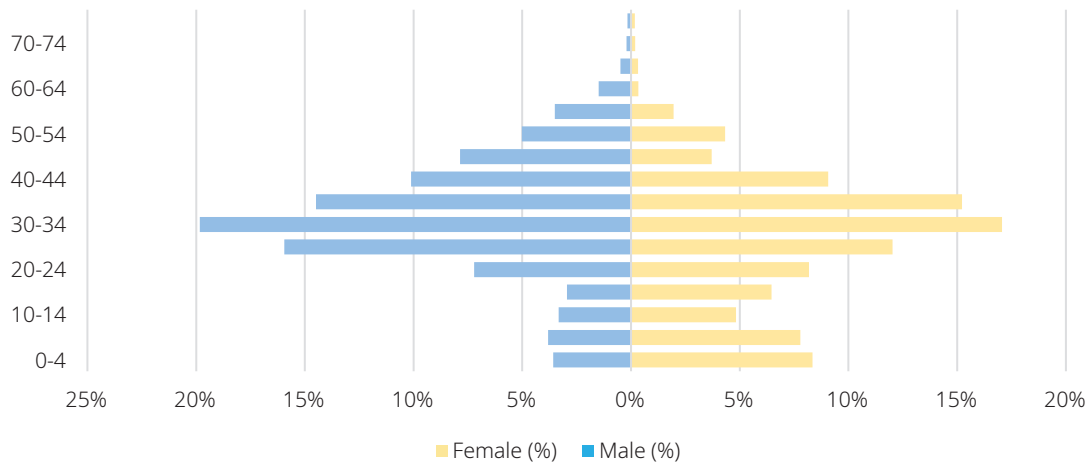
⁶ SLBFE, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

Table 6. International migrants in the United Arab Emirates, 2010, 2015 and 2020

Year	Total migrants	Migrants (male)	Migrants (female)	Migrants (male) %	Migrants (female) %	Total United Arab Emirates population	Migrant %
2010	7 316 697	5 463 446	1 853 251	74.67	25.33	8 549 998	85.58
2015	7 995 125	5 890 170	2 104 956	73.67	26.33	9 262 896	86.31
2020	8 716 332	6 419 792	2 296 540	73.65	26.35	9 890 400	88.13

Source: Dubai Online, UAE Population 2022 – Total, Nationality, Migrants, Gender.

Figure 9. International migrants in the United Arab Emirates, by age and sex, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International Migration Stock 2020".

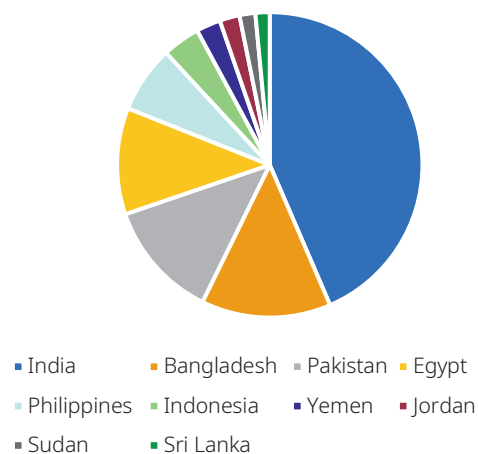
The net migration rate for the United Arab Emirates in 2023 is 0.433 per 1,000 population, which is a 63.4 per cent decline from 2022, when it was 1.182 per 1,000 population. And that year was a 38.8 per cent decline from 2021, when it was 1.931 per 1,000 population, which was a 27.9 per cent decline from 2020. (Uae Net Migration Rate 1950-2023 n.d.)

The biggest expatriate group in the United Arab Emirates is Indian (table 7 and figure 10), at nearly

40 per cent. Other large groups in the expatriate population are Bangladeshis, Pakistanis, Egyptians, Filipinos, Indonesians, Yemenis, Jordanians, Sudanese and Sri Lankans (with Kuwaitis, Palestinians, Syrians, Lebanese and Nepalis represented in smaller numbers). Egyptians are the largest group from Africa. British nationals are the largest group from Europe. According to the data, Sri Lankans rank tenth.

Table 7. No. of international migrants in the United Arab Emirates, 2020

Country	No. of migrants	%
India	3 471 300	39.83
Bangladesh	1 095 231	12.57
Pakistan	996 288	11.43
Egypt	899 612	10.32
Philippines	564 769	6.48
Indonesia	318 809	3.66
Yemen	205 618	2.36
Jordan	168 968	1.94
Sudan	133 226	1.53
Sri Lanka	120 491	1.38

Figure 10. Top-ten migrant origin countries to the United Arab Emirates, 2020

Source: "UAE Population 2022 – Total, Nationality, Migrants, Gender".

Table 8 illustrates the percentage distribution of employed non-United Arab Emirati nationals by main groups of occupations.

Table 8. Percentage distribution of employed non-United Arab Emirati nationals, by main groups of occupations, 2019

Occupation	Non-United Arab Emirates		
	Male	Female	Total
Managers	9.8	8.3	9.4
Professionals	13.8	20.2	15.3
Technicians and associate professionals	11.2	8.6	10.6
Clerical support workers	3.7	6.5	4.4
Service and sales workers	14.9	13.9	14.7
Skilled agricultural, forestry and fishery workers	1.2	...	0.9
Craft and related trades workers	19.2	0.2	14.7
Plant and machine operators and assemblers	12.2	0.3	9.4
Elementary occupations	13.8	41.7	20.4
Not stated	0.1	0.2	0.1
Total	100	100	100

Source: See uaestat.fcsc.gov.ae, 2019 data.

b. Migration policy in the United Arab Emirates

The five-year Green visa enables foreigners to sponsor themselves without assistance from United Arab Emirates citizens or employers under the country's new immigration policies. This visa is open to independent contractors, skilled employees and investors. Persons with a Green visa can sponsor their own family members. A Green visa holder has up to six months to renew their work permit when it expires.

The Golden visa offers a ten-year extended residency option. Golden visas are available to investors, business owners and people with "remarkable talent", such as professionals, sports stars, students and humanitarian pioneers.⁸ Holders of a golden visa may also sponsor their children and relatives. If the holder of a golden visa dies, their family members may continue to reside in the United Arab Emirates as long as the visa is still in effect. The benefits of having a 100 per cent ownership of a business is also provided to holders of Golden visas under the new immigration regulations.

c. Migration trends in the United Arab Emirates

The labour demand for migrant workers in the construction sector is expected to increase in 2023 and in the coming years due to several mega infrastructure projects ongoing (33 currently) and planned. These projects require low- and semi-skilled labourers (table 9). Due to the country's infrastructure development, the tourism and care sectors have developed and are expected to generate job opportunities.

According to the 2015 ILO report *Labour Market Trends Analysis and Labour Migration from South Asia to Gulf Cooperation Council Countries, India and Malaysia*, the United Arab Emirates is expected to engage in sustained large-scale construction activities over the next 15 years, during which time the population of the urban centres will double. Sectors at the centre of this strategy are construction, real estate, tourism and hospitality, manufacturing, logistics, education and health care, with significant expected demand for workers at all levels.

Table 9. Occupation categories for low-skilled and semi-skilled workers, up to 2025

Construction and maintenance of buildings	Sales and services	Domestic work	Education and health
Construction supervisor or foreperson	Driver	Domestic worker	Nurse
Construction worker	Cook	Housekeeper	Paramedic
Welder	Waiter		Teacher
Plumber	Other hotel service staff		
Electrician	Cleaner		
Air-conditioning technician	Private service		
Tiler	Security guard		
Mason	Gardner		
Carpenter	Foreperson		
Crane operator			
Maintenance engineer			
Civil engineer			

Source: ILO, *Labour Market Trends Analysis and Labor Migration from South Asia to Gulf Cooperation Council Countries, India and Malaysia*, 2015.

8 "Everything You Need to Know About the Golden Visa UAE", n.d.

The United Arab Emirates has initiated reform of the controversial kafala system that gives employers inordinate control over migrant workers and severely limits workers' human and labour rights. Under the 2020 reforms, the Government defined minimum labour standards, introduced paid holidays, limited working hours and prohibited child labour. The changes have eased some of the contractual limitations for migrants, including domestic workers.

Recruiting agencies have an increasingly important role in recruitment, training and workforce management. By leveraging online job boards, social media and other digital tools, these agencies are reaching a wider pool of candidates and streamlining the recruitment process. There is a growing trend of mega-sized agencies.

The Government announced a long-term plan for the transformation of the Emirate's economy, focusing on knowledge-based industries. Entitled Abu Dhabi Economic Vision 2030, the plan identifies the following immediate economic priorities:⁹

1. Building an open, efficient, effective and globally integrated business environment.
2. Adopting a disciplined fiscal policy that is responsive to economic cycles.
3. Establishing a resilient monetary and financial market environment with manageable levels of inflation.
4. Driving significant improvement in the efficiency of the labour market.
5. Developing a sufficient and resilient infrastructure capable of supporting the anticipated economic growth.
6. Developing a highly skilled, highly productive workforce.
7. Enabling financial markets to become the financiers of the economic sectors and projects.

The strategy contains three sectors and five pillars.

Three sectors:

- construction;
- medical products; and
- consumer products.

Five pillars:

- infrastructure;
- legislative structure;
- funding;
- talent; and
- market demand.

The country made history when women were hired as public bus drivers.¹⁰ Demand for qualified women migrant workers typically spans job categories of sales rep, yoga instructor, nurse, special education teacher, paralegal, media agent, administration assistant, waitress, receptionist and call centre agent.

The majority of Emiratis who work do so in public sector jobs. Foreign low-skilled workers are sought for private sector jobs that offer low wages.

d. Migration to the United Arab Emirates from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, 20,185 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in the United Arab Emirates in 2021. This was a decline from the 32,821 migrants in 2018 and the 32,860 migrants in 2019. The United Arab Emirates was among the top-five destinations for Sri Lankans for all three years.¹¹

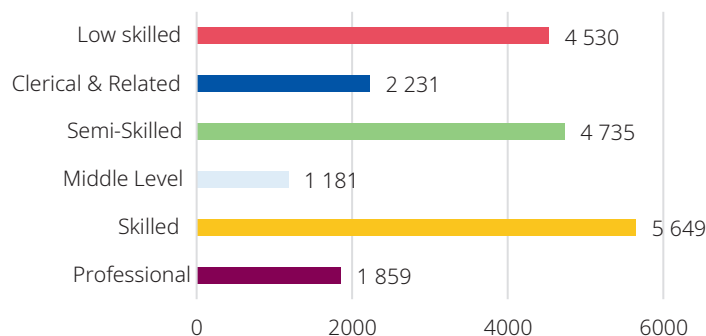
Among the total registered Sri Lankan migrants in 2021, more than 59 per cent were men, leaving women to account for 41 per cent (figure 11).

⁹ See The Abu Dhabi, Economic Vision 2030, 2008.

¹⁰ *Filipino Times*, "Dubai Hires First Women Bus Drivers in Middle East", 15 July 2020.

¹¹ Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

Figure 11. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in United Arab Emirates, by skill category, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

As previously noted, the Middle East was the top region for generating remittances to Sri Lanka from 2016 to 2021. According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, the United Arab Emirates reported \$356 million in remittances to Sri Lanka in 2021.¹²

The United Arab Emirates has offered 76,080 vacancies in 386 occupation types to Sri Lankan workers. According to the latest available data with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, only 4,921 vacancies have been filled.¹³

3. Qatar

a. Migrant population in Qatar

Qatar ranked third in the scoring system used for this study, emphasizing its importance as a labour market that Sri Lanka could gain by using novel and customized approaches for orderly migration. According to the three scoring criteria, Qatar is in the top-five countries for remittances to Sri Lanka

and has received the most Sri Lankan migrants over the past few years.

The total migrant population in Qatar in 2020 numbered 2,226,192 persons (figures 12 and 13).

Figure 12. International migrants in Qatar, by gender, 2020

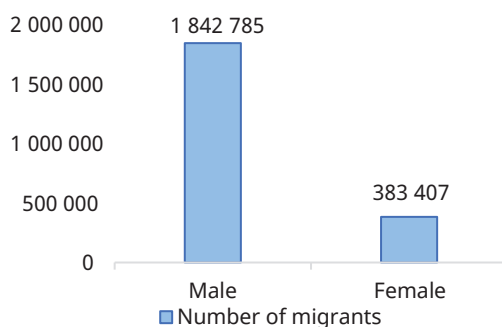
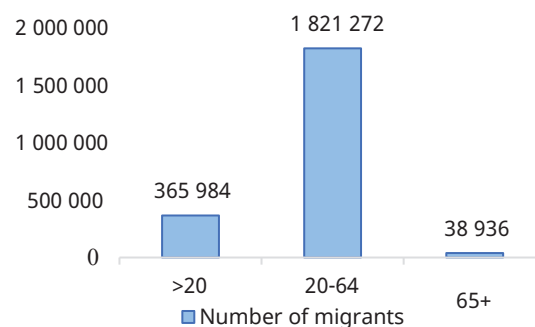


Figure 13. International migrants in Qatar, by age category, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International Migration Stock 2020".

¹² KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

¹³ SLBFE, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

According to data from the International Organization for Migration, the top-five migrant-sending countries to Qatar in 2020 (latest available data) were India (by far), Bangladesh, Nepal, Pakistan and Egypt (table 10).

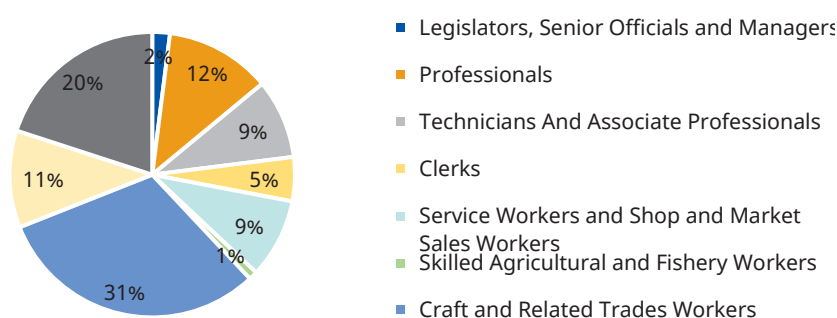
Table 10. Top-five migrant-sending countries to Qatar, 2020

Country	Migrant population
India	702 013
Bangladesh	261 672
Nepal	253 940
Pakistan	235 505
Egypt	183 544

Source: IOM, *World Migration Report 2022*, 2022.

As illustrated in Qatar's 2020 census data (figure 14), the largest portion of non-Qatari citizens were employed as craft and related trades workers. Among them, a large portion had a secondary or post-secondary education attainment.

Figure 14. Percentage of non-Qatari nationals, by occupation



Source: Planning and Statistics Authority-State of Qatar, "General Population, Housing and Establishment Census 2020.

The non-Qatari workers with a university level of education were largely employed as professionals, technicians and associate professionals and craft and related trades workers (General population, Housing and establishment Census 2020 2020). Additionally, non-Qatari workers accounted for 99 per cent of the labour market in the private sector in 2012.¹⁴

b. Migration policy in Qatar¹⁵

Generally, issuance of temporary work permits and work visas or job recruitment are guided by the kafala system. Each foreign employee who enters the country must have a sponsorship from an employer. This sponsor can be an individual or a company. In this system, every employee is tied to

¹⁴ GIZ and ILO, *Labour Market Trends Analysis and Labour Migration from South Asia to Gulf Cooperation Council Countries, India and Malaysia*, 2015.

¹⁵ Source of information for this section: see Qatar Labour Law and Immigration: Recent Reforms, 18 January 2021; GIZ and ILO, *Labour Market Trends Analysis and Labor Migration from South Asia to Gulf Cooperation Council Countries, India and Malaysia*, 2015.

their sponsor (called kafeel) for a specific contract period, and the employees are not allowed to change their job or change the destination country without the consent of their sponsor (employer). Some studies in Qatar have revealed that some sponsors exert excess control of their employees in an illegal way by keeping their personal documents, such as passport and other travel papers. Mostly low-skilled workers have been affected by this situation, and they experience labour exploitation and abuse at the hand of their employer. Higher-skilled workers are less affected by this system because they cannot be replaced easily.

The kafala system has been heavily criticized internationally. It has demotivated migrant labourers to seek out Gulf Cooperation Council countries, especially low-skilled workers from Asia. Reforms have been encouraged.

A new employment law ushered in reforms in 2020 in terms of employment contracts, the minimum wage and the kafala system. The reforms also required that the termination of probationary workers be given a minimum of one month notice (from the previous minimum of three days' notice); and the termination notice for outside of probation must be given one month for workers in their first two years of employment and two months for workers with longer employment. Violations require employers to pay compensation equivalent to the worker's basic wage for the notice period or the remaining part of the notice period.

In case of redundancy, employers must submit a detailed statement with reasons for the termination, the number of workers and categories and the period when the termination will take effect. This must be submitted to the Ministry of Administrative Development, Labour and Social Affairs at least 15 days prior to the termination.

As per the new national minimum wage law, the basic salary was revised to 1,000 Qatari riyal per month, as of March 2021.

The kafala system reform allows foreign workers to move between employers without consent of the previous employer. This means they are not required to obtain a no-objection certificate to move to a new employer. And they no longer need an exit permit to take up a new job in another country. Most importantly, the reform imposes a penalty for employers who violate the new labour law.

The Government has signed labour-related MOUs with several South Asian countries – Bangladesh (1988, 2008), Nepal (2005, 2009), Pakistan (1978, 2008) and India (1985, 2007) – that focus on the protection of migrant workers during recruitment, prior to departure, the content of contracts and salaries or wages.

c. Labour demand and trends in Qatar

The current trend in most Gulf Cooperation Council countries is to reduce dependency on oil and gas and diversify their economies in such “novel” (new or non-traditional) sectors as construction, agriculture, hospitality and manufacturing. Qatar is on a path to diversify its economy and create more job opportunities.

Qatar's successful bid to host the 2022 World Cup was supported by its plans for developing large-scale infrastructure projects, such as a metro system, a light rail system, a new port, roads, stadiums and related sporting infrastructure. The Government recognizes that these large-scale infrastructure projects have led to increased job opportunities in the medium term and, in the long term, they may lead to an indirect creation of job opportunities in tourism, hospitality, cleaning, security services and other sectors. As highlighted in the literature, these infrastructure development projects may require low- and medium-skilled labour until around 2025 (table 12).

Table 11. Projected occupational categories of low-skilled or semi-skilled workers for medium-term demand, up to 2025

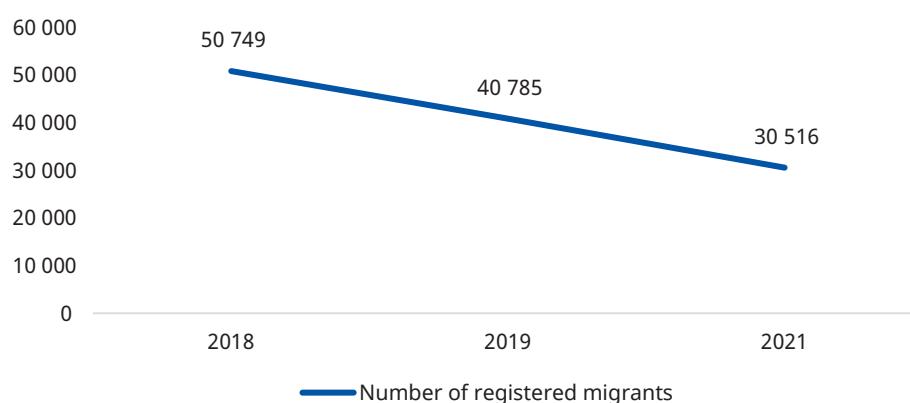
Construction and maintenance of buildings	Sales and services	Domestic work	Education and health
• Construction supervisor or foreperson • Construction worker • Welder • Plumber • Electrician • Air-conditioning technician • Tiler • Mason • Carpenter • Crane operator • Maintenance engineer • Civil engineer	• Driver • Cook • Waiter • Other hotel service staff • Cleaner • Private service • Security guard • Gardner • Foreperson	• Domestic worker • Housekeeper	• Nurse • Paramedic • Teacher

Source: GIZ and ILO, *Labour Market Trends Analysis and Labor Migration from South Asia to Gulf Cooperation Council Countries, India and Malaysia*, 2015.

The female migrant worker share is considerably small in all sectors except households with employed persons. However, the future trend forecast sees more demand for women workers for the country's economic expansion, with high demand for women with low- and middle-skill levels. When more Qatari women seek employment, there will be demand for domestic workers from foreign countries.

d. Migration to Qatar from Sri Lanka

According to Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment data, 30,516 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in Qatar in 2021, which was the largest number among all countries. But it also represented a decline: In 2018, there were 50,749 registered migrants and 40,785 in 2019 in Qatar, even though the country was in the top-three destinations for Sri Lankan migrants in those three years (figure 15).

Figure 15. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Qatar, 2021

Note: 2020 is excluded due to the COVID-19 pandemic affecting migration.

Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

Among the total registered migrants in 2021, 28,621 were men and 1,042 were women (figure 16). The largest portion of Sri Lankans in Qatar were in jobs in the skilled categories (figure 17).

Figure 16. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Qatar, by gender, 2021

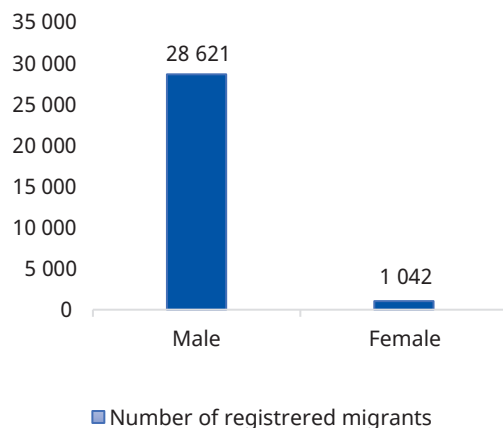
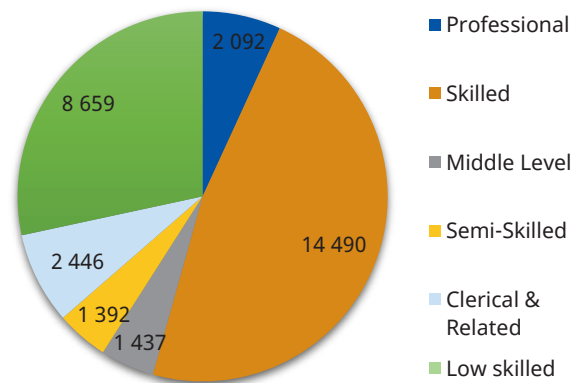


Figure 17. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Qatar, by skill category, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, Qatar was the second-highest source of remittances to Sri Lanka in 2021, at US\$487 million.¹⁶

The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment vacancies page as of June 2023 cited 702 job categories for men and women, with 74,430 positions (of an initial 100,081 vacancies) still available.¹⁷

4. Kuwait

a. Migrant population in Kuwait

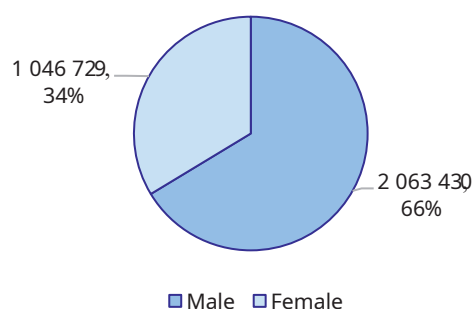
According to the World Migration Report 2022, Kuwait was the twentieth-largest destination country for international migrants. In 2020, as the report noted, 2.98 million migrants lived in Kuwait, or 69.8 per cent of the total population. That means two thirds of Kuwait's population were migrant workers.

Data from the Population Division of the United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs (UN DESA) on the international migrant population put the number at slightly more, at 3,110,159 migrants in Kuwait. Of them, 2,063,430 were men and around half, or 1,046,729, were women (figure 18).

¹⁶ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

¹⁷ SLBFE, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

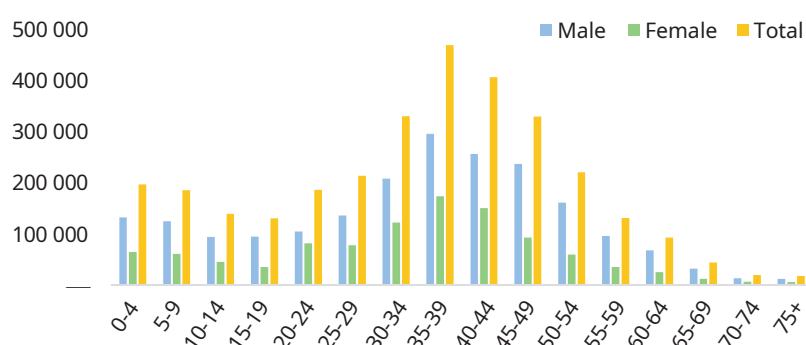
Figure 18. International migrants in Kuwait, by gender, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International Migration Stock 2020".

Most of those migrants were aged 35–39 (figure 19).

Figure 19. International migrants in Kuwait, by gender and age, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International Migration Stock 2020".

Net migration to Kuwait increased between 1995 and 2019, at 17 per cent, before steadily declining from 2020 to 2023 (table 12).

Table 12. Net migration rate in Kuwait, 2020–23

Year	Net migration rate	Decline, compared with previous year (%)
2020	7.125 per 1 000 inhabitants	15.56
2021	5.812 per 1 000 population	18.43
2022	4.499 per 1 000 population	22.59
2023	3.186 per 1 000 population	29.18

Source: See MacroTrends, "Kuwait Net Migration Rate 1950–2023".

The vast number of migrant workers in Kuwait in 2020 hailed mostly from South Asia and Arab countries (table 13). Labour migrants from these regions are predominately employed in the construction sector

and services industry. Among the many immigrant communities in Kuwait in 2020, 32 per cent were Indians and 21 per cent were Egyptians.¹⁸

Table 13. Share of international in Kuwait, by origin region, 2020

Region	Share (%)
Arab region	27.9
South Asia	37.8
Africa	1.9
Other countries	1.1

Source: IOM, *Kuwait-Country-Strategy 2020–2024*, 2020.

Among the Asian countries represented in Kuwait in 2020, Filipinos had the largest grouping, at 11,000 migrants, followed by Nepalese (9,000 migrants), Indians (8,000 migrants) and Sri Lankans (also 8,000 migrants).¹⁹

The share of all foreign workers in the total population in 2020 was 61.7 per cent, while the proportion of foreign workers in the total workforce was 86 per cent. Of the nearly 70 per cent of non-Kuwaitis in the population, an estimated 144,000 persons were irregular migrants. The documented migrants numbered 3,344,362, with 69 per cent of them men and 31 per cent of them women.²⁰

The Government does not grant citizenship to foreigners unless it is an exceptional case, which leads to temporary labour mobility being the most predominant form of migration into the country, especially from countries in South Asia.

The majority (83 per cent) of Kuwaitis are employed in the public sector due to the higher pay, job stability, short hours and other psychosocial factors. Only 8.7 per cent of public sector employees are non-Kuwaitis; 88.3 per cent of non-Kuwaitis are employed in the private sector. According to the *Towards a National Jobs Strategy in Kuwait report*, non-Kuwaiti jobs in the public sector in 2020 were concentrated in health (47 per cent) and education (40 per cent), and migrants were paid less than what nationals were paid for the same work (figure 20). The facilities, wages and benefits for the migrant workers in the private sector are well below the public sector standards. This is one reason behind Kuwaitis' low interest in working in the private sector and the failure of the Government's Kuwaitization efforts.²¹

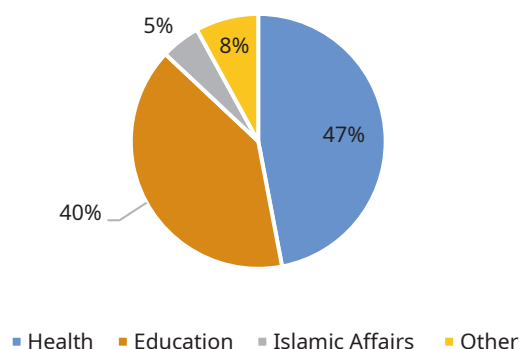
18 IOM, *Kuwait-Country-Strategy 2020–2024*, 2020.

19 Ibid.

20 Ibid.

21 World Bank Group, *Towards a National Jobs Strategy in Kuwait*, 2020.

Figure 20. Proportions of non-Kuwaiti jobs in the public sector, 2019

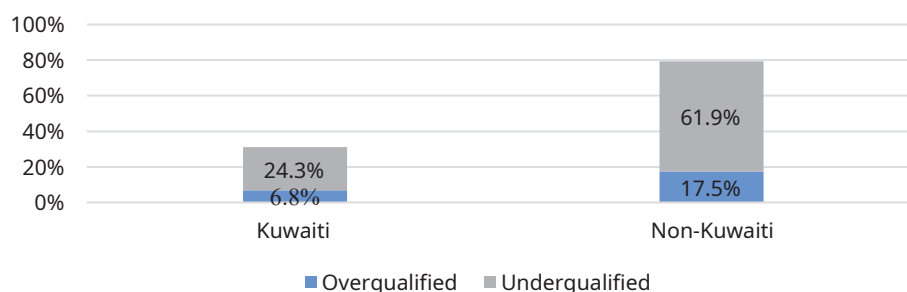


Source: World Bank Group, *Towards a National Jobs Strategy in Kuwait*, 2020.

There is a significant mismatch, estimated at 77 per cent, between workers' skills and the skills demanded by the market. The skills gap was larger for non-Kuwaitis than Kuwaitis in 2019. For Kuwaiti

nationals, 6.8 per cent were overqualified for their job while it was 17.5 per cent for non-Kuwaitis (figure 21).

Figure 21. Qualification mismatch in Kuwait, by nationality and type, 2020



Source: World Bank Group, *Towards a National Jobs Strategy in Kuwait*, 2020

According to data from Kuwait's Public Authority for Civil Information, foreign workers in general, and among them Asians, are more often employed in services and blue-collar occupations than in highly skilled professions. Asian labourers are also mostly employed in the private and domestic labour sectors, while 71 per cent of Asian females alone work in the domestic sector.²²

b. Migration policy in Kuwait

The Ministry of Interior largely manages the country's migration policy. The Domestic Workers Department within the Ministry is responsible for policies regarding domestic labour. Kuwait's migration policy is derived from its "Kuwaitization" policy, aiming to create a 100 per cent Kuwaiti

22 Gulf Labour Markets and Migration, *The Demographic and Economic Framework of Migration in Kuwait*, 2013.

workforce in the public sector and reducing the number of expatriates in the private sector.²³ The Kuwait Public Policy Centre is mandated to provide suggestions to the Government on the formulation of migration policy. Considering the Kuwaitization, the country's frequent changes in rules and regulations governing migration have become less transparent. For transparency, the Public Authority of Manpower has created the Tazeez social media account, but it is only in Arabic.

Kuwait is the first and only Gulf Cooperation Council country to set a minimum wage (in 2016) for domestic workers, at 60 Kuwaiti dinar (US\$200) in 2016. Additionally, the Parliament passed a law in June 2015 that, for the first time, gave migrant domestic workers labour rights, including one day of rest per week, a 12-hour working day with rest and annual paid leave.

Kuwait issued a new standard contract for migrant workers, and a 2016 administrative decision allowed some foreign workers to transfer their sponsorship to a new employer after three years of work without their employer's consent. These reforms, however, do not extend to migrant domestic workers.

The education system does not supply the skills needed in the private sector. Most Kuwaiti students are enrolled in humanities and art subjects, with only about 30 per cent majoring in science, technology, engineering or mathematics. Students aim for public sector employment due to the higher wages and social status.

c. Labour demand and trends in Kuwait

Several features of the 2010 Labour Law have potential impact on nationals as well as the expatriate labour force in Kuwait. If implemented effectively, the law could enhance the welfare of all workers, including non-nationals. The elimination of the kafala system and regulation of foreign worker inflow by an independent authority could reduce visa trading and lower the migration costs for foreign workers. Transferring from one employer to another would also become easier.

Kuwait looks to develop and modernize its infrastructure to improve the quality of life for its citizens and residents. The New Kuwait: Vision 2035 guides investments into the construction sector.

Like other Gulf Cooperation Council countries, Kuwait has embarked on long-term infrastructure mega projects with heavy investment. For example, the value of construction projects in Kuwait is expected to more than double in 2023. Five ongoing projects to build housing units are costing a total of 3.22 billion dinar (US\$10.5 billion), the last of which is to be completed in 2029. Other infrastructure projects include a railway, a new airport, five planned cities and a metro service for Kuwait City. For each of those projects, Kuwait is in the process of importing labourers. Labour demand for migrant workers will remain high because their perceived work ethic is preferred to local workers, in addition to the lower wages and benefits that foreign workers are willing to accept. With the development of infrastructure, new jobs are expected to emerge in the hospitality (hotels) and retail sectors.

d. Migration to Kuwait from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, 12,816 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in Kuwait in 2021. It was a dramatic decrease from the 46,914 in 2018 and the 43,073 in 2019, but an increase from the 8,015 migrants in 2020. Kuwait was among the top-five destinations for Sri Lankans for all four years. Among the total registered migrants in 2021, more than 30 per cent were men and 70 per cent were women. Table 14 reflects the number of registered migrants in 2021 by their skill category.

23 Khitam Al Amir, "One-third of Expats Want to Leave Kuwait", *Gulf News*, 20 May 2021.

Table 14. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Kuwait, by skill category, 2021

Skill category	No. of registered migrant workers
Professional	98
Skilled	3 055
Middle level	72
Semi-skilled	7 769
Clerical & Related	148
Low-skilled	1 674
Total	12 816

Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

As previously noted, the Middle East was the top region in terms of the origin of remittances to Sri Lanka from 2016 to 2021. According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, the most remittances from Sri Lanka migrants in any one country came from Kuwait, at US\$115 million in 2021.²⁴

Kuwait has made around 334 occupation types and 370,435 jobs available to Sri Lankan migrants. According to the latest available Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment data, 342,260 of those vacancies remain available.²⁵

5. United States of America

a. Migrant population in the United States

The United States ranked fifth in the study's scoring system, with the largest migrant population globally and as a top remittance contributor to Sri Lanka. Regarding the migrant flow to the United States, there is no reliable picture; more data are needed, as are new approaches to this potential destination country for Sri Lankan workers.

As depicted in the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development's (OECD) country profile for the United States in 2019, 14 per cent of the population was foreign born. The estimated total migrant population (all persons) in 2020 was 50,632,836, with more women than men among them (figures 22 and 23).

²⁴ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

²⁵ Bureau of Foreign Employment, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

Figure 22. International migrants in the United States, by gender, 2020

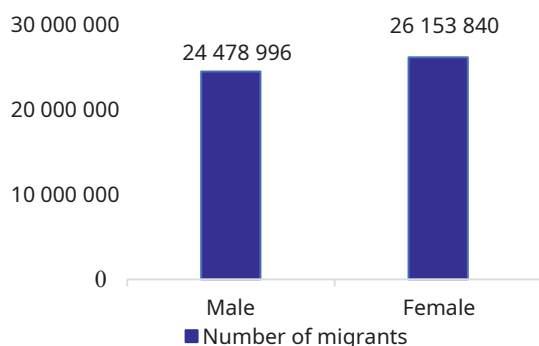
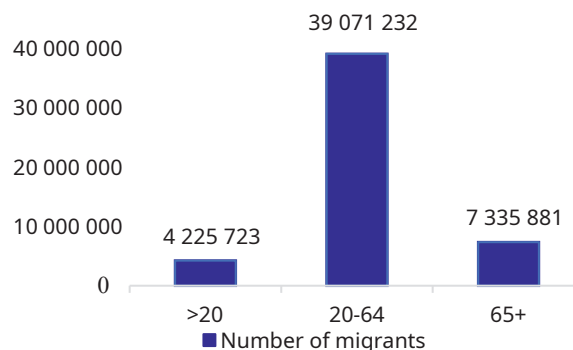


Figure 23. International migrants in the United States, by age category, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, “International Migration Stock 2020”.

The OECD’s labour market outlook for the United States shows that foreign-born labour force participation in 2021 was 74.2 per cent and the foreign-born employment rate was 70 per cent. According to 2020 OECD statistics, the long-term migrant (all persons) flow into the United States consisted of family migrants (61 per cent). Migrant workers accounted for 11 per cent), as did

accompanying family members of workers and migrants for humanitarian purposes.²⁶

According to International Organization for Migration data, the top-five migrant-sending countries to the United States in 2020 were Mexico (by far), India, China, Philippines and El Salvador.

Table 15. Top-five migrant-sending countries to the United States, 2020

Country	Migrant population
Mexico	10 853 105
India	2 723 764
China	2 184 110
Philippines	2 061 178
El Salvador	1 410 659

Source: IOM, *World Migration Report 2022*, 2022

b. Migration policy in the United States²⁷

As per the OECD’s International Migration Outlook 2021, the Government reviewed the country’s migration policies to ensure a safe and humane immigration system. The initiative led to the welcoming of refugees and greater promotion of legal immigration, as well as citizenship. But then

the country reverted to WHAT I DON’T KNOW turned to their previous public charge rules which was a court order given in 2019. The Government is collaborating with other stakeholders mainly focused on wide spreading the awareness on public charge rules among the community with respect to public health and ongoing vaccination programmes during the pandemic period.

²⁶ OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2022*, 2022.

²⁷ Information sources for this section: see Pew Research Center, “Key Facts About U.S. Immigration Policies and Biden’s Proposed Changes”, 11 January 2022; OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2021*, 2021.

However, President Biden's immigration policy proposal includes reforms to undo restrictions made during the Trump administration, including the lifting of restrictions established during the pandemic period. The reforms seek to provide unauthorized immigrants a pathway to legal status and an eight-year pathway to citizenship; promote family-based immigration; revise employment-based visa rules; and increase the number of diversity visas. Revising the employment-based visa rules includes increasing the number of employment-based Permanent Resident Cards (Green Cards) issued to foreign workers and their families and increasing the number of diversity visas to 80,000 for persons from underrepresented nations. Also, President Biden's proposal is seeking a review of the contractionary policies that the previous administration had adopted for H1-B visas, which are given to highly skilled foreign workers.

Aligning with strategies adopted for COVID-19 pandemic, the Department of Homeland Security offered certification to employ temporary workers, pending their final approval. The Department also introduced measures to accelerate the processing of employment authorization applications as well as for student applicants who complete the Optional

Practical Training within the 14-month period after approval of work authorization.

c. Labour demand and trends in the United States

The US Bureau of Labor Statistics reported that the American Government expects to add 8.3 million jobs between 2021 and 2031 to the country's labour market. The leisure and hospitality sector was the most expected sector for the fastest employment growth in 2021, after the pandemic period. During this period of 2021–31, the health care and social assistance sectors are predicted to be the largest job creation sector in the United States. This is due to the growth of the population older than 65. This trend is expected to lead to more demand for elderly care occupations and other health care opportunities. In addition, the Bureau has projected a change in wages and salaries for the same time period, with the leisure and hospitality, health care and social assistance, mining and education services having high rates of wage increases while manufacturing, retail trade, federal government and utilities may have decreases. Table 16 reflects the ten fastest-growing occupations expected in 2021–31.

Table 16. Ten-fastest growing occupations and median annual wages in the United States, 2021–31 (US\$)

Occupation	Median annual wage, May 2021
Nurse practitioners	\$120 680
Umpires, referees and other sports officials	\$56 260
Statisticians	\$24 440
Information security analysts	\$29 350
Athletes and sports competitors	\$30 010
Data scientists	\$100 910
Cooks, restaurant staff	\$77 300
Motion picture projectionists	\$102 600
Ushers, lobby attendants and ticket takers	\$95 570
Wind turbine service technicians	\$35 860

Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics, "Employment Projections, 2021–2031".

d. Migration to the United States from Sri Lanka

The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment has no data on Sri Lankans migrating to the United States for work. According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, the United States was among the top-ten remittance contributors to Sri Lanka in 2021, at US\$158 million).²⁸

On the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment's vacancies page, there are three types of job categories for the United States, and most of them are in the health sector. Altogether, there are 138 approved vacancies, and all of them are still available for Sri Lankans.²⁹

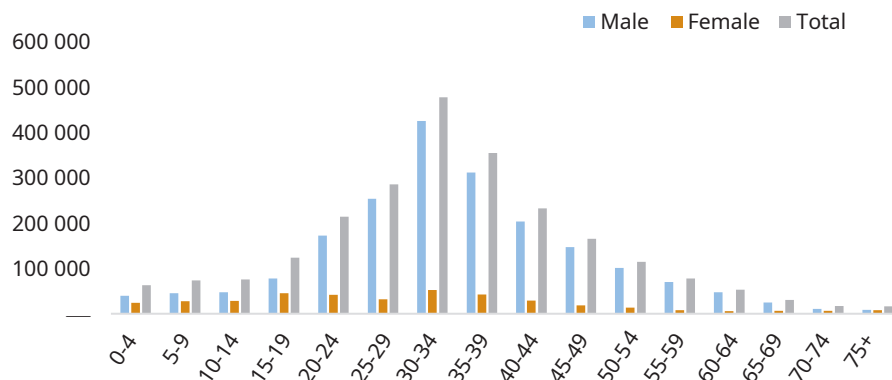
6. Oman

a. Migrant population in Oman

Oman is popular as a labour-importing country. In the scoring system adopted for this study, Oman placed fifteenth among the remittance origin countries and sixth among destination countries for Sri Lankan migrants. Overall, Oman ranked sixth in terms of its potential for skilled and professional migrants from Sri Lanka.

According to Oman's National Centre for Statistics and Information, the total population in 2021 of 4,507,468 persons included 2,757,983 Omanis (61.2 per cent) and 1,749,485 expatriates (38.8 per cent). But according to UN DESA statistics, 2,372,836 migrants lived in Oman in 2020; of them, 1,984,025 were men and 388,811 were women (figure 24).

Figure 24. International migrants in Oman, by age and gender, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International Migration Stock 2020".

According to Oman's National Centre for Statistics and Information's March 2021 statistics, Bangladesh nationals continue to be the largest migrant community in the country, with a total 546,615 workers and their dependants, followed by Indians,

at 491,427 persons, and Pakistanis, at 182,885 persons.³⁰

The top-five sending countries in 2018 were Bangladesh, India, Pakistan, Philippines and Egypt (table 17).

28 KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

29 Bureau of Foreign Employment, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

30 Nasrallah 2021.

Table 17. International migrants in Oman, by country of citizenship, 2018

Country	Migrant population
India	748 461
Bangladesh	690 407
Pakistan	257 105
Egypt	50 431
Philippines	49 243
Uganda	31 986
Sri Lanka	23 063
Nepal	17 748

Source: Gulf Labour Markets, Migration and Population, “Oman: Population (selected nationalities and sex)”, 2018.

The net migration rate for Oman in 2023 is 4.120 per 1,000 population, which is a 41.4 per cent decline from 2022, when the rate was 7.025 per 1,000 population, which was a 29.3 per cent decline from 2021, when the rate was 9.931 per 1,000 population. And that rate represented a 22.6 per cent decline from 2020, at 12.836 per 1,000 population.

According to the National Centre for Statistics and Information’s Monthly Statistical Bulletin for January 2022, there were 1.131 million expatriates employed in the country’s private sector in December. However, there was a 10 per cent decline in the number of expatriates working in the government sector, dropping from 38,073 public sector employees in November 2021 to 37,996 in December 2021. In total, there were some 1.38 million expatriates employed in Oman (Omans expat numbers on the rise since October 2022).

b. Migration policy in Oman

There is a strong downward trend in the number of foreigners in Oman. It is mostly due to several labour-related policies designed to prioritize Omanis for employment over expatriates, a trend called “Omanization”. Some jobs in the private sector will be nationalized, and foreign workers in the country’s public service will also be replaced by Omani

nationals as part of a wider strategy called Vision Oman 2040 that seeks to diversify the economy away from oil and make it more beneficial to the local population.

In line with the Omanization policy, the Government enforced restrictions on non-Oman citizens in 207 job categories. By 2018, the Ministry of Labour had extended the ban to foreign workers in 87 jobs spanning ten sectors.³¹ According to Oman Vision 2040, the Government is looking to have Omanis fill a 40 per cent share in private sector employment.³²

c. Labour demand and trends in Oman

Oman citizens dominate the public sector while foreign workers are more numerous in the private sector. Data from 2020 indicate that nearly 90 per cent of the public sector employees were Omani nationals.³³ However, the Omanization policies have brought more Oman citizens into the private sector than the public sector, which has had tough impact on the foreign labour market.

Due to the Omanization policy, there are only limited sectors and jobs open to foreign workers. Under the policy, the following occupations are reserved for citizens:³⁴

31 Mona Farag, “Oman’s Latest Employment Rules for Foreigners Explained”, in *NGulf*, 3 September 2022.

32 Government of Oman, Oman Vision 2040, 2021.

33 Author, “Skills Needs in the Oman Labour Market: An Employer Survey 2022”, 2022.

34 K.C. Das, and Nilambari Gokhale, “Omanization Policy and International Migration in Oman”, Middle East Institute, 2010.

- specialists: lawyer, civil engineer, accountant, legal adviser, department manager;
- technicians: primary school teacher, nurse, architectural draftsman, TV cameraperson;
- occupational workers: accounts clerk, general car mechanic, general salesperson, general leather worker;
- skilled workers: leather worker, welder, typist, electrician; and
- limited-skilled workers: newspaper vendor, machine operator, car repair or fitter.

The future demand for foreign workers will depend on many factors: the number of young nationals entering the labour market and the effect of the localization of labour markets; the ability of Omanis to create new jobs; the development of locals based on vocational training and skills-based courses; and the reduction of the gap between the needed and available skills of locals.

As with other Gulf Cooperation Council countries, Oman is invested heavily in infrastructure projects.

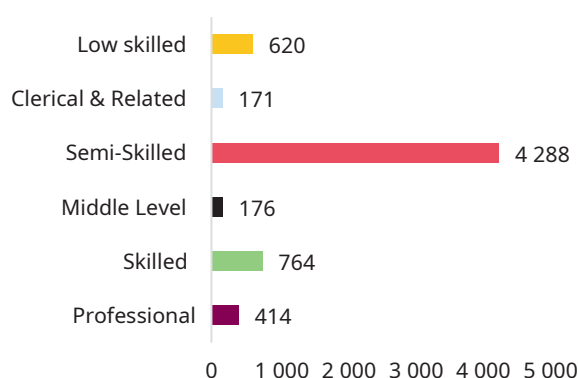
Oman's Ras Al Khar Eco-Resort Su is among the mega projects, which include oil, gas and green fuel mega projects as well as projects in the health and education sectors. The infrastructure projects are generating jobs in the construction sector and the logistics and manufacturing sectors.

In the Oman Vision 2040, five sectors have been singled out as potential drivers of future employment and economic growth: Manufacturing was expected to be the major driver. For example, Liwa Plastic Industries Complex has created 13,000 jobs (1,000 direct and 12,000 indirect). Transportation and logistics, tourism, mining and fisheries are the other four drivers.³⁵

d. Migration to Oman from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, 6,433 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in Oman in 2021 (figure 25). This was a decline from the 8,329 migrants in 2018 and the 9,016 in 2019 but an increase from the 2,719 migrants in 2021. Among the total registered migrants in 2021, more than 75 per cent were men, with only 25 per cent women.

Figure 25. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Oman, by skill category, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

35 See Government of Oman, Oman Vision 2040, 2021.

Again as previously noted, the Middle East was the top region for remittances going to Sri Lanka from 2016 to 2021. According to the KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, all Sri Lankans in Oman remitted US\$78 million in 2021.³⁶

Oman has made 39,251 jobs in 128 occupation types available to Sri Lankans. According to the latest available data with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, Sri Lankans have filled 4,384 of the vacancies, with 34,867 still available.³⁷

7. United Kingdom

a. Migrant population in the United Kingdom

The United Kingdom emerged seventh in the scoring system used for this study, with a large migrant population of migrants from many countries and as a top source of remittances to Sri Lanka. Only a few Sri Lankans in the United Kingdom, however, were registered with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment.

According to OECD statistics, 14 per cent of the population in the United Kingdom in 2019 was foreign born.³⁸ The total migrant population in the United Kingdom in 2020 was 9,359,587, with more women than men (figure 26). Among the migrant population, the largest portion was aged 20–64 in 2020 (figure 27).

Figure 26. International migrants in the United Kingdom, by gender, 2020

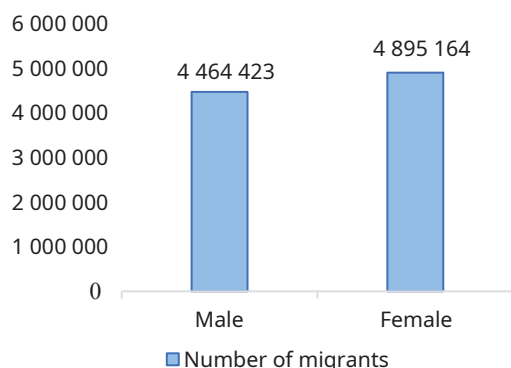
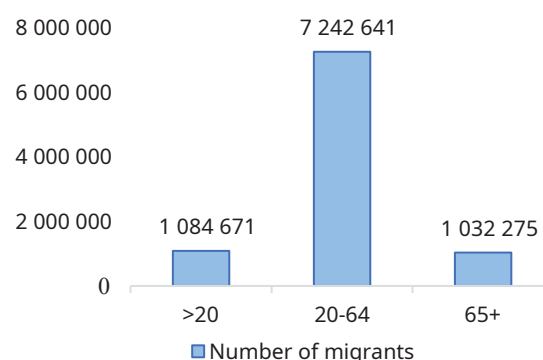


Figure 27. International migrants in the United Kingdom, by age, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, “International Migration Stock 2020”.

According to OECD data 2022, 79.9 per cent of the labour force participants in 2021 in the United Kingdom were foreign born, with the foreign-born employment rate at 75.5 per cent. Both rates were

higher than the average rates in 2021 for OECD countries as average labour force participants rate was 75.7 per cent while average foreign-born employment rate was 69.2 per cent.³⁹

³⁶ KNOMAD, “Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021”, n.d.

³⁷ SLBFE, Foreign Job Vacancies”, n.d.

³⁸ OECD, International Migration Outlook 2022, 2022.

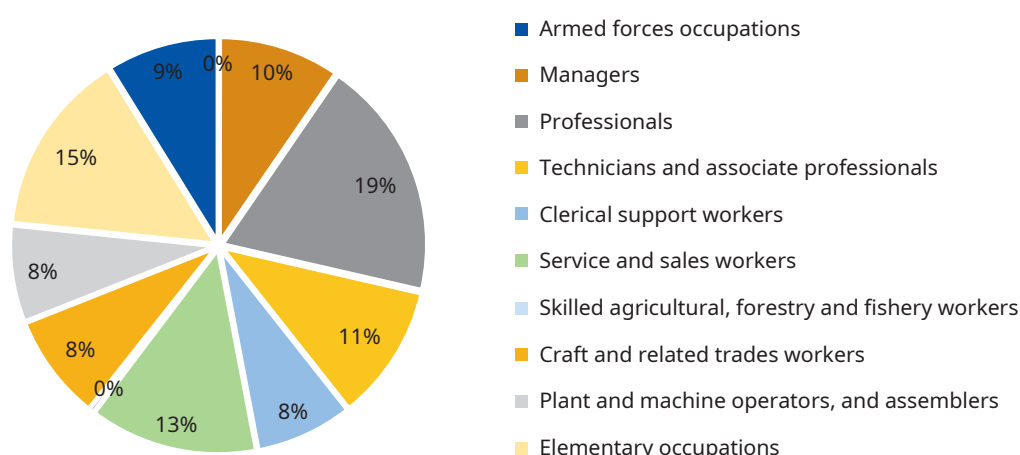
³⁹ Ibid

The United Kingdom's 2012 Labour Force Survey findings indicate that the finance, retail and health sectors have comprised a greater proportion of international migrants than persons born in the country.⁴⁰ Figure 28 depicts the economically active foreign-born population by occupation, according to the 2011 Census data,⁴¹ with the largest portion of foreign-born people employed as professionals, followed by elementary occupations.

As stated in a 2022 press release from the University of Oxford, by the third quarter 2021, foreign-born

employees in the United Kingdom constituted 18 per cent of the total employed population. More migrant men were likely to be employed than men born in the United Kingdom, although fewer migrant women were less likely to be employed than women born there. Migrants born in Pakistan and other South Asian countries (with the exception of India) were heavily represented in the retail and transport and storage sectors.

Figure 28. Percentage of foreign-born population in the United Kingdom, by occupation, 2011



Source: UN DESA, "Economically Active Foreign-born Population by Occupation, Age, Sex and Urban/Rural Residence", 2011 (latest available data).

According to International Organization for Migration data, the top-five migrant-sending countries to the United Kingdom in 2020 were Poland, India, Pakistan, Romania and Ireland (table 18).

Table 18. Top-five migrant-sending countries to the United Kingdom, 2020

Country	Migrant population
Poland	835 975
India	835 359
Pakistan	537 047
Romania	393 569
Ireland	370 151

Source: IOM, *World Migration Report 2022*, 2022.

⁴⁰ Government of United Kingdom, Immigration and the UK Labour Market: The Latest Evidence from Economic Research, 2012.

⁴¹ The data cover the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland, excluding the Channel Islands (Guernsey and Jersey) and Isle of Man as per the data source.

b. Migration policy in the United Kingdom⁴²

The United Kingdom introduced a point-based immigration system that took effect in January 2021. The most important thing is that the system treats European Union citizens and non-European Union nationals alike – all require a visa to enter the United Kingdom. According to the Government, the European Union’s free movement system was failing to meet the needs of the United Kingdom as well as failing to provide benefits to highly skilled migrants from other regions willing to migrate to and serve its economy. The Government implemented the new system with the objective of expanding its migration system to serve all foreign-born residents in an equal way. The Government believes this adaptation will revolutionize the operation of its borders, tighten security and deliver a better “customer” experience for migrants coming to the United Kingdom.

This system is expected to provide more opportunities to skilled foreign workers who can contribute the most to the economy. The objective of the new system is to end free movement and change the long-term work route, which is now called the “skilled-worker route”, to focus on highly skilled or semi-skilled foreign workers. To obtain a skilled worker visa, applicants must have the required points based on certain criteria, such as a job offer from an approved sponsor, a job at an appropriate skill level, English language skills, etc. The required points for each applicant vary based on the job, applicant’s skill level, the salary and so on.

As explained in the OECD’s International Migration Outlook 2022, the new policy implications include adaptation of the digital control system, which makes the recruitment of foreigners for skilled jobs more flexible and covers national labour shortages. The policy also includes new routes for economic

workers, such as health and caregiving workers and new graduates. Changes to the quota-based seasonal worker visas include a temporary extension, a scaled-up route (in effect since mid-2022), adaptation of special reforms for the resettlement of Afghan citizens, adoption of the Nationality and Borders Act, 2022 that prevents illegal entry and targets smuggling networks and country-specific agreements with Rwanda (a new Migration and Economic Development Partnership) and Ukraine regarding refugees and their families affected by the war. Additionally, high-growth companies are now able to sponsor workers in high-skill roles.

c. Labour demand and trends in the United Kingdom⁴³

A study published by the Government on The Future of Work – Jobs and Skills 2030 cited 13 trends as the most influential on the direction of jobs and skills (table 19). The study’s findings highlight that more than one third of economically active people are aged 65 or older. The findings also note the increase of virtual workers globally, that the majority of business innovations in the future will be co-developed with partners outside the business and that advanced manufacturing processes could lead to employment increases in the manufacturing sector. The study findings also stress actions for protecting the future job market from challenges, such as job losses due to digitalization, automation of professional work, artificial intelligence and robots. The suggested actions refer to increasing workforce diversity, encouraging individuals to take greater responsibility for investing in their own skills and developing technological skills and calling on policymakers to devise a strategy that ensures low-skilled labour adaptation to the changing labour market.

42 Source for the information in this section: Government of United Kingdom, “The UK’s Points-based Immigration System: Policy Statement”, 19 February 2020; OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2022*, 2022.

43 Source for the information for this section: Government of United Kingdom, *The Future of Work: Jobs and Skills in 2030*, 2014; Ann Morris, Shortage Occupation List 2023, 4 October 2023; Government of United Kingdom, *Immigration Rules – Immigration Rules Appendix Shortage Occupation List - Guidance*, 2016; CIPD, *Labour Market Outlook: Spring 2023*

Table 19. The 13 trends with great influence on jobs and skills in the United Kingdom, to 2030

Society and the individual	Technology and innovation	Business and the economy	Resources and the environment	Law and politics
• Changing work environments • Growing diversity • Desire for • Work-life balance • Demographic change • Income uncertainty	• Converging technology • ICT and big data • Digitalization of production	• Changed economic perspectives • New business ecosystems • Shift to Asia	• Growing scarcity of resources	• Decreasing scope for political action

Source: Government of United Kingdom, *The Future of Work: Jobs and Skills in 2030*, 2014.

The Government publishes a regularly updated Shortage Occupation List on the most important industry gaps that the United Kingdom needs to fill with high-skilled professionals, wherever they may originate. The list provides information on

eligible job opportunities for skilled worker visas that applicants can apply for. For instance, table 20 shows the ten occupations with vacancies listed as of June 2023.

Table 20. Top-ten shortage occupations in the United Kingdom, as of June 2023

1181	Health services and public health managers and directors – all jobs
1242	Residential, day and domiciliary care managers and proprietors – all jobs
2111	Chemical scientists – only jobs in the nuclear industry
2112	Biological scientists and biochemists – all jobs
2113	Physical scientists – only the following jobs in the construction-related ground engineering industry: engineering geologist, hydrogeologist, geophysicist
2113	Physical scientists – only the following jobs in the oil and gas industry: geophysicist, geoscientist, geologist, geochemist, technical services manager in the decommissioning and waste areas of the nuclear industry, senior resource geologist and staff geologist in the mining sector
2114	Social and humanities scientists – only archaeologist
2121	Civil engineers – all jobs
2122	Mechanical engineers – all jobs
2123	Electrical engineers – all jobs

Source: Immigration Rules Appendix, Shortage Occupation List.

A recent survey of employers in the United Kingdom by the Chartered Institute of Personnel and Development revealed that by the spring of 2023, employment intentions remained positive in all industries.⁴⁴ The predicted recruitments will be highest in the construction sector with a few novel occupations likely added to the Shortage Occupation List, such as bricklayers, roofers, carpenters and plasterers. The survey report stressed that employers in the United Kingdom can access a wider pool of suitable workers due to the more favourable migration arrangements, including the recent reforms of the system.

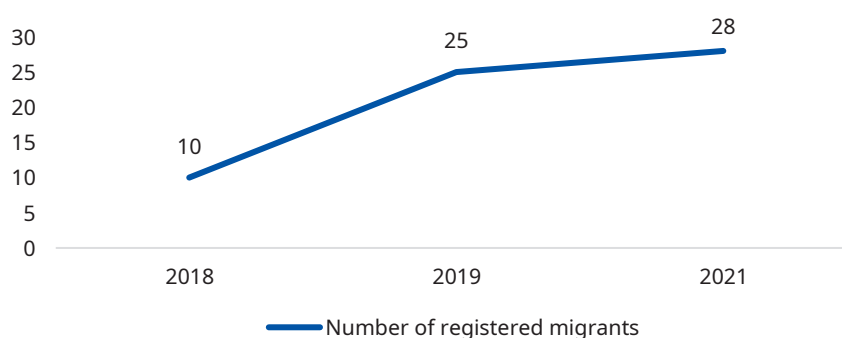
The survey report also highlighted that the education and health sectors are struggling to fill their vacancies. More than half of the surveyed employers in each industry reported a struggle to fill their vacancies, and 16 per cent of the surveyed employers need to fill their vacancies with non-European Union citizens.

In response to a recommendation from the Migration Advisory Committee in the United Kingdom, the Government announced that jobs in the seafood sector, such as fisherfolk, trawler skippers and experienced deckhands on large vessels, will be added to the Shortage Occupation List as of May 2023.

d. Migration to the United Kingdom from Sri Lanka

According to Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, only 28 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in the United Kingdom in 2021. In 2018, there were ten registered migrants and 25 in 2019 (figure 29). Of the 28 registered migrants, four were women, and most of them were classified as professionals (figures 30 and 31). These statistics emphasize the importance of rethinking a novel approach regarding the United Kingdom to capitalize on the opportunities in their labour market.

Figure 29. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the United Kingdom, 2018, 2019 and 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

44 CIPD, *Labor Market Outlook – Views from Employers*, 2023.

Figure 30. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the United Kingdom, by gender, 2021

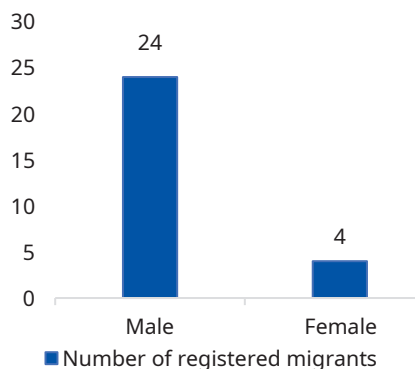
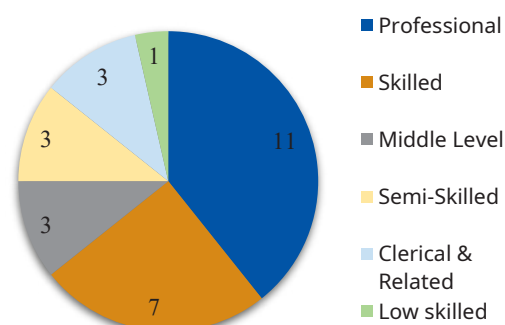


Figure 31. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the United Kingdom, by skill level, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, the United Kingdom was among the top-six countries for Sri Lanka remittances in 2021, at US\$359 million.⁴⁵

On the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment's vacancies page, there are eight types of job categories for the United Kingdom, and most of them are in the health and caregiving sector, with 596 vacancies – 485 of which remain unfilled.⁴⁶

8. Germany

a. Migrant population in Germany

In the scoring system used for this study, Germany placed eleventh among countries of top remitters to Sri Lanka and was eighth overall. According to the International Organization for Migration's World Migration Report 2022, Germany is the second-largest destination country for international migrants.

According to UN DESA statistics for international migrants as of mid-2020, there were 15,762,457 migrants in Germany. Of them, 7,891,635 were men and 7,870,822 were women, and most were aged 20–64 (table 21).

Table 21. International migrants in Germany, by age category, as of mid-2020

Age category	Migrant population
Younger than 20	1 323 893
20–64	11 067 885
65 and older	3 370 679

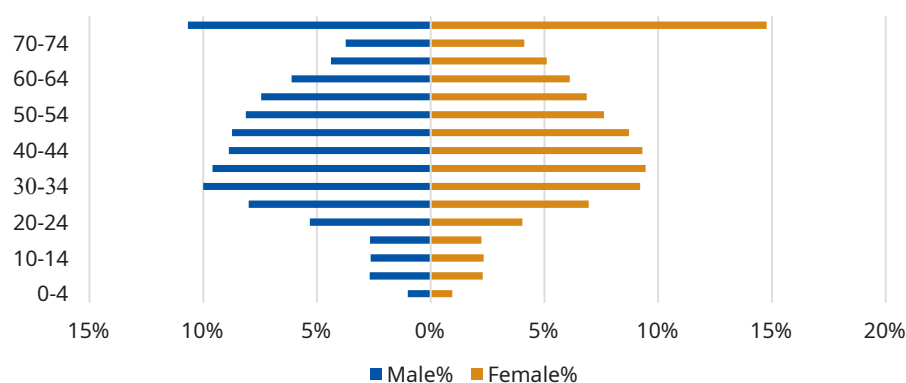
Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International Migration Stock 2020".

⁴⁵ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

⁴⁶ SLBFE, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

The net migration rate for Germany in 2020 was 4.632 per 1,000 population, which was a 17.3 per cent decline from the 2019 rate.

Figure 32. International migrants in Germany, by age and gender, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, “International Migration Stock 2020”.

According to OECD statistics, Germany received 631,000 new migrants in 2018 who came on a long-term or permanent basis (including changes of status and free mobility). This represented a reduction of 26.7 per cent from the number in 2017. It comprised 60.7 per cent of migrants benefiting from free mobility, 10.3 per cent who were labour migrants, 15.4 per cent family members (including accompanying family) and 12.4 per cent humanitarian migrants.⁴⁷ Around 48,000 entry permits were issued to tertiary-level international students and 29,000 to temporary and seasonal labour migrants (excluding intra-European Union migration). The majority of the immigrants in 2020 were from Europe (69.1 per cent), followed by Romania (185,924 immigrants), Poland (103,496 immigrants) and Bulgaria (72,734 migrants).⁴⁸

b. Migration policy in Germany

In June 2019, the Government approved a package of migration-related laws. The Skilled Immigration Act, which came into force in 2020, opens the labour market to skilled non-European Union migrants who have had vocational training. The Skilled Immigration Act enables third-country nationals with qualified vocational training to enter Germany

to obtain employment or to have their professional qualifications recognized. Labour migrants with an employment contract or job offer no longer need to undergo a labour market test to work in occupations with labour shortage. Despite the law coming into effect in 2021 only about 25,000 skilled workers in total came to Germany under the new rules.

In 2022, the Cabinet adopted a new skilled labour strategy that provides for an immigration policy that strengthens the Skilled Immigration Act with administrative reforms in recruitment. As part of this, the Government published a white paper on amending the law on skilled labour immigration, with the objective of making the recruitment of such workers from developing countries for the German labour market simpler and quicker.

In 2023, Germany is to become even more attractive for skilled workers from around the world: A new law is planned to make it easier and faster for people from countries outside the European Union to enter the labour market. The Federal Ministry of Labour and Social Affairs is expected to introduce a new immigration possibility for skilled foreign workers with the creation of an “opportunity card” that will be issued according to a points-based system. It

⁴⁷ OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2020*, 2020.

⁴⁸ Federal Office for Migration and Refugees. 2023. Migration Report 2020: Key Results. Bundesamt für Migration und Flüchtlinge.

includes four criteria: applicants should be 35 or younger, have a degree, have at least three years of work experience and have language skills or a previous stay in Germany.

c. Labour demand and trends in Germany

One of the main challenges that Germany faces is its ageing population and low birth rate. Thus, the

Government estimates the country needs at least 400,000 skilled migrants annually to keep up with the labour demand. Germany will continue experiencing massive labour shortages (table 22) unless it begins recruiting skilled immigrants to replace workers retiring from the country's ageing workforce.

Table 22. Sectors considered particularly hard hit with skilled labour shortages in Germany, 2021

Social sector and social education: This sector had an average of 20,500 vacant positions for educators in 2021 and 2022.

Health and care: Care professions require skills training with qualification or a degree. In 2021–22, 18,300 posts were available in geriatric care and 16,800 in health care and nursing.

Construction and skilled crafts: Sectors such as electrical construction; plumbing, heating and air-conditioning technology; and construction planning and supervision have had a severe labour shortage that grew more so in 2021. There were 87,500 vacancies in the manual trades that were not filled in 2021. Here, the lack is especially in skilled workers who have obtained their professional qualification.

Information technology: In 2021, the skilled labour gap increased to about 28,700 workers, a record high.

Science, technology, engineering and mathematics: A total of 320,600 STEM jobs had a reported labour shortage in 2022. The largest shortage (136,300 jobs) was skilled workers who had completed their professional training.

Source: German Institute for International and Security Affairs, *Germany is Looking for Foreign Labour*, 2023.

Germany is preparing to pass a new national law that will make it easier for foreigners to obtain German citizenship as part of a broader shake-up of its immigration policy aimed at strengthening the country's shrinking workforce. Additionally, there is a push to hire well-trained employees in almost all sectors. There is high demand for doctors and nursing staff, IT specialists, climate technicians, engineers and, in the wake of the expansion of renewable energies, specialists in the fields of heating and engineering technology.

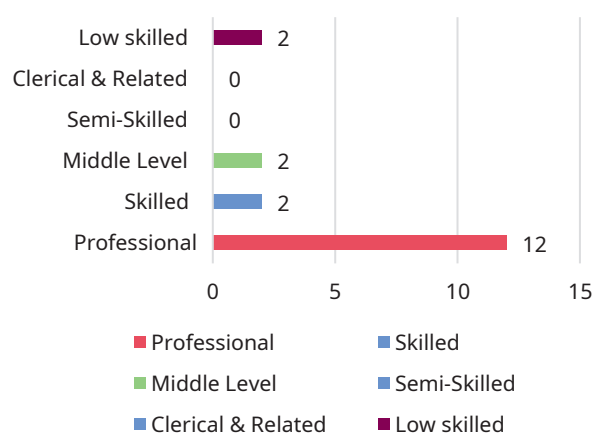
Businesses in the hotel and restaurant sectors as well as the logistics sector have been seeking personnel. Apart from skilled labour, the demand

for low-skilled qualified workers also has been growing, for instance, in the help and household-related services.

d. Migration to Germany from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, 18 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in Germany in 2021 (figure 33).

Figure 33. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Germany, by skill level, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

According to KNOMAD's the bilateral remittance matrix, Sri Lankan migrants in Germany remitted US\$150 million in 2021.⁴⁹ Currently, Germany is seeking 400 nurses from Sri Lanka.⁵⁰

9. Japan

a. Migrant population in Japan

Japan emerged ninth in the study's scoring system, which emphasizes its importance as a destination country for foreign employment for Sri Lankans despite it not being in the traditional pool of destinations. Based on all three criteria (global migrant population, remittances to Sri Lanka and popularity as a destination) Japan looms as a market to target with an approach that is more efficient and different from the regular methods.

According to OECD International migration outlook data 2022, Japan hosted some 2.3 per cent of all migrants globally in 2021. In 2020 OECD data, 67 per cent of the long-term immigrants in Japan were there for employment. That year, Japan hosted a total of 2,770,996 migrants; of them, 1,347,156 were men and 1,423,840 were women. The largest portion of the migrant population were in between age 20-64 (figures 34 and 35).

⁴⁹ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

⁵⁰ SLBFE, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

Figure 34. International migrants in Japan, by gender, 2020

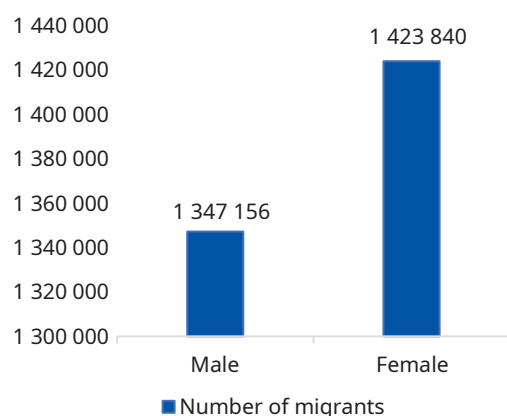
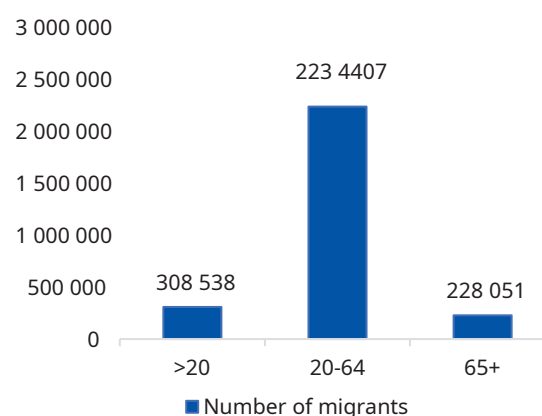


Figure 35. International migrants in Japan, by age category, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, “International Migration Stock 2020”.

According to OECD data, the foreign-born employment rate in Japan in 2020 was 77.4 per cent, which was higher than the OECD average rate in 2021 (69.2 per cent), as was the foreign-born labour market participation rate, at 81.5 per cent compared to OECD average rate in 2021 (75.7 per cent), respectively.⁵¹

In 2020, the top-five countries sending migrants to Japan were China, Republic of Korea, Viet Nam, Philippines and Brazil (table 23).

Table 23. Top-five migrant-sending countries to Japan, 2020

Country	Migrant population
China	775 893
Republic of Korea	456 203
Viet Nam	335 668
Philippines	275 252
Brazil	204 814

Source: IOM, *World Migration Report 2022*, 2022.

b. Migration policy in Japan⁵²

The country’s migration policy in Japan includes several types of residencies, such as family residence, working residence and a start-up visa for entrepreneurs. Japan follows three types of immigration schemes: a residence system, a points-

based system and admission based on the transfer of technology, skills or knowledge. The point-based system differs from other countries by targeting high-skilled workers under the status of residence system and is considered as a fast-track path to permanent residence status. Japan’s immigration

⁵¹ OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2022*, 2022.

⁵² Source of information for this section: see Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan, “Visa”; Chizuko Hayakawa, “Japan’s Recent Dynamic Developments in Immigration Law and Policy”, *Open Edition Journals*, April 2019; OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2021*, 2021

policy aims to attract high-skilled and professional workers. However, due to its large ageing population and low birth rate, Japan is liberalizing its migration policy.

The Government moved to accept low-skilled workers in 2018 with an amendment to the Immigration Control Act. In 2019, Japan began prioritizing semi-skilled workers as well. The Government introduced two categories of residency: specified-skill worker and semi-skilled workers in 14 industry fields experiencing a labour shortage.

Japan promulgated a law regarding the promotion of Japanese language education also in 2019. This was aimed to prepare foreign nationals to more easily engage with Japanese citizens.

Due to the global pandemic situation, the Government banned foreigners in 2020 from entering the country except special permanent residents or in special circumstances. The visa free regime was suspended, as was public transport.

c. Labour demand and trends in Japan⁵³

The Japanese labour market can be categorized as having low unemployment and high employment. However, the automation of most economic activities and the ageing population are concerning challenges. The rapid automation process is leading to a mismatch of supply and demand for labour. For instance, employers are experiencing difficulties in finding employees with the right skills and qualifications. Unless training and education reforms take place to uplift employees' skills and experience

to match the changing employment environment, an imbalance between the demand for and supply of labour is likely.

OECD data analysis stresses that most low-skill occupations, such as elementary and agricultural jobs, will be affected by the technological processes, although the occupational levels of managers, professionals and technicians will be less affected. Similarly, attitudes towards technology will be a factor of adaptation in a sector or industry. A survey conducted among Japanese adults revealed a strong preference for human workers rather than automated tools for such services as childcare, health care and education.⁵⁴

A 2020 McKinsey & Company report noted that with new technology adaptations, employers should start training and reskilling employees in the modern systems.⁵⁵ Thus, Japan's labour market will require more data scientists and people with skills in technology, analytics and business to carry out its transformation process.⁵⁶

Drawing on the RGF International Recruitment's 2021 Talent in Asia report, table 24 shows the jobs most in demand in a few popular industries in Japan.⁵⁷

53 Source of information for this section: see OECD, OECD, *Changing Skill Needs in the Japanese Labour Market*, 2021; McKinsey & Company, "Japan Must Accelerate Automation During the COVID-19 Recovery to Combat a Labor Shortage That Threatens Economic Growth", 2020; RGF Professional Recruitment, *Salary Trends, Hiring Trends and the Most In-demand Jobs in Japan*, 2021.

54 OECD, *Changing Skill Needs in the Japanese Labour Market*, 2021.

55 Maya Horii and Sakurai Yasuaki, *The Future of Work in Japan: Accelerating Automation After COVID-19*, McKinsey & Company, 2020

56 Ibid

57 RGF Professional Recruitment, *Salary Trends, Hiring Trends and the Most In-demand Jobs in Japan*, 2021

Table 24. Jobs most in demand in Japan, 2020

Industrial sector
Application engineering
Project management (director)
Sales and marketing (business development manager)
Senior management
Financial services sector
Audit and compliance
Investment banking (associate)
Private equity
Project finance
Real estate asset management
Relationship management (managing director)
Risk management
Technology, internet and telecommunications sector
AI and data science (manager)
Cloud security and infrastructure (senior manager)
Consulting implementation and management
Digital marketing
Digital transformation
Enterprise software
Financial services IT
IT consulting (director)
Project management
Sales
Consumer goods and retail sector
Business strategy and commercial (manager)
Customer relationship management
Digital marketing
E-commerce (director)
Marketing and branding
Sales and business development
Supply chain and procurement
Trade marketing (manager)
Health and life science sector
Clinical development (manager)
Health care service and management
Hospital management
Medical (doctor)
Regulatory affairs (director)
Sales and marketing

Source: RGF Professional Recruitment, Salary Trends, Hiring Trends and the Most In-demand Jobs in Japan, 2021.

The RGF report parsed the in-demand jobs into hard and soft skills (table 25).

Table 25. Hard and soft skills most in demand by employers in Japan, 2020

Hard skills	Soft skills
Industry knowledge and experience	Communication and presentation
Functional mastery and expertise	Task-focused
Proficiency in a foreign language	Good team player
Technical skills	Problem-solving
Professional certifications and licenses	Adaptable and flexible
Educational background	Innovation and creativity
	Accountability and responsibility

Source: RGF Professional Recruitment, *Salary Trends, Hiring Trends and the Most In-demand Jobs in Japan, 2021*

d. Migration to Japan from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, 817 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in Japan in 2021, which was an increase from the 746 in 2018 but a decrease from the 1,594

in 2019 (figure 36). Among the registered migrants in 2021, 92 per cent were men while only 8 per cent were women (figure 37). Japan was in the top 20 destinations for Sri Lankan workers in all three years.

Figure 36. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants to Japan, 2021

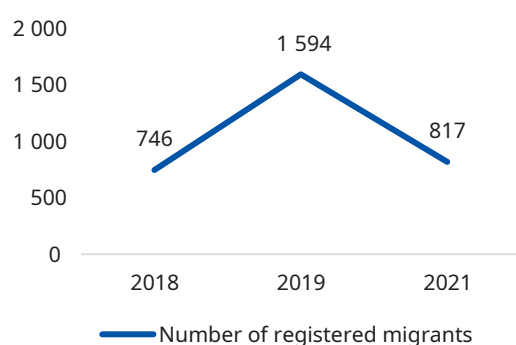
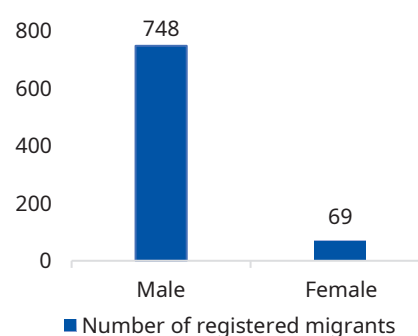


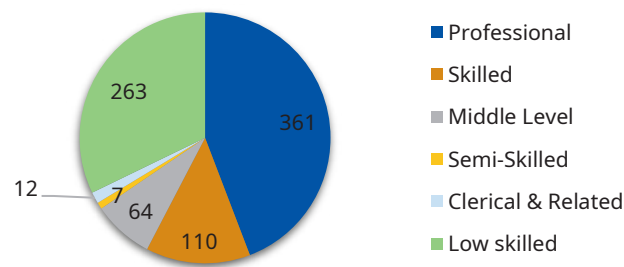
Figure 37. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants to Japan, by gender, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

As figure 38 indicates, the largest proportions of Sri Lankan migrants in Japan in 2021 were in professional and low-skill categories.

Figure 38. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants to Japan, by skill category, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, Japan was in the top-20 countries of remittances to Sri Lanka, at US\$71 million.⁵⁸

Japan has invited Sri Lankans to apply for 6,357 jobs in 28 occupation types. Most of them are

professional and skilled jobs, including the new specified-skilled worker. The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment's vacancies page indicates that 6,035 vacancies remain available for Sri Lankans.⁵⁹

10. Canada

a. Migrant population in Canada

Although Canada reached the same scoring as Japan and, like Japan, was not in Sri Lanka's traditional pool of destinations, it falls into tenth place. Nonetheless, Canada has a significant population of foreign migrants and a significant volume of remittances globally.

According to Canada's Census data, migrants constituted a quarter of the population (23 per cent) in 2021, the highest among the G7 countries.⁶⁰ This proportion is projected to grow to around 34 per cent by 2041, at 8,049,323 persons and with more women than men among them (figures 39 and 40).

Figure 39. International migrants in Canada, by gender, 2020

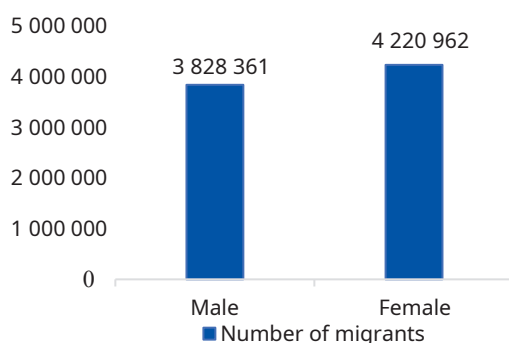
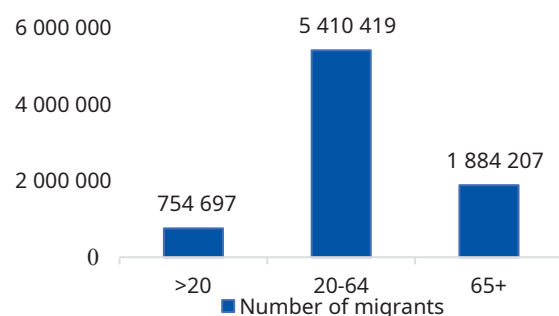


Figure 40. International migrants in Canada, by age category, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International Migration Stock 2020".

58 KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.⁵⁴

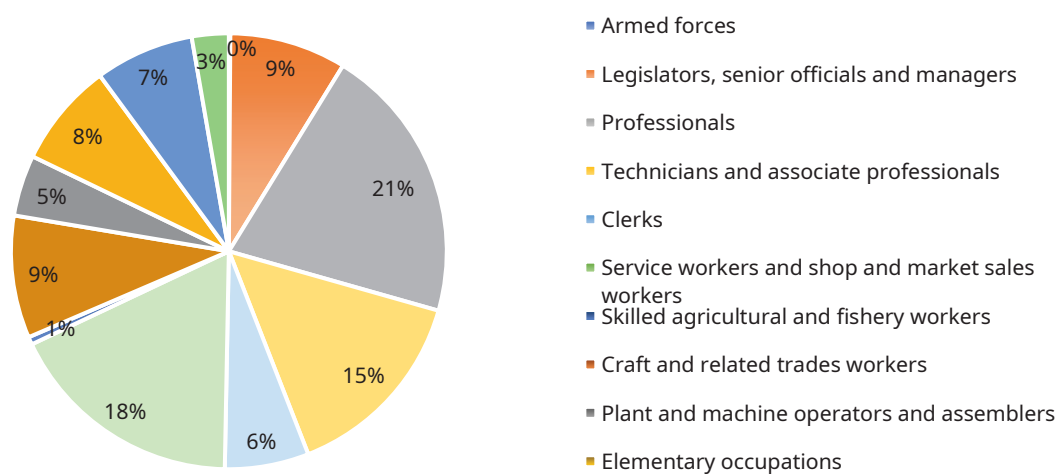
59 SLBFE, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

60 Statistics Canada, "Immigrants Make Up the Largest Share of the Population in Over 150 Years and Continue to Shape Who We Are As Canadians", 26 October 2022.

According to OECD data, the foreign-born employment rate in 2021 in Canada was 73.3 per cent, which was higher than the average for OECD countries (at 69.2 per cent). Similarly, the foreign-born labour market participation rate was higher than the OECD average, at 80.1 per cent, and 75.7 per cent, respectively, in 2021.⁶¹

Canada's Census population data for 2016 (latest available data) indicate that the majority of migrants were working in professional categories (figure 41).

Figure 41. Percentage of foreign-born population in Canada, by occupation, 2016



Source: UN DESA, "Economically Active Foreign-Born Population By Occupation, Age, Sex and Urban/Rural Residence", 2016 (latest available data).

In 2020, the top-five migrant-sending countries to Canada were India, China, Philippines, the United Kingdom and the United States (table 26).

Table 26. Top-five migrant-sending countries to Canada, 2020

Country	Migrant population
India	720 083
China	699 190
Philippines	633 547
United Kingdom	537 504
United States	273 226

Source: IOM, *World Migration Report 2022*, 2022.

61 OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2022*, 2022.

b. Migration policy in Canada⁶²

Canada offers a world-leading migration system that has evolved through several adaptations to encourage more migrants. As cited in the OECD's International Migration Outlook 2022, the Immigration Plan 2022–24 aims to increase the number of new permanent residents to around 1 per cent of the population per year. The Atlantic Immigration Programme was launched to support the growth ambition, including:

1. Overall admissions amounting to 1.1 per cent of the Canadian population by 2024.
2. A long-term focus on economic growth, with nearly 60 per cent of admissions in the Economic Class.
3. Help for vulnerable populations, like the special measures for granting permanent residence to refugee claimants working in health care during the pandemic.
4. Support for global crises by providing a safe haven through humanitarian immigration to persons facing persecution.
5. Talent retention of persons already in Canada by granting permanent status to temporary residents accepted through the time limited

pathways for essential workers launched in spring 2021.

The Economic Mobility Pathways pilot was initiated to address the labour shortage in high-demand sectors with skilled refugees. Amendments to the Citizenship Act were made, along with a special resettlement initiative for Afghans and human rights defenders. And a Canada-Ukraine Authorization for Emergency Travel was adopted.

During the pandemic period, Canada followed a unique procedure to facilitate migrants, such as shifting language training to online delivery, and allocation of resources for protection from gender-based violence during the pandemic.

Canada is working to digitalize its migration governance over the next five years. This will require investment in an enterprise-wide digital migration management platform to improve the digital tools for application processing and other businesses.

c. Labour demand and trends in Canada⁶³

Analysis of government data by CBC News highlighted that many industries had increased their number of employees between 2019 and 2022, along with their growth rate, while a few industries were reducing their production (table 27).

⁶² Source of information for this section: Government of Canada, "New Immigration Plan to Fill Labour Market Shortages and Grow Canada's Economy", Press statement, 14 February 2022; OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2022*, 2022.

⁶³ Source of information for this section: Benjamin Shingler and Graeme Bruce, "In a Tight Labour Market, This Is Where Canadian Workers Are Going", CBC, 23 August 2022.

Table 27. Growth sectors and sectors with decline in labour in Canada, 2019–22 (%)

Growth sectors		Sectors in decline	
Professional, scientific and technical services	19.5	Transportation and warehousing	-2.3
Public administration	17.1	Forestry, fishing, mining, quarrying, oil and gas	-5.1
Finance, insurance, real estate, rental and leasing	14.4	Agriculture	-10.7
Information, culture and recreation	10.3	Business, building and other support services	-11.6
Educational services	10.2	Other services (except public administration)	-12.4
Construction	6.5	Accommodation and food services	-14.2
Health care and social assistance	5		
Wholesale and retail trade	4		
Manufacturing	0.7		
Utilities	0.4		

Note: Data is for all labour, Canadian and migrant.

Source: Benjamin Shingler and Graeme Bruce, “In a Tight Labour Market, This Is Where Canadian Workers Are Going”, CBC, 23 August 2022.

According to Fabian Lange, a labour economist, many workers are climbing the job ladder towards industries with better compensation and benefits. Therefore, as the CBC report acknowledged, it may signal a trend of workers shifting from food services

and agriculture to higher-paying quality jobs in manufacturing, health care and social assistance, in line with their skills and expertise. The CBC report also cited wage increases in various industries from 2019 to 2022, such as the five highlighted in table 28.

Table 28. Top-five industries with increased wages in Canada, 2019 Q1–2022 Q1 (%)

Industry	Change in average offered hourly wage
Information and cultural industries	25
Agriculture, forestry, fishing and hunting	21
Arts, entertainment and recreation	18
Other services (except public administration)	17
Real estate and rental and leasing	16

Source: Benjamin Shingler, and Graeme Bruce, “In a Tight Labour Market, This Is Where Canadian Workers Are Going”, CBC, 23 August 2022.

Among the top-five industries, three of them are depicted in table 27 under the sectors that have grown in number of employees as well.

The CBC report stressed that Canada's labour force participation rate is steadily declining, and the leading factor driving down the rate is changing composition and characteristics of the population, such as ageing. Government statistics revealed that the population share of retirement-age persons is rapidly rising, and this requires more capable individuals for the work force. Additionally, the Canadian Government reported that the worker-to-retiree ratio will drop to only 3:1 in the future, and this as a sign of strong economic need for increased immigration.

According to government statistics, immigrants in 2021 accounted for 13 per cent of the workforce in the accommodation and food services sector, 11

per cent in the professional services sector, and 10 per cent in the manufacturing and transportation sectors. Between 2010 and 2018, there was a 35 per cent increase in earnings for all new economic immigrants. However, the government statistics also reveal challenges related to skill utilization of migrants, especially for high-skilled workers. Temporary foreign workers and international students have also become an important resource to fill the labour shortages.

d. Migration to Canada from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, only 29 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in Canada in 2021, up from 14 migrants in 2018 and 20 in 2019. Among them, only seven were women (figures 42 and 43).

Figure 42. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Canada, 2021

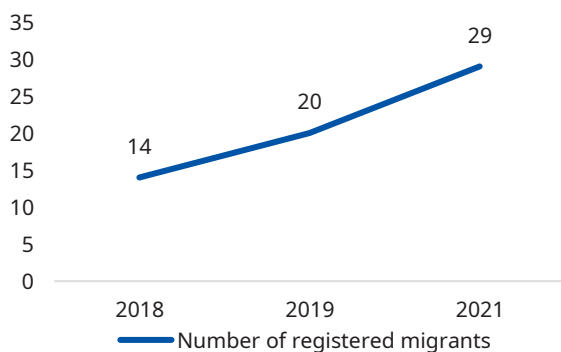
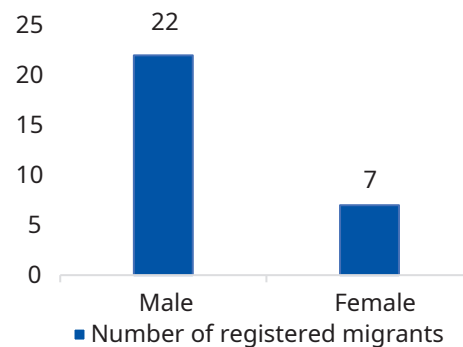


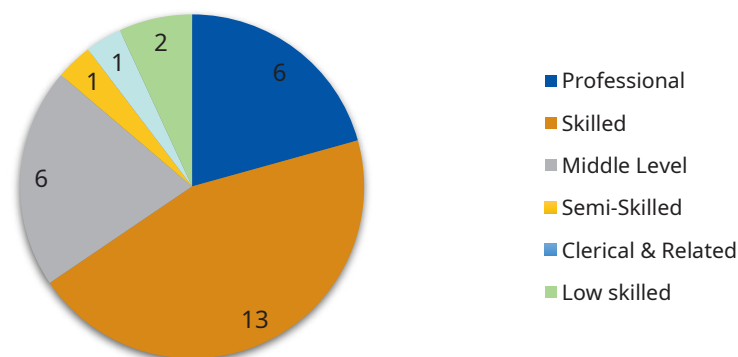
Figure 43. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Canada, by gender, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

The largest proportion of migrants in Canada who were registered with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment in 2021 had jobs in the skilled category (figure 44).

Figure 44. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants to Canada, by skill category, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, remittances from Canada to Sri Lanka placed it among the top-five destination countries, at US\$402 million in 2021.⁶⁴

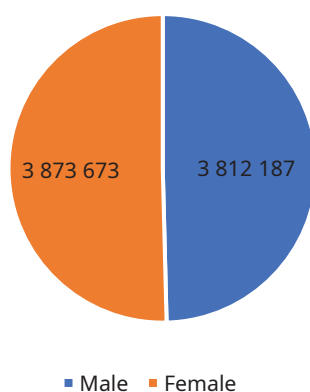
The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment's vacancies webpage lists two job categories with 32 positions available for Sri Lankan migrants.⁶⁵

11. Australia

a. Migrant population in Australia

According to UN DESA statistics, Australia had 7,685,860 foreign migrants in 2020, with 3,812,187 men and 3,873,673 women (figure 45).

Figure 45. International migrants in Australia, by gender, 2020



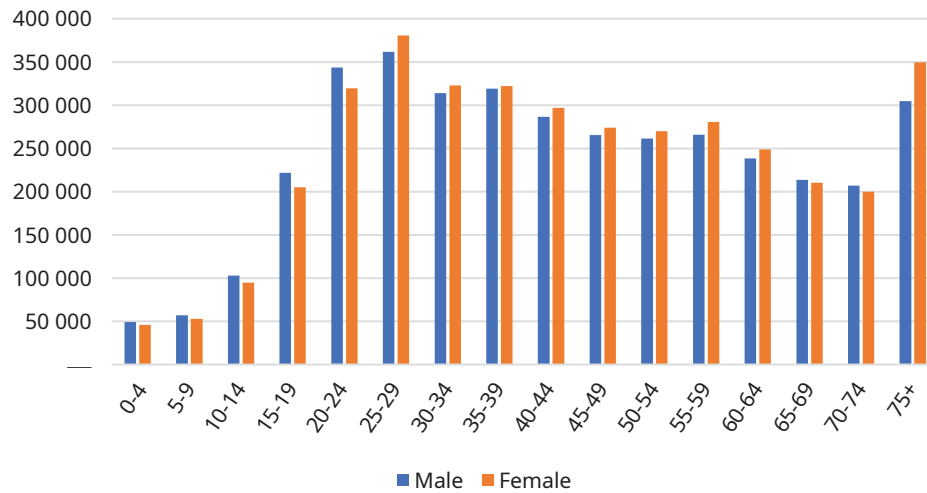
Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International migration stock 2020".

⁶⁴ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

⁶⁵ SLBFE, Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

As figure 46 indicates, most of the migrants in 2020 were aged 25–29.

Figure 46. International migrant population in Australia, by age and gender, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, “International Migration Stock 2020”.

The decline in the net migration rate in Australia has been around 4 per cent for the past four years (2020–2023 (table 29).

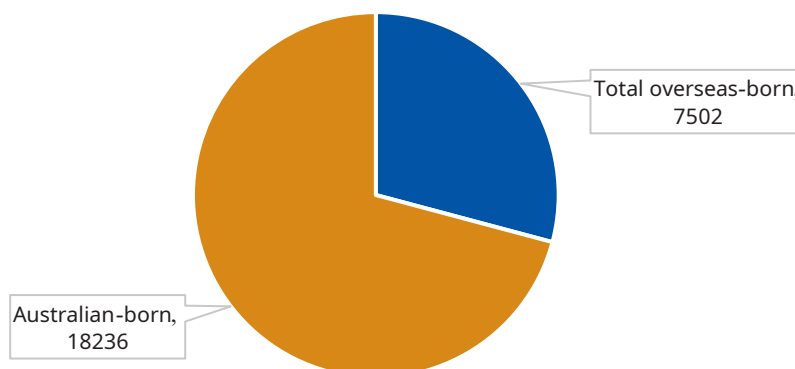
Table 29. Net migration rate in Australia, 2020–23

Year	Net migration rate	Decline compared to previous year (%)
2020	5.911	4
2021	5.665	4.16
2022	5.419	4.34
2023	5.173	4.54

Source: See MacroTrends, “Australia Net Migration Rate 1950–2023”.

Around 29 per cent of the Australian population in 2021 were born elsewhere (figure 47).

Figure 47. Australian-born population compared with migrants born overseas, 2021

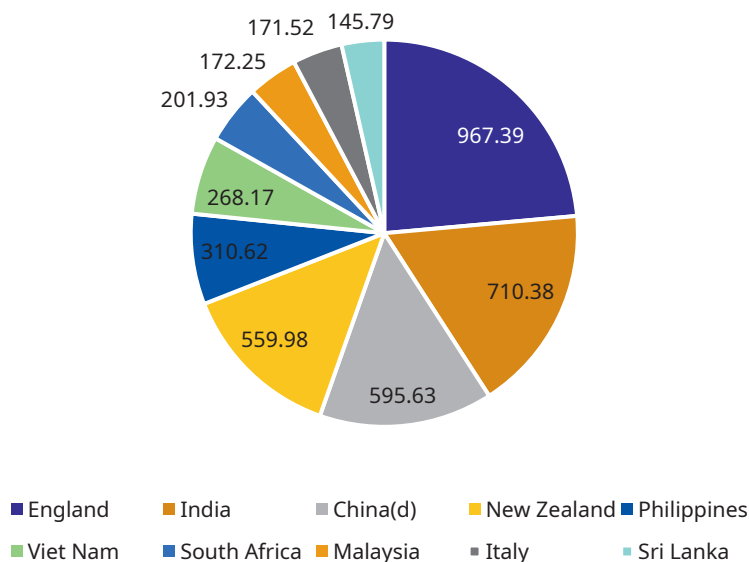


Source: Australian Bureau of Statistics, “Australia’s Population By Country of Birth, 2021”.

Among the people born outside of Australia, England led in terms of numbers, at 967,000, followed by India, China and New Zealand (figure 48). The English

population had decreased from slightly more than 1 million per year from 2012 to 2016. Sri Lanka ranked tenth in 2021, with 145,790 migrants.

Figure 48. Australia’s overseas-born population, by top-ten countries of birth, 2021 (thousands)



Source: Australian Bureau of Statistics, “Australia’s Population By Country of Birth, 2021”.

b. Migration policy in Australia

Australia’s migration policy consists of a humanitarian component and a migration component. The humanitarian component mainly focuses on people migrating for asylum, including refugees who have entered Australia legally and are in need of protection and refugees who enter illegally.

The migration component of the immigration policy is categorized in three parts:

- **Special Eligibility:** available for individuals who were connected with Australia in the past, for example, people born in Australia but raised elsewhere or previous citizens of Australia.

- Skilled migration: given much significance due to labour shortages.
- Family stream: or family migration represents that Australia supports families.

Australia's Permanent Migration Program aims to balance a range of economic, social and demographic objectives and priorities while focusing on its longer-term national interests.

c. Labour demand and trends in Australia⁶⁶

In the past couple of years, Australia's labour landscape has undergone significant transformation due to the global impact of the COVID-19 pandemic presenting challenges to businesses and various job sectors in the country.

The following sectors are identified as declining job industries in Australia for 2023.

- telephone operators and mobile customer service, currently in decline due to the innovation of answering machines and the internet;
- door-to-door sales workers: not in high demand due to online shopping and sales;
- retail work;
- agriculture and farming; and
- manufacturing, in decline due to the technological advances in machinery.

Health care, education and training, construction, professional, scientific and technical industries and the travel and tourism industry are growing industries in Australia.

With Australia's increasing life expectancy as well as the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic, Australia has increased its demand for health care professionals. The top-three specialty health care jobs in demand in 2023 are caregivers for older persons and persons with disabilities, registered nurses and physiotherapists. Demand for these jobs is expected to continue.

Education and training are considered as always in demand of workers despite technological advances. The top-three specific jobs in high demand in 2022 and 2023 were primary school teachers, university lecturers and tutors, and childcare educators.

With the prevailing and future demand for better infrastructure and the increase in demand for housing, the construction industry requires plenty of specialized skilled people. Despite concerns about potential automation replacing construction labour in the future, the demand for construction-focused initiatives supersedes such apprehensions. The leading four construction jobs in demand in 2023 and expected in the near future are electricians, plumbers, construction managers and concreters.

Software and applications programmers, ICT managers and ICT support technician jobs are considered as the most in demand for the future in the category of professional scientific and technical.⁶⁷

d. Migration to Australia from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, 14 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in Australia in 2021, far fewer than the 40 in 2018 and in 2019, but double the number for 2020.

⁶⁶ Source of information for this section: Victoria University, "10 In-demand Careers for the Future".

⁶⁷ Mallory, "Information Technology Jobs and Descriptions", n.d.

Table 30. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Australia, 2021

Year	Male	Female
2016	7	2
2017	5	-
2018	43	0
2019	38	2
2020	6	1
2021	13	1

Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

12. France

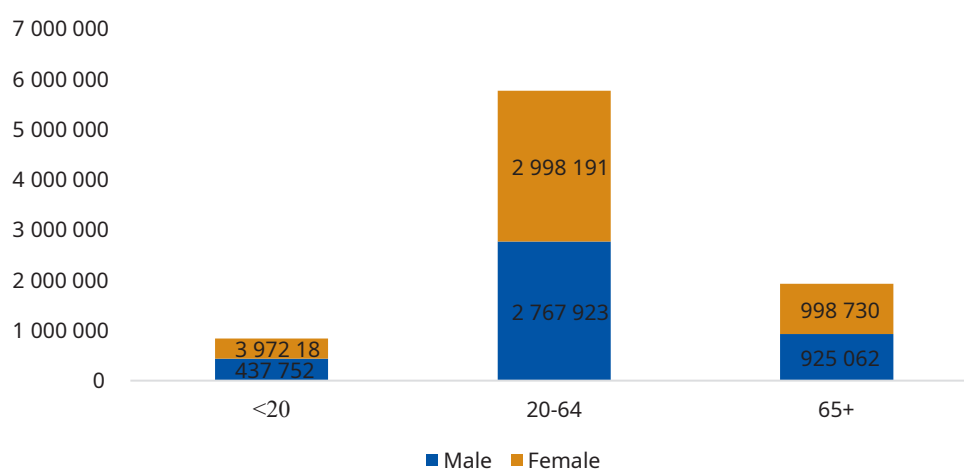
a. Migrant population in France

In the scoring system used for this study, France placed within the top-ten countries in terms of remittances to Sri Lanka but it did not fare highly in the other two criteria, thus landing twelfth among the fifteen countries in terms of potential for skilled and professional Sri Lankan migrants.

According to the *World Migration Report 2022*, France is the seventh-largest destination country for international migrants. According to the French National Institute of Statistics and Economic Studies,

the 2021 Census counted nearly 7 million immigrants (foreign-born people) in France, representing 10.3 per cent of the total population.⁶⁸

According to the UN DESA statistics on the international migrant population), 8,524,876 migrants lived in France in 2020. Of them, 4,130,737 were men and 4,394,139 were women, with more than half of them (5,766,114) of in working age, 20–64, (figure 49).

Figure 49. International migrants in France, by age, 2020

Source: UN DESA, Population Division, "International migration stock 2020".

68 French National Institute of Statistics and Economic Studies, "Immigration to France", n.d.

The net migration rate for France in 2022 was 0.883 per 1,000 population, a 9.96 per cent increase from 2021.⁶⁹

In 2018, France received 277,000 new migrants on a long-term or permanent basis. Of them, 30 per cent had benefited from free mobility within the Europe, 14.5 per cent were declared labour migrants, 36.7 per cent were family members, and 11 per cent were

humanitarian migrants. The labour participation rate for foreign-born individuals was 67.8 per cent and employment rate for them was 58.9 per cent in 2019.

The top-three migrant-sending countries to France in 2020 (latest available data) were Algeria (853,466), Morocco (802,806) and Portugal (601,762).

Table 31. Immigrants in France, by country of birth, 2020

Country of birth	Migrant population
Algeria	853 466
Morocco	802 806
Portugal	601 762
Other countries of Europe	482 942
Tunisia	302 379

Source: French National Institute of Statistics and Economic Studies, “Immigrants By Country of Birth – Immigrants and Immigrant Descendants”.

Of the 1,673,200 foreign nationals in the workforce in 2018, the largest sector – comprising almost 300,000 people – was services, such as security and cleaning of professional premises, hairdressing, housekeeping and home help. This was followed

by the construction industry, where 247,300 foreign workers were employed. Table 32 lists most in-demand jobs in France, in order, with the salary range, and a comparison with the highest-paid jobs.

Table 32. Most-in-demand jobs in France and highly paid jobs, 2023

Most in-demand jobs	Salary range (per year)	Highly paid jobs	Average annual salary
1. Insurance agent	€40 000–€60 000	Surgeons and doctor	€184 000
2. Software engineer	€40 000–€60 000	Judge	€155 000
3. Data analyst	€35 000–€75 000	Lawyer	€125 000
4. Childcare specialist	€10 000–€25 000	Bank manager	€118 000
5. School teacher	€25 000–€45 000	Chief executive officer	€111 000
6. Nurse	€30 000–€55 000	Chief financial officer	€103 000
7. Front-end web developer	€35 000–€50 000	Orthodontist	€99 500
8. IT technician	€37 000–€50 000	College professor	€88 500
9. Real estate agent	€25 000–€53 000	Pilot	€73 700
10. Project manager	€50 000–€80 000	Marketing director	€66 400

Source: Grabjobs.co, “Top 15 Most In-demand Jobs in France in 2023”; Salary Explorer, “Best Paying Jobs in France”, 2023.

69 MacroTrends, “France Net Migration Rate 1950–2023”, n.d.

b. Migration policy in France

The 2018 law prolonged the validity of the “talent passport” residence permit, initially established by a 2016 law, to four years. Family members (spouse and children) can obtain this permit without undergoing a family reunification process. In December 2019, a circular was dispatched to prefectures proposing organizational enhancement for application processing. The Government revealed plans to institute a sector specific professional immigration policy, aligning with the updated regional Shortage Occupational Lists (not updated since 2008).⁷⁰

France intends to introduce a residence permit for undocumented workers already within the country, specifically tailored for occupations facing labour shortages. This initiative will be accompanied by measures aimed at streamlining deportation procedures.

c. Labour demand and trends in France

The most sought-after professions in France for foreigners are in the fields of agriculture and tourism. For example, harvesters for grapes and

other fruit crops are needed and the tourism sector requires waiters, maids, bartenders, instructors, guides and assistant cooks.⁷¹ Mostly it is work in bars, cafes, restaurants, hotels, camping sites and ski resorts. Although France is an extremely popular tourist destination, the travel and tourism sector is reportedly experiencing a severe labour shortage – according to the World Travel and Tourism Council, around 70,000 jobs remain unfilled across the country.⁷²

Housekeepers, nannies and caregivers, deemed low-skilled, are in demand in France. There are opportunities in construction sites for men as electricians, carpenters, plumbers, painters and handymen.

As per information from local employment agencies, the sought-after occupations in France in 2023 include machine operators, carpenters, butchers and programmers. Similar to global trends, there is a demand for skilled engineers and construction workers. Overall, the French labour market is currently grappling with a significant shortage of qualified personnel (table 33).

Table 33. Occupations with labour shortages in France, 2023

1 Engineer (different directions)

2 Marketing manager

3 Butcher

4 Machine operator

5 Carpenter

6 Programmer (different directions)

7 Worker in agriculture

8 Builder (different directions)

9 Social worker

10 Specialist in tourism

Source: : Data from the French employment agency and international recruitment agencies, see Wage Centre, “Shortage Occupations in France in 2023”.

⁷⁰ OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2020*, 2020.

⁷¹ Wage Centre, “Shortage Occupations in France in 2023”.

⁷² Shengen Visa News, “70,000 Jobs Remain Unfilled in France’s Travel & Tourism Sector, WTTC Says”, 3 August 2022.

The designated minimum wage in France stands at €1,709.28 per month, with an hourly rate of €11.27. As of 2023, the average monthly salary in the country hovers around €3,085 or €2,400 net, while income tax varies from 14 per cent to 45 per cent. Notably, the highest earning occupations include practicing doctors and management companies representing large business.⁷³

d. Migration to France from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, only two Sri Lankans registered as

migrant workers in France in 2021, which was up from one in 2018 and 2020 (with two in 2019). According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website, there are no vacancies available for Sri Lankans in France.⁷⁴

According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, US\$155 million in remittances to Sri Lanka originated in France in 2021.⁷⁵

13. Singapore

a. Migrant population in Singapore

In the scoring system for this study, Singapore placed eighteenth in top remitters to Sri Lanka and thirteenth among destination countries for Sri Lankan migrations, thus landing it in the thirteenth slot among the 15 countries analysed for their potential for skilled and professional migrants.

More than 2.5 million international migrants lived in Singapore as of mid-2020, accounting for 43 per cent of the total population, according to UN DESA data. Of them, 1,411,131 were women (55.9 per cent). Around 326,151 migrants were aged between 40 and 44 years, with nearly as many (316,466 persons) aged 45–49. Nearly 27,000 migrants were children aged up to 4 years.

Singapore's migration policy allows so many workers of every skill level, thus 47 per cent of all residents in 2017 were foreign-born. In 2020 and at more than 1.13 million persons, Malaysians were the largest

group of Asian migrants in Singapore. Chinese migrants were also present in large numbers, at 426,434 people. Indonesians followed, at 159,685, while Indians numbered 144,970 and Pakistanis numbered 126,848. The smallest group of migrants were Sri Lankans, at 10,767.

People from these areas tend to move to Singapore mainly because of the high salaries and good opportunities and due to geographical proximity. By mid-2020, Singapore was among the top-ten countries of destination for migrants in Asia and the Pacific. The net migration rate for Singapore in 2022 was 4.570 per 1,000 population, which was a 0.85 per cent decline from 2021.

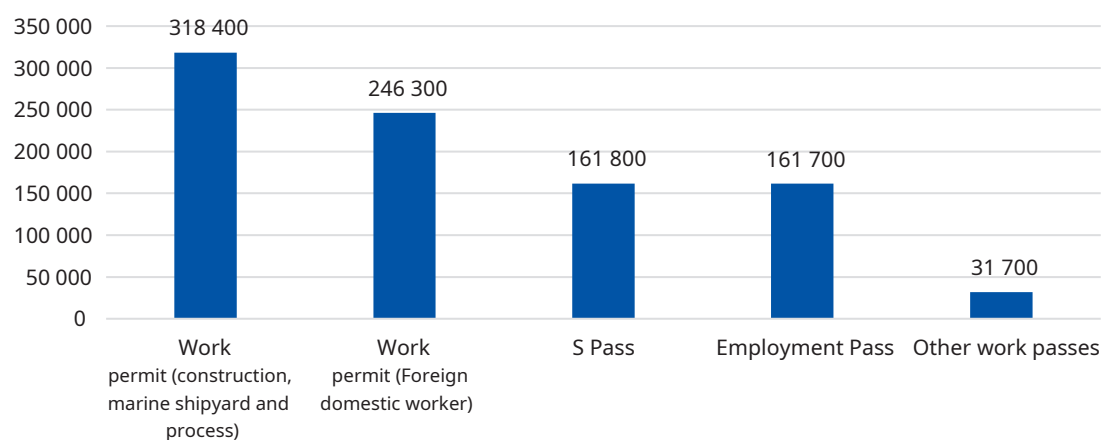
Figure 50 shows the breakdown of foreign workers in Singapore in 2021, by work permit, with the largest grouping, at 318,400 migrants with a work permit, in construction, marine shipyard and process sectors.

⁷³ See Wage Centre, "Shortage Occupations in France in 2023".

⁷⁴ SLBFE, "Foreign job Vacancies", n.d.

⁷⁵ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

Figure 50. Foreign workers in Singapore by work permit, 2021



Source: Statista, “Singapore: Foreign Workforce Breakdown By Type”, 2021.

b. Migration policy in Singapore

Singapore’s migration policies have evolved over the years. An exemption is now available to engage in certain short-term activities without a work permit. Otherwise, a work permit is required to engage in any employment, trade, vocation or profession. Applying for a work permit is a relatively smooth and uncomplicated process that takes about three weeks. The Ministry of Manpower issues the following permits to live and work in Singapore:

1. A work permit for low- and semi-skilled workers, domestic workers, nannies (restricted to Malaysian citizens) and performing artists employed by eligible public entertainment outlets.
2. An S Pass for mid-level skilled technical workers.
3. The most-common visa is the Employment Pass for skilled and professional immigrants who are managers, executives and highly paid or highly skilled individuals or individuals who are both highly paid and highly skilled. Immigrants on the Employment Pass who are more skilled and educated also are more highly paid. In addition, those with an Employment Pass must have good professional qualifications, such as a university degree or specialized skills.

4. A personalized Employment Pass is for high-earning professionals, managers and executives.
5. An Entry Pass is for entrepreneurs intending to start new businesses in Singapore that contribute to local employment.

Employment Passes – the type of work permit that is most relevant for corporate immigration – are issued for 12–24 months at a time in the first instance. They may be renewed – typically for 12, 24 or 36 months, at the discretion of the issuing authority – as early as six months prior to expiry. Early renewal involves no loss or wastage of the validity period of the holder’s current pass.

c. Labour demand and trends in Singapore⁷⁶

Professional and business immigration have been a feature of the economy since the 1980s. Highly skilled migrants enter the country increasingly due to the high-tech and knowledge-intensive industries.

Singapore wanted to develop as a global city and thus attract foreign talent. “Foreign talent” refers to university-qualified foreigners with advanced skills working in high-paid professions, such as the financial, information technology, engineering, architecture, artistic and education sectors that add

⁷⁶ Source of information for this section: Association for Asian Studies, *Singapore Immigration and Changing Public Policies*, 2017; Joyce Teo, “24k More Nurses, Healthcare Staff Needed by 2030 as S’pore Ages”, *The Straits Times*, 5 October 2022.

value to the economy and provide cultural capital. In the past, skilled professionals came from the United States, Canada, France, Australia and the United Kingdom. Nowadays, foreign talent also hails from China or India and other South-East Asian countries. The Government is looking to expand the professional categories for foreign talent to include mid- and lower-level white-collar positions.

One important category of low-skilled foreign workers in Singapore are female domestic workers, whose job it is to care for children, clean, cook and generally tend to the needs of whole households. They come from Philippines, Indonesia, Myanmar and Cambodia.

Workers in the construction industry are another significant group of low-skilled migrants, coming mainly from India, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Philippines, Myanmar, Thailand and China. There are massive infrastructure projects affected by the labour shortages in the construction sector.

One in four Singapore citizens will be aged 65 or older by 2030 (about 18.4 per cent of Singaporeans

were in that age group in 2022, up from 11.1 per cent in 2012). This reality will positively affect the situation for foreign labour. The number and role of foreign nurses will grow, for instance. Already, 24,000 more nurses and other health care staff are needed by 2030. The majority of foreign nurses currently in the country are from the Philippines, Malaysia, China, India, Myanmar and other countries. The Government is also trying to grow its pool of family physicians to meet its target of 3,500 by 2030.

d. Migration to Singapore from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, 1,184 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in Singapore in 2021, which was a decline from the 1,918 in 2018 and the 2,124 in 2019 but up from the 763 in 2020. Singapore was among the top-15 destinations for Sri Lankan labour for 2021. Among the total registered migrants in 2021, more than 57 per cent were men, with women accounting for 42 per cent of them. According to the skill categories of registered migrants, the majority of them had low skills (table 34).

Table 34. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants to Singapore, by skill category, 2021

Category	No. of registered migrant workers
Professional	227
Skilled	314
Middle level	70
Semi-skilled	127
Clerical & Related	7
Low-skilled	434

Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, US\$35 million in remittances to Sri Lanka originated in Singapore in 2021.⁷⁷

Singapore invited Sri Lankans to apply for 9,959 vacancies in 49 occupation types. According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment's vacancies webpage, only 512 positions have been filled.⁷⁸

⁷⁷ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

⁷⁸ SLBFE, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

14. Italy

a. Migrant population in Italy

Italy placed fourteenth among the total 15 countries, despite not traditionally in the pool of popular destinations. But it clearly now offers huge potential for Sri Lankan migrant workers. The country ranks highly in terms of migrant populations and remittances to Sri Lanka, even though only a few Sri Lankan migrants heading to Italy have registered with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment over the past few years.

According to UN DESA statistics, a total of 6,386,998 migrants lived in Italy in 2020, constituting 10 per cent portion of the population and with more women than men. Most of the migrant population was aged 20–64 (figures 51 and 52).

Figure 51. International migrants in Italy, by gender, 2020

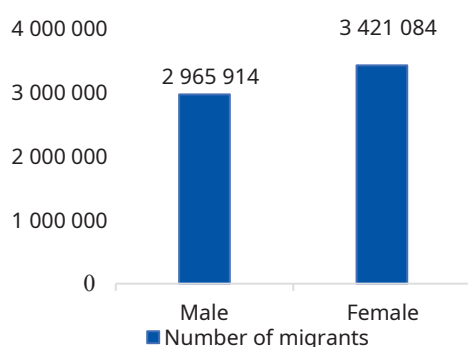
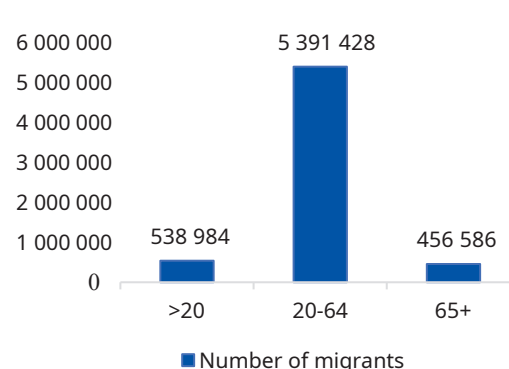


Figure 52. International migrants in Italy, by age category, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, “International Migration Stock 2020”.

As OECD statistics indicate, the labour market participation rate of foreign-born persons in 2021 in Italy was 68.2 per cent, which was quite lower than the average (75.7 per cent) for OECD countries. The foreign-born employment rate (at 59.3 per cent)

also was lower than the average OECD rate (at 69.2 per cent).⁷⁹ And as reported in the World Migration Report 2022, the top-five migrant-sending countries to Italy in 2020 were Romania, Albania, Morocco, Ukraine and China (table 35).

Table 35. Top-five migrant-sending countries to Italy, 2020

Country	Migrant population
Romania	1 048 862
Albania	486 187
Morocco	451 960
Ukraine	248 460
China	233 338

Source: IOM, *World Migration Report 2022*, 2022.

79 OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2022*, 2022.

b. Migration policy in Italy⁸⁰

Italy became a popular migration destination country during 1970–80. Since then, the foreign population has regularly increased. Various government administrations made attempts to regularize the migration process during 1986–2002. Due to polarized political debate, lack of proper developed administrative structures and weak implementation capacities, the migrant recruitment remained an inefficient process, and irregular migrants working in the informal economy increased. More attempts have been made (in 2009, 2012 and 2020) to reform the migration policy.

According to the OECD International Migration Outlook 2021 and 2022, the recent migrant policy changes are due to the change of Government and the COVID-19 pandemic. The reforms have included regularization of irregular migrants and changes to the annual quota for seasonal and non-seasonal workers. A national plan to address exploitation and illegal recruitment in the agriculture sector was adopted; it covers all workers in the agriculture sector, including migrants who are irregular workers and need protection. The reforms encompass labour protection, enforcement and exploitation prevention. The number of residence permits were increased for study reasons, special protection, religious reasons, calamities, elective residence, artistic activities and for persons awaiting citizenship. The maximum duration of granting Italian citizenship was reduced to 24 months.

In response to the pandemic situation, Italy took several measures to regularize foreign workers who had been in the country before 8 March 2020.

This involved issuing new contracts or a temporary residence permit (if a previous one had expired after October 2019) for citizens of non-European Union countries in agriculture, fisheries and related activities or in domestic work or caregiving services.

c. Labour demand and trends in Italy

The Italian economy consists of a few major economic sectors: services, manufacturing, construction and agriculture. In terms of employment status, the most general type of contract is fixed term and full-time appointments. The most required qualification in the labour market is an upper-secondary school diploma. Like many countries, the labour market is experiencing a quick improvement from the pandemic period. For instance, along with gross domestic product growth, there was an increased labour force participation rate and reduced unemployment rate and a reduction in the number of jobseekers in 2022. Due to the uncertainty of economic trends and supply of raw materials because of the war in Ukraine, some economic sectors have slowed their progress, such as manufacturing and construction. Services is remaining strong, along with the recovery of the tourism industry.

Thus, the 2022 forecast for labour demand revealed a requirement of 1,531,450 workers for the services sector (business, tourism, catering) and 322,400 new recruitments for the industry sector. The 2022 job demand were jobs that primarily required a secondary education qualification.⁸¹ Table 36 indicates the most difficult-to-recruit employment categories per each education level.

80 Source of information for this section: Claudia Finotelli, "Migration and migration policy in Italy", bpb, 4 April 2022; OECD, International Migration Outlook 2022, 2022; OECD, *International Migration Outlook 2021*, 2021.

81 EURES, "Italy Is Looking For You!", 2022.

Table 36. Most difficult-to-fill categories per each education attainment level in Italy, 2022

Tertiary level	Vocational level	Secondary level
• Dentistry • Health care • Paramedical • Mathematical • Physical • Computer science	• Textile and clothing • Motor vehicle repair • Electricians • Well-being sector	• Mechanics • Mechatronics • Energy • Electronics and electrical engineering • IT and telecommunications • Industrial and craft production and maintenance

Source: See European Job Days, “Italy”.

Table 37 highlights the sectors that may benefit from the Government’s push for the green economy concept and thus a higher demand to fill modern job opportunities (green jobs).

Table 37. Sectors in Italy that could generate high demand for workers with green economy skills

Construction sector

Sustainable architect

Designers of sustainable buildings

Installers of low environmental-impact air-conditioning systems; for mechanics

Experts in electric motor systems and/or component technologies; for the environment

Environmental IT specialists to develop environmental software and applications

Environmental lawyers, mobility managers, energy managers and eco-designers

Source: See Europa, “Labour Market Information: Italy”.

The Government’s forecasting for 2022–26 acknowledged that workers are needed: 40,000 ICT technicians; 30,000 mathematics and computer science specialists; 120,000–130,000 technicians in organizational and financial activities; 50,000 environmental engineers and architects; 220,000 workers specializing in construction and the maintenance of building structures and construction

finishers; and 25,000 construction engineers and technicians.⁸²

In addition, the forecast emphasized the importance of reducing female unemployment, which was reportedly the highest among the Europe countries, at 9.9 per cent in 2021.⁸³

⁸² Ibid

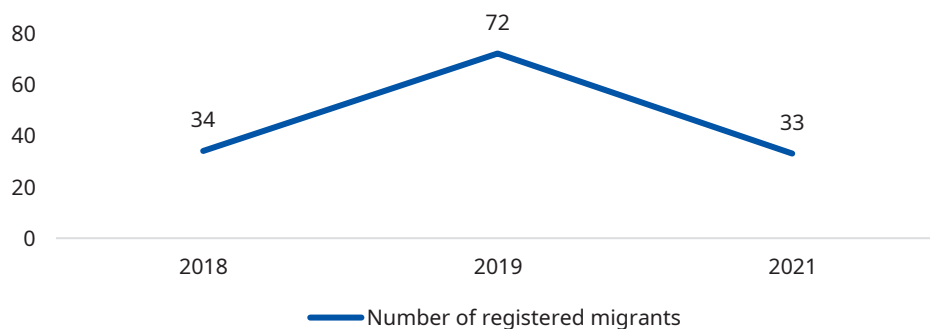
⁸³ Ibid

d. Migration to Italy from Sri Lanka

Italy's latest Census statistics refer to 1,936 immigrants from Sri Lanka in 2021, with 915 men and 1,021 women. However, the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics contain only record of 33 Sri Lankan migrant workers in Italy in 2021, with

18 men and 13 women (figures 53 and 54). (Those same records showed 34 registered migrants in 2018 and 72 in 2019.) This emphasizes the need for Sri Lanka to increase the number of migrants to Italy and the importance of regular reliable data on the migrant outflow.

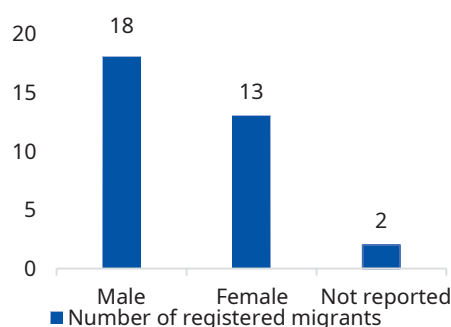
Figure 53. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Italy, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

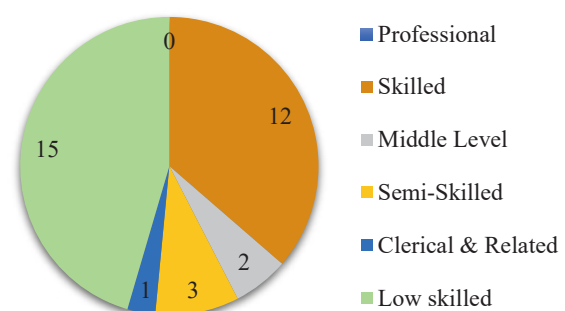
The few migrants registered with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment were in low-skilled jobs (figure 55).

Figure 54. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Italy, by gender, 2021



Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

Figure 55. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in Italy, by skill category, 2021



According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, Italy emerged in the top-ten of countries with a large remittance total to Sri Lanka, despite the few Sri Lankan migrants, at US\$264 million.⁸⁴

On the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment vacancies webpage, there are no available vacancies for Italy.⁸⁵

⁸⁴ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

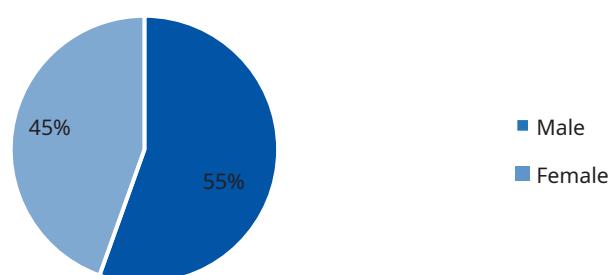
⁸⁵ SLBFE, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

15. Republic of Korea

a. Migrant population in the Republic of Korea

According to UN DESA statistics on the international migrant population, 1,728,182 migrants lived in the Republic of Korea in 2020. Of them, 958,365 were men, and 769,817 were women (figure 56).

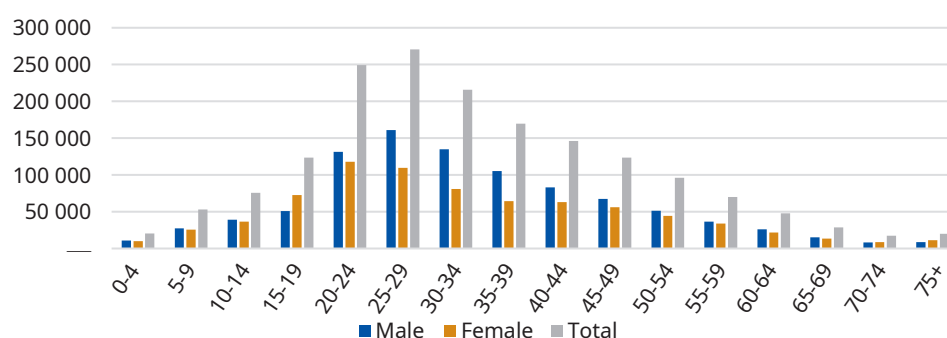
Figure 56. International migrants in the Republic of Korea, by gender, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, “International Migration Stock 2020”.

Most of the male migrants were aged 25–29, while the majority of female migrants were aged 20–24 (figure 57).

Figure 57. International migrants in the Republic of Korea, by age category, 2020



Source: UN DESA, Population Division, “International Migration Stock 2020”.

Table 38 presents net migration rate of the Republic of Korea for the past four years.

Table 38. Net migration rate in the Republic of Korea, 2020–23

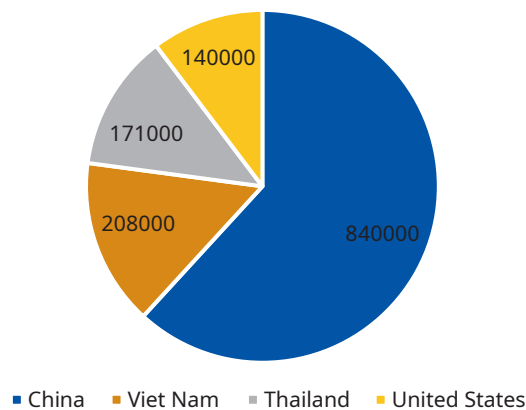
Year	Net migration rate	Decline, compared to previous year (%)
2020	0.294	12.21
2021	0.326	10.88
2022	0.358	9.82
2023	0.39	8.94

Source: See MacroTrends, “South Korea Net Migration Rate 1950–2023”.

In 2020, the Republic of Korea received 54,000 new immigrants on a long-term or permanent basis, which was a reduction of 28.2 per cent from 2019. It comprised 2.5 per cent of labour migrants, 38.9 per cent family members (including accompanying family) and 0.4 per cent humanitarian migrants. Around 28,000 permits were issued to tertiary-level international students and 49,000 permits to temporary and seasonal labour migrants.

The largest group of migrants in the Republic of Korea in 2021 (figure 58) were from China (840,000 migrants, or 43 per cent), with the second-largest from Viet Nam (208,000 migrants), followed by Thailand (171,000 migrants) and the United States (140,000 migrants).

Figure 58. Number of migrants living in the Republic of Korea, by country of origin, 2021



Source: The Korea Bizwire, “Number of Foreigners Staying in S. Korea Decreased 3.9 pct in 2021 Amid Pandemic”, 26 January 2021.

b. Migration policy in the Republic of Korea⁸⁶

There are three categories of foreign workers according to their visa status in the Republic of Korea:

1. non-professional foreign workers;
2. overseas Korean workers; and
3. overseas professionals.

Non-professional foreign workers are primarily recruited through the Employ Permit System, which allows workers into the country for a short period of time and promotes their circular movement. The Government introduced the Employ Permit System in 2004 to help small and medium-sized enterprises find unskilled workers, mostly in the manufacturing, agriculture and fishery sectors. The labour market is facing a conundrum in which the labour force is shrinking due to the ageing population but, although the younger generation is more qualified than the older generations, and they are not showing interest in taking the jobs left open by retiring workers. They see those jobs as the difficult, dangerous or dirty jobs, mostly work in the agriculture, manufacturing and fisheries that require no skill. The professional labour market is extremely competitive, which is where the highly qualified younger generation seek to compete for employment, leaving a considerable labour shortage in the non-professional jobs. Although a few large conglomerates dominate the economy, 99 per cent of establishments are small and medium-sized are struggling to reduce their labour shortages.

The Employment Permit System supports such enterprises to fill their labour gap with foreign workers. The Government facilitates between them and the sending countries and agents to channel foreign workers to where labour is needed. There are currently 16 countries in the Employment Permit System as sending countries, including Sri Lanka, Mongolia, Nepal, Philippines, Thailand and Viet Nam.

For the overseas professional category, there are seven visa types, from E1 to E7. The E7 category is further divided on varying levels of professional categories.

E-1 Professors

E-2 Native language teachers

E-3 Research and development researchers

E-4 Technicians involved in technical transfers

E-5 Persons professionally qualified

E-6 Entertainers

E-7 Professional workers

- E-7-1 Professional
- E-7-2 Semi-professional
- E-7-3 General skilled worker
- E-7-4 Skilled worker under scoring system

In 2019, the Government significantly revised its visa regulations, primarily aimed at luring international talent to address the labour shortages within small and medium-sized enterprises. These changes in immigration policies were a strategic move to attract skilled professionals to the country. The focus of these alterations centred on professional and semi-professional positions, primarily under the E-7 visa category. As part of this update, applicants are now required to provide authenticated work experience and educational degree certificates.

In 2021, reforms in labour migration policy were made to address the sectoral labour shortages due to the COVID-19 pandemic. In November 2021, limits on daily and weekly entries under the Employment Permit System workers were lifted and the Government resumed issuing the permits in high-risk countries.

Current legislation allows migrant workers to change their job with the permission of their employer, and work contracts must be renewed each year. The Employment Permit System still restricts the employment of foreigners through regulations concerning the location and period of employment. Foreign workers are allowed to remain employed for

⁸⁶ Source of information for this section: Bongsoo Jung, "Korean Immigration: The System for Employing Foreign Workers", LinkedIn, 8 October 2022; Amnesty International, Protect the Rights of Migrants in South Korea, 25 November 2006.

a maximum of five years, and the number of foreign workers introduced is adjusted annually, depending on the labour market conditions.

c. Labour demand and trends in the Republic of Korea⁸⁷

Jobs in small and medium-sized enterprises in the manufacturing sector are unattractive to Koreans. This is pushing some sectors to fully rely on migrant workers, especially in farms and factories. The Government hopes to attract 110,000 migrant workers in 2023, although far more workers are needed.

The Republic of Korea is one of the world's fastest-ageing societies, although around 33.1 per cent of the population aged 70–74 are still working. Its ageing population is a major challenge. The Central Bank reported that more than 230,000 people aged 60 or older have found jobs in factories and construction sites since early 2020, while younger people are leaving those sectors. The country's foreign worker pool of 848,000 is relatively small compared with other industrialized economies. Immigrants make an important contribution to the factory sector.⁸⁸

Additionally, the shrinking male population is another huge challenge for the country. The population decline is a major contributing factor to the need for immigration, which is growing. The current supply of migrant labour is not sufficient.

There is high demand for English speakers in the Republic of Korea, especially for English teaching in schools, tuition centres and colleges as well as big companies. The salary for such jobs ranges from US\$1,200 to US\$4,000 per month, depending on the position, experience and skills.

Migrants with English and Korean proficiency have opportunities as a translator, interpreter, content creator and other work. There are also plenty of job opportunities in the manufacturing, automobile, information technology, health care and finance sectors – along with lower-skilled jobs. The Employment Permit System seeks workers in construction, fisheries, manufacturing, agriculture and various heavy and light industries.

The Government has signed MOUs with the 16 countries in the Employment Permit System whose citizens are eligible to apply for the available jobs. The Government increased the quota for the E-7-4 category visa to 30,000 in 2023, up from 5,000, due to the labour shortages in the agriculture and manufacturing sectors.

d. Migration to the Republic of Korea from Sri Lanka

According to the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, 1,428 Sri Lankans registered as migrant workers in the Republic of Korea in 2021, far fewer than the 5,410 in 2018 and the 6,207 in 2019.

⁸⁷ Source of information for this section: Cynthia Kim, "Korea Inc's Foreign Labour Crunch Puts Older Workers Back in Factories", Reuters, 16 August 2022; Joy of Korean, "Ultimate 2023 Guide to Jobs in South Korea for Foreigners", 3 November 2023; World Economic Forum, "Chart: South Korea's Population is Ageing and Shrinking", 3 March 2021.

⁸⁸ Cynthia Kim, "Korea Inc's Foreign Labour Crunch Puts Older Workers Back in Factories", Reuters, 16 August 2022.

Table 39. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the Republic of Korea, by gender, 2021

Year	Male	Female
2016	8 559	71
2017	5 756	51
2018	5 354	56
2019	6 166	41
2020	1 274	17
2021	1 424	4

Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

Among the total registered migrants in 2021, more than 99 per cent were men (table 39), and most were in low-skill jobs (table 40).

Table 40. Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment-registered migrants in the Republic of Korea, by their skill category, 2021

Skill category	No. of registered migrants
Professional	1
Skilled	17
Middle level	1
Semi-skilled	0
Clerical & Related	1
Low-skilled	1 408

Source: Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment statistics, 2021.

According to KNOMAD's bilateral remittance matrix, US\$91 million in remittances to Sri Lanka originated in the Republic of Korea.⁸⁹

The Korean Government invited Sri Lankans to apply for 1,858 vacancies in three occupation

types. According to the updated Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment vacancies webpage, 1,463 vacancies remain available.⁹⁰

⁸⁹ KNOMAD, "Bilateral Remittance Matrix 2021", n.d.

⁹⁰ SLBFE, "Foreign Job Vacancies", n.d.

► 3. Qualitative research findings

Profile of the migrant workers interviewed in the study

Figure 59 illustrates the profiles of the Sri Lankan migrants who have worked abroad or are seeking foreign employment opportunities as aspiring migrants or TVET-qualified students. These profiles

provide an understanding of the demographics, qualifications and skills of the aspiring and returned Sri Lankan migrants interviewed for the gap analysis study.

Figure 59. Profile of aspiring and returned migrants interviewed in the study

Aspiring migrants	Returned migrants	TVET qualified
• Male and female • Age: 24–44 • Married and unmarried (more married aspirants) • Professions: IT software engineering, electrical engineering, civil engineering, nursing and care optician, teaching, photography, hairdressing • Education: Academic and professional qualifications, International English Language Testing System, language skills • Work experience: Locally, three to five years minimum • Aspire to apply for permanent residency in three years • Migrate with the family • Preference for countries: Europe, Japan, New Zealand, Australia for better living standards	• Male and female (mostly male returned migrants) • Age: 28–54 • Married and unmarried (most married) • Profession: electrical, maintenance, software engineering, technician, hotel management, food and beverage, teaching, beauty culture • Education: Academic, professional, NVQ qualifications, licentiate certificates • Work experience: local or foreign of five years • Employed in United Arab Emirates, China, Italy and Japan and returned to Sri Lanka during COVID-19 pandemic • Few aspire to remigrate to Europe or Oceania • Resettlement plan: matured male and female engage in their own micro or small business, provides consultancy and advisory services	• Male and female (most male) • Age: 22–28 • Married and unmarried • Followed courses at technical colleges with the expectation of seeking foreign employment • Education: NVQ level 6–7 • Expected career paths: primarily technical-related fields –electrical, welding, maintenance, hospitality (food and beverage) • Acquiring language proficiency in English, Korean, Japanese • Work experience: local (internship) or early stage of career • Preference to seek foreign employment in European countries, Japan, Australia, New Zealand, Republic of Korea and Middle East countries for better salaries and benefits

Reasons for wanting to migrate for foreign employment

Figure 60. Primary reasons for deciding to seek overseas employment opportunities (all categories including, professional, skilled and semi-skilled)



Note: The recent government policy decision on granting five-year unpaid leave for government sector employees triggered interest to seek foreign employment opportunities.

Preferred countries for migration by the aspiring migrants

Figure 61. Preferred countries for foreign employment, as described by aspiring migrants

Preferred countries by migrant workers	Reasons for their preference
Europe	European countries "...Considering the best living standards in countries such as the United Kingdom, Italy, Germany, France and Ireland , have well-paid jobs for automobile engineering and information technology..."
Australia	"More opportunities found in the health sector for medical professionals such as doctors, pharmacists, dentists, nurses and caregivers in the United Kingdom . Those who can afford would opt to settle down in the United Kingdom with a work visa."
New Zealand	Emerging opportunities in Eastern Europe (Romania, Poland, Czech Republic) for semi-skilled workers.
United States & Canada	New Zealand, Australia "More opportunities found in the health sector: nursing and caregiving and information technology."
Japan	"...highly paid jobs, good climate and culture, a large Sri Lankan community living there..."
Middle East	United States and Canada "More jobs for IT professionals and health sector for nurses and caregivers..."
Republic of Korea	"A large Sri Lankan community living there, yet high cost of living."
	Middle East "Kuwait and [United Arab Emirates] offer highly paid jobs, yet [these countries are] less preferred in terms of living conditions."
	Japan and Republic of Korea "...Offer more technical job categories, such as technicians, welders, binders, electricians with lucrative salaries..."

Trends in opportunities for foreign employment available for the aspirant migrant workers



Professionals

"Plenty of opportunities available for the professionals in the field of cyber security, engineering, nursing in health sector, chefs in the food and beverage, hospitality industry."

– Labour relations officer, Sri Lanka Foreign Mission in Europe

"Information technology is a growing sector that has many opportunities of emerging jobs like cyber security, AI and information systems, which are highly paid." – Software engineer



Skilled

"Opportunities for the skilled technical jobs: maintenance officers, welders, electricians, health care officers, nurses, caregivers, hairdressers in salons, etc." – Student who had completed TVET

"I am a teacher being trained to be a caregiver as there are plenty of opportunities in Israel." – Teacher

"I am a government nurse holding a diploma in nursing, planning to go to New Zealand as a health officer." – Nursing officer



Semi-skilled

"Jobs available for drivers, housekeepers, cleaning services and construction workers in the Middle East and more in Eastern Europe." – Local foreign employment agency officer

"More opportunities in airports, hospitals, road or building construction sites for drivers and cleaners in the Middle East, Romania and Poland." – Local foreign employment agency officer

Triggering points that created interest to seek foreign employment and the expected outcome of migration for foreign employment

Aspiring migrants	TVET qualified	Returned migrants
Professional and skilled categories Influenced by relatives and colleagues living abroad to join them and earn lucrative salaries and benefits.	Skilled categories Influenced by the peers or relatives who are working abroad in technical-oriented jobs, salons or hospitality industry. The senior students or lecturers at technical and vocational colleges have guided the students to seek better opportunities in the overseas countries.	Professional and skilled categories Interest to earn more than what was earned locally. Colleagues or previous employer helped to find overseas opportunities.
Low-skilled categories Primarily female employees migrate as domestic helpers due to the economic hardships that they go through in life, the expenses on education of children, building their own house, etc.		Low-skilled categories Female domestic helpers have returned to Sri Lanka having completed their contract period but they aspire to go to another country because they find it difficult to survive without the income earned in foreign employment.

Life is constrained in the country with the political unrest and economic downturn. Inability to fulfil basic living standards due to the high cost of living.

There is a perception that there is lack of lucrative opportunities in Sri Lanka for technical college graduates, thus they aim to go abroad upon completion of their study programme.

Life is constrained in the country with the political unrest and economic downturn. Inability to maintain the basic living standards due to high cost of living in the country.

Expected Outcome of Migration for Foreign Employment

Professional and skilled categories	Skilled categories	All categories
Uplifted standard of living through more income for the benefit of the individual and the family as a short-term goal. The long-term goal is to apply for permanent residency.	Earn high income to fulfil the requirements of the family for a few years and return to Sri Lanka to start up their own business. <i>"In countries like Dubai and Japan, we can earn very high salaries. For the technical jobs, they pay well. And we cannot ever think of earning that much in Sri Lanka."</i> – NVQ-qualified student	Earn better income to support and fulfil the requirements of the family. Work overseas for a few years and return to Sri Lanka to start up their own business.
Fulfil short-term career aspirations to pursue higher education and settle down by applying for permanent residency as long-term goal among the professional category.	<i>"Middle East, there's a very good opportunities for Sri Lankans and their salaries are much higher than other countries...even for low-skilled labour."</i> – Local foreign employment agency officer	<i>"I could earn a very high salary for the qualifications and work experience – I earned around five times of what I earned in Sri Lanka. I worked as a maintenance engineer. I have served in many countries in the same hotel chain as I was invited to work in other countries as well. However, during COVID-19 pandemic, I returned to Sri Lanka."</i> – Returned migrant maintenance engineer
Better future for children. Provide high standard of education for children in an overseas country. <i>"I wish to migrate as a family with children having sold property in Sri Lanka. With the expectation to get permanent residency in three to five years."</i> – Software engineer	<i>"A domestic helper in Kuwait will earn a basic [wage] of 180,000 rupees upwards and the technical officers or heavy vehicle drivers will earn 300,000–500,000 rupees per month."</i> – Local foreign employment agency officer	

Process of job search

The following describes how the various interviewed migrants had started their process to find an overseas job pathway.

Aspiring migrants

Aspiring migrants of the professional and skilled categories were more concerned about gathering information through various credible sources, and initially they browsed through websites to select the best country and job opportunities available.

Most common sources of information on job opportunities:

- LinkedIn job opportunities.
- Close relatives or colleagues living in preferred countries;
- Google search, job sites or social media (Facebook);
- Migration consultants.
- Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website; and
- Country-specific job sites.

TVET qualified

TVET-qualified students were interested to move for foreign employment and highly paid jobs and they typically searched opportunities through:

- Personal contacts or colleagues living in preferred countries;
- Guidance of the lecturers at the technical and vocational colleges;
- Recommendations by current employer;
- Google search, job sites and social media (Facebook); and
- Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website.

Returned migrants

Most of the returned migrants had searched job opportunities through the foreign employment agencies during their previous employment:

- Local foreign employment agencies and the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website; and
- Personal contacts in overseas countries.

The majority of these returned migrants intended to remigrate and to do so to a European country for employment rather than a Middle Eastern country due to the better standard of living.

Factors to be considered when selecting a country and job opportunities.

The following were the most common factors considered by the interviewed migrants when selecting a country and job opportunity for foreign employment:

- selecting a country with high standard of living;
- finding suitable opportunities to match with their qualifications and skills;
- knew someone who had already settled down in a country;
- a reliable employment agency to consult, registered with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment;
- total remuneration package and other fringe benefits (Insurance, leave entitlement);
- cost of living in the countries and taxation;
- language of a country;
- culture and people of a country;
- knowledge about food habits;
- social security conditions;
- education facilities for children;
- contract period of employment;
- process for applying for permanent residency;
- financial requirement for the application process;
- visa process for spouse and children;
- accommodation facilities and cost;
- rules and regulations of a country for migrant workers; and
- natural catastrophes and related threats in countries (and thus avoid these places).

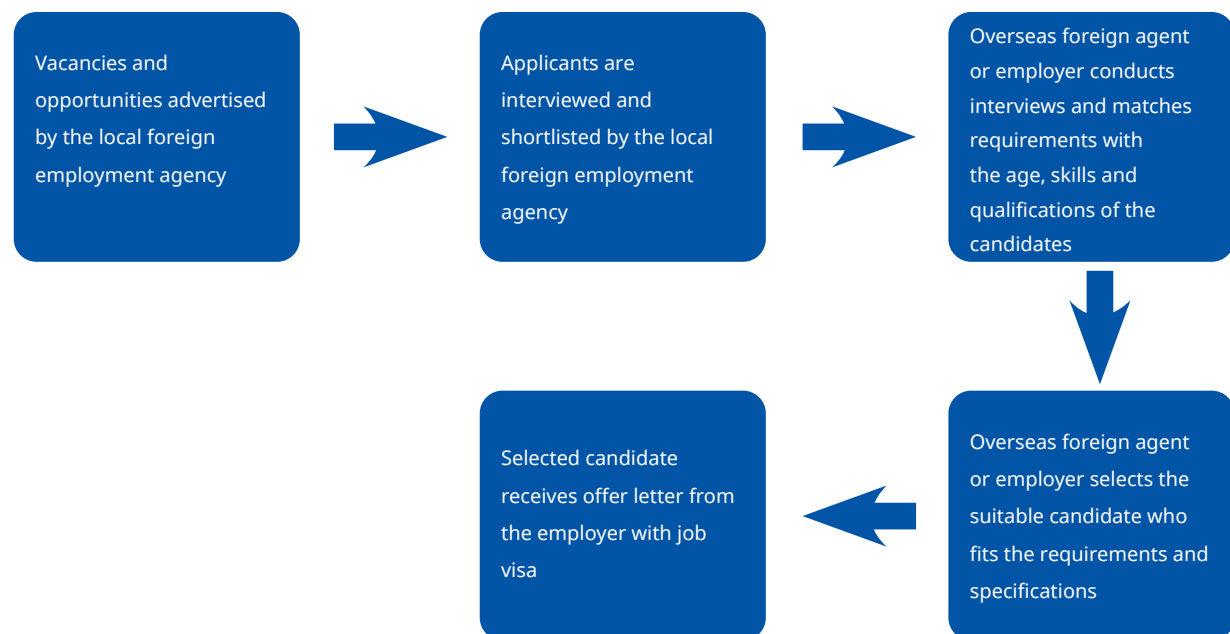
Job selection process

There are two main methods of job selection experienced by the applicants: (a) through a local foreign employment agent and (b) direct application through job sites or personal contacts living overseas (figures 62 and 63).

Process when using a local foreign employment agent:

- Job orders attested by a Sri Lanka Foreign Mission or positions in destination countries are received through the overseas foreign employment agents or from employers to a local foreign employment agency.
- Duration of the process of selection and offer letter with visa generally takes three to six months.
- Two- to three-year contract period can be extended at the discretion of the employer.
- Required to obtain training from the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment or any other institution, if necessary for the profession and job category.
- Completion of job contract (agreement).
- Undergo a medical examination and obtain necessary medical clearance.
- Register with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment.

Figure 62. Process of job selection through a local foreign employment agent

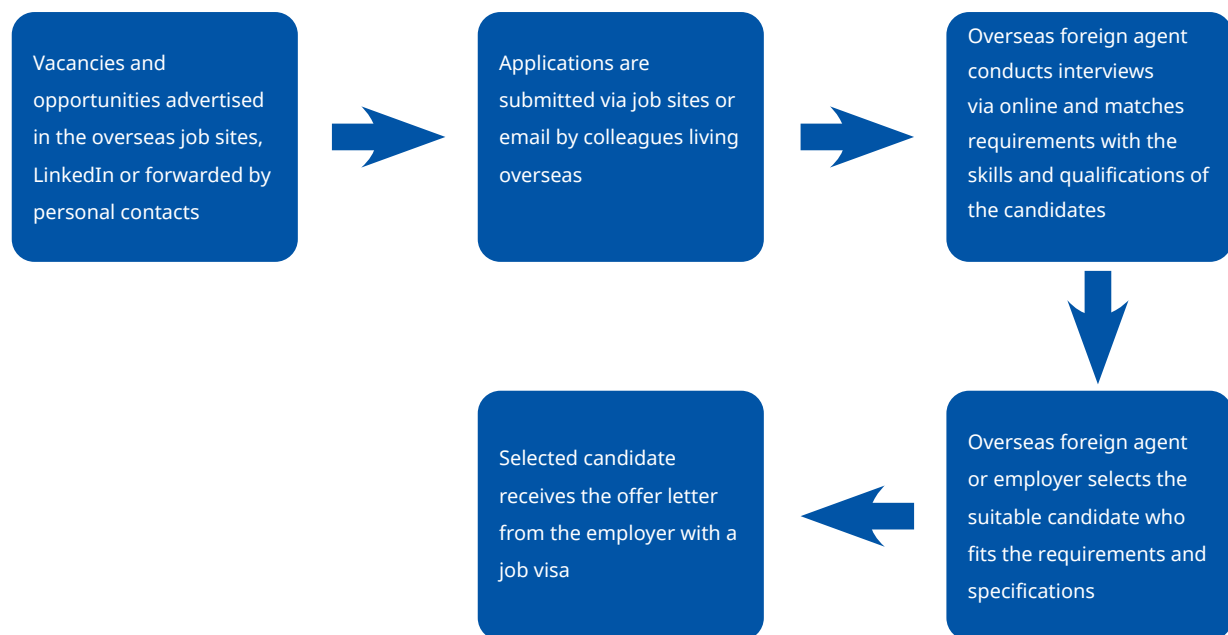


“Usually, the recommended age category for potential foreign employment is below 40 years. Then they select a suitable candidate based on their qualification because they check all the job requirements during the interviews. After relevant foreign companies select some candidates, they send offer letters to those candidates by informing them about the salary, working time period, holiday schedule and about vacations. If such a candidate agrees with those conditions, we request the visa processing....” – Foreign employer agency officer

Process when using direct applications through job sites or personal contacts living overseas:

- Job opportunities are received or identified through personal contacts living overseas or job sites and social media. Many applicants search opportunities through the LinkedIn professional network.
- Duration of the process of selection and offer letter with visa generally takes six to ten months.
- Most opportunities have a contract period that can be extended at the discretion of the employer.

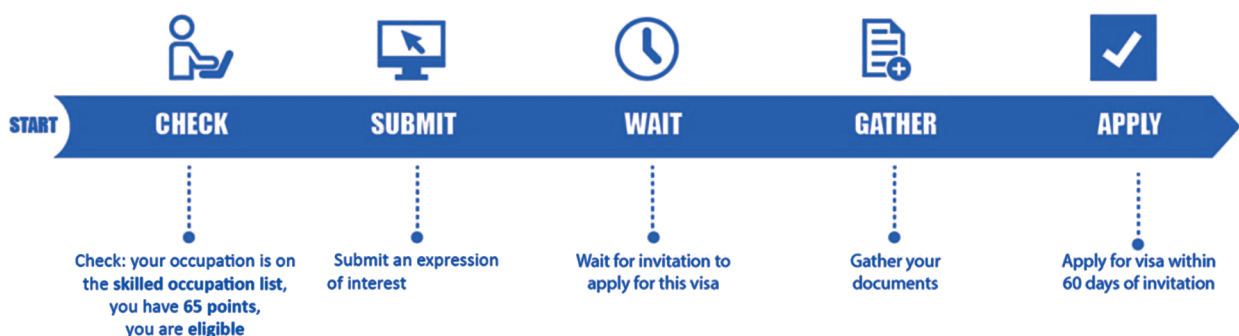
Figure 63. Process of direct application for foreign employment opportunity



Apart from the job application process, some of the aspiring migrants (professionals) had attempted to apply for a migration visa to Australia or New Zealand directly through a migration visa centre or website, as described in figure 64. As a special requirement,

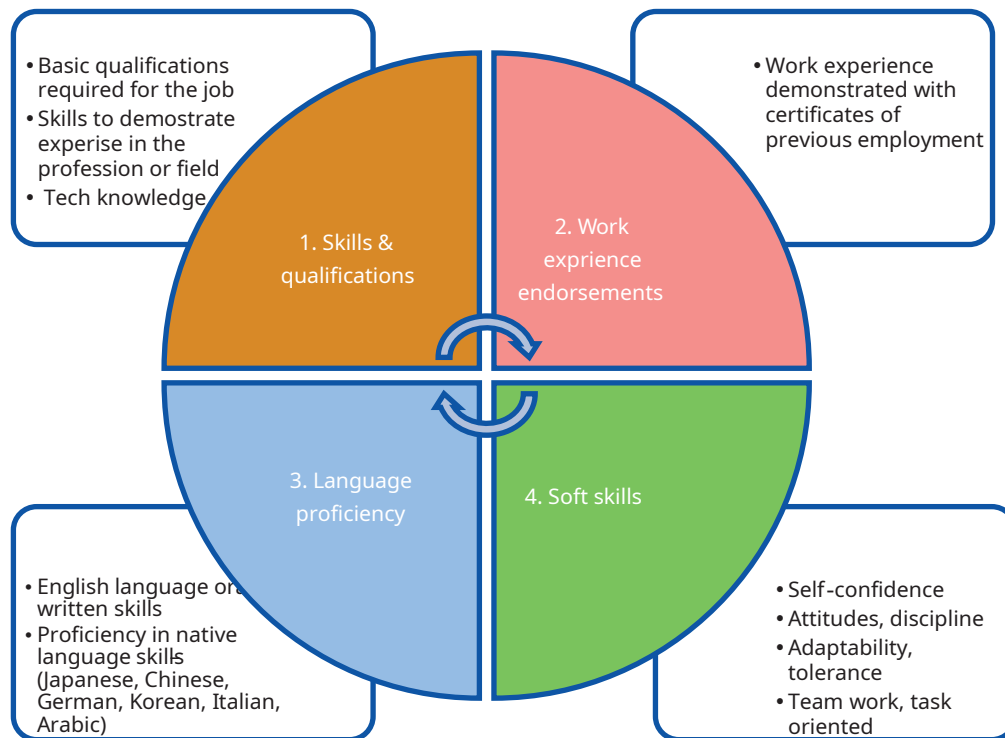
educational qualifications and age of an applicant affect eligibility: Migrants younger than 45 can only apply through the online system for professional category migration.

Figure 64. Process of direct application for skilled migration to Australia and New Zealand



Source: See www.immigrationsaustralia.com.au.

Figure 65. Process of matching the qualifications, skills and work experience during the recruitment process



1. Basic qualifications and skills required for the application as per the recruitment criteria will be matched during the selection process (depending on the job category):
 - younger than 45 years;
 - gender preference based on job type; and
 - skills and knowledge about technology and use of equipment.
2. Work experience is given higher weighting for extensive exposure in relevant field and in multiple organizations than the basic qualifications.
3. Language proficiency: Oral and written English language proficiency is mandatory.
 - i. International English Language Testing System (IELTS) is an English language test required for work, study and migration in English-speaking countries, such as Australia, Canada, Ireland, New Zealand, United Kingdom and United States.
 - ii. Proficiency in native language skills, such as Arabic, Chinese, German, Italian, Japanese and Korean.
4. Soft skills are required to perform with self-confidence; attitudes, task management and goal-orientation aspects are tested during the interview process and also considered during the selection process.

Summary of basic qualifications and skills required for professional and skilled categories

- Postgraduate, first degree, higher national diploma, diploma, certificate level and NVQ levels 4–6 are recognized qualifications. Professional qualifications from the Chartered Institute of Management Accountants (CIMA) or the Chartered Institute of Marketing (CIM) are recognized depending on the job category.
- Postgraduate and other degrees and higher national diploma offered by universities in

Sri Lanka as well as foreign universities are recognized.

- In Canada, American medical professionals must follow their qualifying programmes and register in the Medical Council.
- NVQ levels 4–6 offered by the technical colleges and TVET institutes, the National Apprentice and Industrial Training Authority of Sri Lanka and the Vocational Training Authority are recognized for skilled professionals in many job categories.
- NVQ categories of courses offered are culinary and cookery, information technology, computer networking, mechanical engineering, civil engineering, language and literature, quantity surveying, nursing, food science and agriculture, construction management, etc.
- National Vocational Qualification (NVQ) Recognition of Prior Learning Certificates are also offered by many courses.

►► *“NVQ system is a skill evaluation system and has a high tendency for a foreign employment. NVQ certificate certifies skills up to the respective NVQ level in that occupation. Career paths are available to obtain qualifications in higher levels of this framework and to gain relevant skills on the basis of experience and competencies.” – Civil engineer*

►► *“NVQ level 6 is equal to a bachelor’s degree on the UK qualification framework and accepted globally as a professional health and safety qualification for health and safety managers and supervisors.” – Local foreign employment agency officer*

Work experience endorsements

The majority of the interviewed aspiring and returned migrants agreed that more than the qualifications, work experience is considered important in the selection process. Work experience commendation certificates are much recognized, and the minimum requirement is three to five years in a similar capacity or field. Certificates related to work experience add more points during the evaluation than the academic or professional qualifications. Technical college qualification plus competency for technical skills must be demonstrated through the minimum years of work experience.

Language proficiency in English and country-specific language skills

Language proficiency in English is essential along with the language of the host country (if different), such as Arabic, Chinese, German, Japanese and Korean, depending on the job. An IELTS test score above 5 is required to be eligible to apply for skilled job categories. For instance, the IELTS examination must be successfully completed with a score of 7.5–8 to apply for nursing.

The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment offers language proficiency training, but the duration is not adequate to improve language proficiency, according to aspiring migrants. Japan is opening up opportunities, but applicants should be proficient in Japanese – they must pass a language skills exam. Similarly in Germany, there is demand for nurses but they must have knowledge in German, according to foreign employment agency staff.

Soft skills of applicants are necessary

The following skills are expected:

- skills in customer care, discipline, mannerisms and teamwork;
- critical thinking, agile leadership, digital literacy, flexibility, learning mindset and data literacy skills;
- analytical ability;
- presentation skills; and
- facing interviews with confidence.

Returned migrants' reasons for returning to Sri Lanka

Most of the returned migrants mentioned that they had returned to Sri Lanka primarily due to the COVID-19 pandemic (2020–2021). A few had returned due to the completion of their contract period.

Countries where they had worked

The majority of returned migrants had worked in Middle Eastern countries, Australia, China, Cyprus or Italy. They intended to remigrate for work opportunities in European countries because they want a better standard of living with their family.

Prominent job categories

The professionals had worked as maintenance engineers, mechanical engineers, electricians, teachers, hairdressers, quantity surveyors, chefs and food and beverage specialists in the hotel sector.

Satisfaction with the overseas employer

Almost everyone mentioned that they were quite satisfied with their previous employer and said they had not encountered any issues. But they knew of other Sri Lankans who had experienced unpleasant situations because they had not selected the job that best fit their skills and capabilities and due to the language barrier being an issue.

Resettlement efforts in Sri Lanka

Some professional migrants had started their own business or consultancy firms upon their return but still preferred to remigrate considering the ongoing economic turmoil in Sri Lanka.

Challenges and barriers observed during the journey of seeking foreign employment

Challenging visa process

- Validity of visa – lengthy process in getting the work visa through foreign employer agents.
- The visa process takes approximately three to six months for European countries. It takes up to three months for Middle Eastern countries, Jordan and Romania.
- The applicants do not have a reliable source of information from the government authorities, and they must depend on a private agency for the visa application process.
- In the event the foreign employer conducts the interview and selection, the job visa is issued without a hassle.
- The visa process is delayed in countries that do not have a local consulate office.
- Financial capacity for the application process and the visa process is costly for European countries (some of the aspiring migrants had to pay 9 million–14 million rupees to acquire a visa).

Finding suitable opportunities to match with qualifications and skills

- Some migrants had not selected a job that best fit their skills and capabilities, thus they encountered many issues due to incompetency in their performance.
- Some migrants had selected a lower-grade job than their Sri Lankan employment category or profession.

“Some of the government servants and private sector employees also have sought to apply for lower-scale jobs, such as domestic helpers, cleaners, drivers, labourers in road construction, simply because they are in search of an opportunity to go for overseas employment.” – Local foreign employment agency officer

- The government sector employees opted to seek foreign employment during the five years of unpaid leave facility.

“With the introduction of the government policy on allowing government servants to apply for unpaid leave for five-year period, most of the staff in the clerical or teaching have moved to overseas job opportunities as their objective is to earn a high income regardless of the type of job they have to perform.” – Local foreign employment agency officer

- Finding a reliable employment agency was challenging.

“There are many scandals involved by the local foreign employment agencies reported in media. Therefore, it is not easy find a reliable agency.” – Aspiring migrant worker

- Language was a barrier for many persons because they lacked fluency or language proficiency in English or a host-country language.

“Skill-wise, we are on top. But the only issue is that of the language barrier in basic English.” – Sri Lankan Foreign Mission officer

- A high IELTS score was required for professional categories in English-speaking countries.
- Total remuneration package offered compared with the cost of living and taxation rates were of concern for the skilled migrants because most of the European countries as well as the United States and Canada had increased the tariff rates recently.
- Knowledge of living standards of the country was a concern for those who planned to obtain permanent residency.

- Accommodation facilities was a concern, in terms of whether the employer would provide food and accommodation.
- Social security and the culture of the country was a concern when there was no orientation.
- Duration of the contract period was an issue; once the contract period was over, migrants would be required to return to Sri Lanka or seek another opportunity with the proper visa application.

Service lapses of government institutions towards migrant workers

- Undue delays in the process of obtaining translations of certificates, (birth, marriage and educational certificates from the Ministry of Education, etc.).
- Delays at the Department of Immigration and Emigration to obtain a passport or renew a passport. Many malpractices due to bribes taken by the intermediaries at the passport office.
- Service of the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment inconsistent – links of the published vacancies in the website were not working at times.
- Lack of continuous and effective crash courses by government institutions to improve the language proficiency of skilled and low-skilled workers as well as other important foreign languages.

Negative perceptions about Sri Lankan migrants in the Republic of Korea

- The Republic of Korea does not provide citizenship for foreign employees; therefore their jobs are mainly on contract basis for three years.

“Sri Lanka is considered as the third position in the ratio for illegal migration and human trafficking in [the Republic of] Korea due to the fact that some of the contractual workers who had not returned to Sri Lanka after the two- to three-year contract period was ended.” – A Sri Lankan Foreign Mission officer

Bargaining power of the overseas foreign employer agents is becoming a threat for Sri Lanka's labour export market

- Overseas foreign employer agents get labour supply from such countries such as Bangladesh, India, Nepal and Viet Nam at lower wage rates to retain high margins for themselves.

"Agents in overseas countries reduce the salary benefits and provide employment opportunities to such countries than the Sri Lankan market for supply of labour."

– Local foreign employment agency officer

Challenges faced by the foreign employment agencies

- Delayed services at the Sri Lanka Foreign Mission offices to provide approval for job orders at the request of local agents; as a result of the delay, sometimes job orders are missed.
- Countries where a Sri Lanka Foreign Mission is not available take more time for visa processing because the applications are sent to India.

"Countries like Czech Republic, Slovakia, Hungary and Poland have visa applications [that] have to be sent to India for processing." – Local foreign employment agency officer

"At least establish a VFS centre in Sri Lanka for the countries that do not have a consular office." – Local foreign employment agency officer

- Less focus on providing opportunities outside of the Middle Eastern countries. Some of the reasons cited:

Constraints with visa process

"It is very difficult to get contacts and agents for seeking opportunities in European countries, and it is very costly for the applicants when it comes to visa processing fees. These countries have more regulations and are difficult to work with." – Local foreign employment agency officer

"The European countries' migration process is somewhat complex. That's why we have not gone through those country opportunities.... For instance, once we got vacancies from Poland –

When people seek opportunities in such European countries, they [must go to India for the job interview and they need a visa to go to India]. If they don't get selected from the interview, they have to come back. However, they have to spend a lot of money at that time. Therefore, we do not focus on those country opportunities."

– Local foreign employment agency officer

Cost of visa processing

"Most of the low-skilled and semi-skilled applicants opt to select Middle East countries as the cost of visa and air ticket are borne by the employer." – Local foreign employment agency officer

Unethical practices by the overseas foreign employment agencies

"As a local foreign employment agency, we have faced many issues time to time. Sometimes, the foreign agents get money from us offering large job orders and afterwards they do not meet the agreement. We already experienced many of such incidents in the past—we informed the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment, but no justice was received to us." – Local foreign employment agency officer

Conclusions

- There is an increasing trend of skilled migration to Europe, Oceania, the United States and Canada due to the living standards. Most opportunities available are in the health, IT and construction sectors, apart from caregiving and nursing.
- Emerging opportunities are found in the professional and skilled categories in Europe, Australia, New Zealand, the United Kingdom, the United States and Canada.
- Semi-skilled and low-skilled opportunities are available in Eastern Europe (Romania and the Czech Republic) as well as Middle Eastern countries.

- Qualifications obtained from local or foreign universities at the degree, postgraduate, diploma or certificate level, as well as NVQ levels 4–6, are recognized in most overseas job markets, depending on the category of jobs.
- Language proficiency in English is a must in all countries as well as the native language in some countries, although ability to speak a host-country language is an advantage in other countries. Lack of proficiency in English has become a barrier for most qualified candidates.
- The majority of the aspiring professional and skilled migrants intend to migrate with their family and apply for permanent residency in two to three years due to the promising economic situation in a country.
- Salaries and benefits are lucrative for both the professional and skilled categories of jobs – they can be four to five times or even more of what could be earned in Sri Lanka.
- Nearly all of the returned migrants who were interviewed for this study had returned to Sri Lanka between 2019 and 2021 mostly due to the COVID-19 pandemic. The majority of them intend to remigrate, seeking opportunities in the European countries because they want a better standard of living for their family

► 4. Country profiles, with recommendations

Saudi Arabia

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities are found through individual job agents, foreign employment agencies, LinkedIn and personal contacts.	- Many Indians dominate the job market due to biases from Indian investors in the finance, hospitality and construction sectors - Lack of fluency in Arabic and English - Know-how on using technology available in Saudi Arabia - Only NVQ levels 5–7 recognized - Work experience of 3–5 years in a similar field or capacity required	- Language skills in English - Basic knowledge in Arabic language - Knowledge about technology - Work experience	There are different types of visas, including a tourist visa, but an employment visa is required to work in Saudi Arabia. A job offer is required beforehand because a work visa is not possible to obtain without a sponsor (employer), who must apply for the visa on behalf of the applicant. A signed employment contract must be received by the applicant prior to arrival. The work visa requires a letter from the employer or visa sponsor that has been certified by the Chamber of Commerce as well as the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. Interviews are conducted by the local agents as well as by the Saudi employers (online). Skills and work experience are given more weight during the selection process. A single-entry tourist visa allows a stay of up to one month (30 days), while a multiple-entry visa permits a stay of up to three months (90 days) in Saudi Arabia. The multiple-entry visa remains valid for a maximum of three months, irrespective of exits and re-entries during that period. Tourists cannot extend their visas and must depart from the country before their visa expires. A tourist visa can be converted to a work visa. It is possible to change a visit visa to a work visa, but it requires certain conditions to be met. The individual must first secure a job offer from a Saudi employer who is willing to sponsor their work visa. The employer will then apply for the work visa on behalf of the employee, and once approved, the individual can change their status from a visitor to a resident and begin working legally in the country. A temporary work visit visa is also a visit visa and is valid for a stay of up to 90 days. The visa is issued electronically without any documents and can be extended for another three months. Application is online through the website of the General Directorate of Residency and Foreigners Affairs and assistance for a visa can be obtained from the Department of Foreign Affairs in Saudi Arabia. See www.dfa.ie/travel/travel-advice/a-z-list-of-countries/saudi-arabia/

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled Sales, technology, sustainability and human resources (most in demand jobs)	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications in the relevant field are recognized. Applicants must have a master's or postgraduate degree or a diploma in a related field. Accountant applicants must have a Bachelor of Science in Accountancy, with 2 years of experience. Applicants for work in beauty salons must have NVQ certification and experience in a salon for 1–2 years. English language fluency is required.	Professional segments require 2–3 years and 4–5 years of experience in a relevant field. Semi-skilled jobs require 1–2-year experience.
Immediate vacancies for 2023 Contract manager Safety adviser Community director Housing adviser Facility manager Foreman engineer (civil) Foreman engineer (NEU) Foreman engineer (HVAC/Mech) IT or communication engineer Utility plant manager Landscaping engineer Safety officer Quality assurance officer Recreation adviser General supervisor Fire captain Food safety or quality officer Laundry supervisor Housekeeping supervisor Food and beverage manager Executive chef Recreation organizer Landscape supervisor Event or recreation organizer Gym instructor Housekeeping manager Laundry manager Weather station system group leader (instrumentation supervisor) Airfield lighting and navigation aids group leader (airfield lighting supervisor) Maintenance planner Electrician – industrial Fire alarm technician Heavy vehicle driver	Vocational training certificate and NVQ level 4 or more are recognized at a negotiable level.	
Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years		

Accountant, accounting technician
Financial analyst
Sales clerk and shopkeeper
System administrator, system analyst
Beauty salon staff: nail technician, hairdresser, receptionist
Construction, oil and gas and retail industries: skilled and semi-skilled technician, project manager, quantity surveying
Marketing, finance, banking, legal officer, supply chain, procurement, sales, business development, logistics, manager
Hospitality and tourism: chef, cook, assistant chef, food and beverage manager, maintenance engineer
Semi-skilled: heavy vehicle driver, domestic helper

Saudi Arabia labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Information technology	Skilled, professional	AI and machine learning specialist	Applicants must have 5–10 years of experience, a bachelor's degree in computer science, mathematics or a related field and strong knowledge of machine learning techniques and applications.	Long term	High market potential	Head of private banking earns 140,000–177,000 Saudi riyal per month. Legal partner (5+ years) earns 104,000–229,000 riyal per month.
Trading	Skilled, semi-skilled, low-skilled	Occupations in the small and medium-sized enterprise sector		Forecasted in Vision 2030 of Saudia Arabia	No specified qualifications or skills	Secretariat general in public sector earns 208,000+ riyal per month.
Hospitality					Plan to create 1 million jobs by 2030, mainly for Saudi nationals	
Sales and services	Skilled, professional	Project managers Client information and customer service workers	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree or equivalent, at least 3–5 years of industry experience, skills in problem-solving, project management software and methodologies, language proficiency (Arabic) and proficiency in cost management, finance, analytics and communication, as well as MS office packages.	Forecasted until 2025	High market potential	Chief strategy officer earns 135,000–180,000 riyal per month.
	Skilled, semi-skilled	Cook Waiter Gardner Foreperson Other hotel service staff Security guard	Applicants must have a degree or equivalent qualification in relevant subjects or high school diploma or equivalent and/or apprenticeship (such as horticulture) or previous experience in similar role. Technical skills expected for gardeners include mowing, trimming, weeding, planting, cultivating, fertilizing, watering, etc. Knowledge on security positions and physical fitness is expected of security guard applicants.		Required number of years in experience may vary from industry, sector, employer For security guards in some cases, opportunities limited to Saudi nationals	A group chief financial officer earns 104,000–150,000 riyal per month. Sales and marketing general manager can earn 59,000–68,000 riyal per month, while the head of corporate communications earns 51,000–56,000 riyal a month.

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
	Low-skilled	Driver Cleaner	Applicants must have qualified in secondary school. Drivers must have a valid Saudi driver's license, prior experience in similar role and verbal and written communication skills.		High market potential and one of the most preferred jobs among semi-skilled migrant workers in Sri Lanka. Fluency in English and Arabic languages is a strong positive factor.	A manufacturing: managing director earns 99,000–135,000 riyal per month. A human resources chief or a shared services officer can earn 104,000–156,000 riyal per months.
Construction	Semi-skilled, low-skilled	Construction supervisor, foreperson Construction worker Welder Plumber Electrician Air-conditioning technician Tiler Mason Carpenter Crane operator	Applicants must have a preferred high school or vocational education, apprenticeship or valid certifications related to the subject, industry experience with skills related to the industry (like masonry techniques, working with blueprints or plans). A bachelor's degree or equivalent in relevant civil engineering or related subject for construction supervisor or foreperson is required. All applicants must have language proficiency in Arabic.	Forecasted until 2025	Required number of years in experience may vary from industry, sector, and employer. Salary may vary based on the years of experience	
	Skilled, professional	Civil or maintenance engineer	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree in relevant field, at least 5 years of experience in engineering, maintenance and planning, language proficiency and computer skills		High market potential subject to fluency in English and Arabic languages	
Health	Skilled, professional	Nurse Paramedic General doctor Dentist X-ray specialist Deputy general manager Obstetrician Operations surgeon Technical performance monitor	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree in medicine or relevant diploma or degree, other relevant certification related to the role (preferred). A master's degree is preferred in some cases. A valid professional license, industry experience in clinical practice, proficiency in English and computer skills, skills in communication, leadership, time management, finance practices, etc. are expected for managers.	Forecasted until 2025 and forecasted in Vision 2030 of Saudia Arabia	High market potential subject to fluency in English and Arabic languages	

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Education	Skilled, professional	Teacher	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree at the least in a relevant field and at least 2 years of experience.	Forecasted until 2025	High market potential subject to fluency in English and Arabic languages	
Automobile manufacturing	Skilled, semi-skilled		Applicants must have higher education or vocational qualifications.		Focusing on high-skilled or specific technical and vocationally skilled people	

Recommendations for Saudi Arabia

Key messages

- Demand for migrant workers is very high, and the trend is predicted to continue up to 2030.
- ICT and hospitality are two important sectors for Sri Lanka to promote migration in Saudi Arabia.
- Fluency in English and Arabic languages is a strong positive factor.

Recommendations

- Immediate vacancies for 2023 should be targeted.
- Strategies should be developed to exploit the market potential for the next 3–5 years, such as in the ICT, hospitality, accounting and business management, construction and beauty salon sectors.
- Mutually beneficial migration should continue through bilateral labour agreements.
- Promoting skilled and semi-skilled migration in Saudi Arabia should be a concentrated focus.
- Skills development programmes, such as English and Arabic, should be facilitated through public–private partnerships to provide short duration courses for migrants before they leave the country. Along with the specific languages, there should be a course on the rules and regulations, culture of the country and other values that would be important for the migrant workers to keep in mind when they are working in Saudi Arabia.
- Demand-side information should be provided through a country-specific job portal. Currently, job opportunities are found through the job agents, foreign employment agencies, LinkedIn and personal contacts and job sites. Because there are more opportunities in the skilled and blue-collar job categories, they should be advertised in prominent newspapers to create awareness. As well, explore the professional job market and link with available resources in the country to send migrants to Saudi Arabia.

United Arab Emirates

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities are found through the individual job agents, foreign employment agencies, LinkedIn and personal contacts. Migrants can enter the country with a visit visa and look for work and then convert this visa to a work visa. To make things easier for expats who want to work remotely in the country, a remote work visa is valid for 1 year. It allows holders to relocate to Dubai and legally work for their current company or organization remotely.	- Threat of Indians in the labour market who are dominating in United Arab Emirates because they get plenty of opportunities through the Indian investor counterparts in the finance sector, hospitality sector and construction. - Language skills in Arabic and English is required. - Lack of knowledge about use of technology	- Language skills in English - Knowledge in native language is an advantage. - Soft skills and knowledge about the culture to work collaboratively with multicultural society. - Knowledge about technology	An offer letter from the employer or contract is required to apply for job visa. An employer-sponsored resident permit requires Ministry of Human Resources and Emiratization approval and an employment contract. The visa process takes about 2 months. An employment entry visa, known as a pink visa, is required. To begin the process of obtaining this permit, the employer must apply for visa quota approval on behalf of the employee. This approval will be obtained through the Ministry of Labour. Visit visa permits a stay of up to 30 days and is valid for 58 days from the date of issuance. Invitation letter, passport copy and valid residence visa copy of the host is necessary to apply, along with an onward and return confirmed ticket.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years

Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Sales, technology, sustainability and human resources (most in demand) Several industries in the energy sector require science, technology and engineering specialist Construction, oil and gas and retail industries: skilled and semi-skilled technician, project manager, quantity surveying Marketing, finance, banking, legal officers, supply chain, procurement, sales, business development, logistics, managerial positions Hospitality and tourism: chef, food and beverage manger, maintenance engineers Semi-skilled: heavy vehicle driver, domestic helper, cleaner	Applicants must prove good health (free of HIV or tuberculosis) and no criminal record. They also must be at a professional level, at skill levels 1-5 (explained below) and they must have a certificate higher than a secondary certificate or an equivalent certificate. The certificate must be attested by the responsible authority. The Ministry of Human Resources and Emiratization has defined nine levels of employment: Level 1: legislator, manager, business executive Level 2: professional in scientific, technical and human fields Level 3: technician in scientific, technical and humanitarian fields Level 4: writing professional Level 5: service and sales occupation Level 6: skilled worker in agriculture, fishery and animal husbandry Level 7: craftsperson in construction, mining, other crafts Level 8: operator and assembler of machinery and equipment Level 9: simple profession, including cleaner and domestic worker	Professional segments require 2-3 years and 4-8 years of experience in the relevant field or similar capacity. Semi-skilled jobs require 1-2-years of experience with work certificates.

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years

Engineering specialist, IT and data engineers, telecom, engineering, quantity surveying, auto technician
 Hospitality and tourism: chef, food and beverage manager, maintenance engineer
 Education sector: primary and early childhood teacher
 Semi-skilled: heavy-vehicle driver, housekeeping assistant, domestic cleaner

Dubai*

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
There is a trend where migrant workers visit on tourist visa and search for jobs. Job opportunities are searched via LinkedIn, websites, employment agents and personal contacts.	- Lack of English fluency to converse - Indians dominate the labour market with their language proficiency and personal contacts with the business community in Dubai - Indian investors offer jobs to their own country people - Medical qualification from a medical school listed in the International Medical Education Directory of the Foundation for Advancement of International Medical Education and Research	English language proficiency	Work visa through the employer for 2-year contract period. Minimum fee of 1,200 diram for domestic workers (men and women)

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years

Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled Nurse, caregiver, doctor, lab technician Banking, insurance and finance officer IT sector: software development Lawyer Teacher, tutor Distribution, supply chain, logistics Facilities, property management Business consultancy services Automotive repair, spare parts, support services	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. Medical doctor applicants must hold a medical qualification listed from a medical school listed in the International Medical Education Directory of the Foundation for Advancement of International Medical Education and Research. The United Arab Emirates accepts American training inclusive of medical school, residency and fellowship. Required to be a graduate of an allopathic medical school listed in the Avicenna Directory of Medical Schools published by the WHO, or the International Medical Education Directory. Nurse applicants must have a degree or diploma in nursing and the Sri Lankan nursing registration. A certificate course in caregiving for the adult caregivers. German Tech, technical colleges and related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4-7) are recognized. All applicants must have English language fluency.	Minimum work experience of 3-5 years is required for professional and skilled categories.

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years

Health sector: Nursing, lab technicians

Finance and insurance sector

Construction sector – engineers and semi-skilled labour

IT sector – software engineering

BPOs and hybrid operations

United Arab Emirates labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Construction and maintenance of buildings	Skilled, low-skilled	Construction worker, welder, plumber, electrician, air-conditioning technician, tiler, mason, carpenter, crane operator	Applicants must have higher secondary, secondary school, vocational course or professional degree. At least 2–5 years of experience working in a similar role is expected.	Project occupational categories of low-skilled or semi-skilled workers in demand, up to 2025	Expats in the United Arab Emirates are not required to pay any personal or corporate income tax, which provides a unique opportunity to receive a 100 per cent tax-free salary or wage in Dubai and other Emirates.
Construction and maintenance of buildings	Skilled, professional	Construction supervisor, foreperson, maintenance engineer, civil engineer	Applicants must have a degree in civil engineering or equivalent from a recognized university. Excellent command of English, both written and spoken, and at least 2–5 years of experience working in a similar role is also required.		The gross salary range is typically from 4,607 dirham (minimum salary) to 23,955 dirham (highest average, actual maximum salary is higher). For a human resource job, the average is 14,489 dirham per month. A job in medicine or social care earns an average of 11,420.80 dirham per month. A job in production earns an average of 11,640 dirham per month. While in telecommunications, the average salary is 15,342 dirham per month.
Sales and services	Skilled	Data entry clerk, administrative assistant, customer service representative	Applicants must have a degree from a recognized institution and proven experience as a data entry administrator or similar role.		
Hotel and hospitality	Low-skilled	Cook, waiter, other hotel service staff	Applicants must have passion for hospitality, with a minimum 2 years of experience in a similar role.		
Hotel and hospitality Construction	Low-skilled	Driver, cleaner, security guard, gardener	Applicants must have a minimum 2 years of experience in a similar role.		
Education and health	Skilled, professional	Nurse, paramedic, teacher	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree in the field and at least 2–5 years of experience working in a similar role.		
Domestic work	Low-skilled	Domestic worker, housekeeper, gardener, security guard	Applicants must have at least 3 years of experience in the same role.		

Recommendations for United Arab Emirates

Key messages

- ICT, science, technology and engineering and hospitality sectors have high demand for skilled and semi-skilled workers.
- Fluency in English and Arabic are strong positive factors.
- Skilled and semi-skilled jobs require work experience.

Recommendations

- The formal pathway should be enhanced through Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment for aspiring migrants to access jobs in the United Arab Emirates.
- Knowledge in handling technology and equipment in the workplace (video demos) and multitasker skills should be provided.
- Remote working opportunities for the professional categories should be identified and promoted.
- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to provide short duration Arabic language courses to be learned before leaving the country. Along with the specific languages, there should be a course on the rules and regulations, culture of the country and other values that would be important for the migrant workers to keep in mind when they are working in the country.
- Because there are more opportunities in the skilled and blue-collar job categories, they should be advertised in prominent newspapers to create awareness. Also, the professional job market should be explored to link with available resources in the country to send migrants to the United Arab Emirates.

United States of America

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities found through personal contacts, LinkedIn and websites.	- Lack of English fluency to converse - Compared to Indians, Sri Lankans lack soft skills - Requirements to obtain approved qualifications, license to perform the professional job categories for medical practitioners - Climatic changes and adaptation - High cost of living and taxation - Must pass physical, drug screen and background or pre-employment screening checks	- Language proficiency in English (required for all jobs) - Soft skills, such as analytical ability - Good verbal and written communication skills in English - Right combination of skills, education and/or work experience	Work visa through the employer has to be applied from the Department of State. The H-1B visa is the most popular visa for professionals in specialty occupations, such as doctor or engineer. An Employment Authorization (EAD) card allows applicants to seek jobs if they have a dependant and their spouse has a job. O-1 visa is granted to applicants with remarkable talent or accomplishments in their field. EB-3 refers to the low-skilled labour visa category and is the “3rd preference” of employment-based visas. A foreign national can obtain the EB-3 low-skilled visa by either (a) adjusting their status in the United States from a student visa or other type of visa to the EB-3 visa or (b) applying overseas to be interviewed at the local American Embassy or Consulate. A permanent labour certification issued by the Department of Labor allows an employer to hire a foreign worker to work permanently in the country. The employer offers the position to the foreign national, contingent on there being no qualified American worker who will apply for the position in the subsequent recruitment. A Permanent Resident Card (Green Card) is available based on eligibility criteria. Student visa is available for postgraduate or master’s programmes at universities.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled Nurse, caregiver, medical doctor Software and hardware engineers (IT sector has more hardware and software engineering, cyber security-related opportunities) Electrical engineer (in construction, power plants), biomedical and chemical engineer Business process outsourcing that follows a hybrid working process Low-skilled persons must pursue sponsorships and be willing to fill openings with the help of an EB-3 low-skilled visa for industries like janitorial, restaurants, packing, warehousing, food prep and fast food	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. It is mandatory to adhere to the qualifying exams to practise as medical and health professionals. Medical professionals (doctors and nurses) must follow the qualifications. Medical practitioners are required to pass the required medical licensing exam. Most migrants, even with experience in practising with foreign qualifications, are required to re-enrol academically, especially when curriculum differs overseas. They are called International Medical Graduates (31.8 per cent of physicians in the country are foreign trained).	Minimum work experience of 3–5 years for all professional and skilled categories. Any foreign doctor who wants to practise medicine in the United States must pass the medical licensing exam to obtain certification. Nurses are required to pass the National Council Licensing Examination–Registered Nurse.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
	To enter a fellowship or residency programme approved by the Accreditation Council for Graduate Medical Education, the Bachelor of Medicine, Bachelor of Surgery students, Indian medical graduates, foreign medical graduates or completed Medical Doctor who want to settle in the United States in the future, the medical licensing exam is the only option to get certified and start a medical practice in the country. Nurse applicants must have a degree in nursing and the Sri Lanka nursing registration. They are required to pass the National Council Licensing Examination-Registered Nurse. Caregivers need a certificate course in caregiving for adults. Language proficiency in English with a test score at a high band is essential. Skill assessment test results during the selection process for migration visa.	
Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years		

IT sector: software engineer, AI specialist, cyber security expert
 Engineer in green energy, from technology engineer to power plant-based energy engineer
 Hospitality sector: chef

Hiring international nurses and doctors is becoming increasingly common in the hospitals of Pennsylvania. For example, Highmark Health, Geisinger Health System, Trinity Health, and Kindred Hospital have all prioritized a programme for hiring foreign medical professionals to provide excellent patient care.

The federal Government had projected that more than 200,000 new registered nurse positions will be created each year from 2016 to 2026. The United States is always looking for experienced health care workers, especially nurses, because they are in high demand. For years, experts in the health care field have sounded the alarm on the high demand for nurses nationwide. Based on projections by the US Bureau of Labor Statistics, the country will need an additional 203,200 registered nurses each year, from now through 2031.

Because the ageing population is high in the United States, there will be more demand for adult caregiver jobs in the long term as well.

**Demand for related jobs that provide support to physicians and other health care providers are likely to be the most in demand. There's a high demand need for physical therapy aides, home health aides and medical assistants.*

American labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Leisure and hospitality	Skilled, semi-skilled	Cook Restaurant Usher Lobby attendant Ticket taker	Applicants must have a high school diploma or equivalent, with proven industry experience, relevant certification for the occupation. Strong interpersonal and communication skills, high organization skills, knowledge of MS office package and proficiency in language (English) are essential.	2021–31	Potential market but requires proficiency in English	The average annual wage is US\$74,738. Highest paid professional categories average US\$117,360 per annum. Semi-skilled and low-skilled are paid US\$45,450 per annum. Median wage for employees in health care support occupations is about US\$33,600.
Health care and social assistance	Low-skilled	Elderly care	Experience in similar role, compassion, relevant certification and training is preferred.	2021–31	Market potential very high but requires proficiency in English	
	Skilled, professional	Nurse practitioner	Applicants must have a valid license as defined by the Nurse Licensure Compact, degree or equivalent qualification, nearly 5 years of experience and strong oral and written communication skills.		Market potential very high but requires proficiency in English	
Sports	Skilled, semi-skilled	Umpire, referee, other sports official, athlete, sports competitor	Applicants must be older than 18 years, have sport-specific coaching experience and knowledge, excellent communication skills, pass a criminal background check, skills in leadership, time management and meeting deadlines.	2021–31		
Mining						
Educational services	University lecturers	Academic position	Applicants must have a PhD from an American university plus teaching experience. Research publications are required.	2021–25		
Data and information technology	Skilled, professional	Statistician Information security analyst Data scientist	Applicants must have a bachelor's or advanced degree, preferably in a technology-related field or equivalent, experience in relevant field, such as machine learning, analysing structured and unstructured datasets, using data mining process models. Skills in MS office package, ability to apply new technologies with little instruction and proficiency in statistical computer languages (Python, R, SQL, etc.) and machine learning methods are expected. Good communication skills is preferred.	2021–31	Market potential very high	
Services	Semi-skilled	Wind turbine service technician	Applicants must have a postsecondary or non-degree qualification.			

Recommendations for United Arab Emirates

Key messages

- There is high demand mainly in health, ICT, green energy and hospitality sector occupations.
- There is a high level of unfilled vacancies in the health sector, particularly for doctors, nurses, and caregivers. Projected demand for newly registered nurse positions will be 200,000 per annum from 2016 to 2026.
- Wages and benefits are highly attractive, with average annual wages at US\$74,738 per annum.
- In the medium and long term, health sector workers have the highest potential in the United States.
- English language proficiency is a mandatory requirement for all categories of employees.
- There is a strict procedure for recognition of foreign qualifications.

Recommendations

- The US Citizenship and Immigration Services should be used as a government source to create awareness of the opportunities in the country. The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment can have a link to this site.
- Professional and semi-skilled migration should get greater concentration.
- The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment should maintain a separate job portal for the United States.
- Education and training should be expanded into high-demand sectors, such as medical doctors, nurses and adult caregivers.
- Evidence-based migration should be promoted; for example, encourage interested migrant workers to use LinkedIn and other personal pathways.
- Mutually beneficial migration should continue through bilateral labour agreements.

Specific requirements for medical practitioners – Doctors

- Most migrants with experience in practising with foreign qualifications require re-enrolling academically, especially when the curriculum differs from overseas training.
- They are called international medical graduates; 31.8 per cent of physicians are foreign trained in the United States.
- It is longer for an international medical graduate to become a doctor than a medical school graduate of an American school.
- Visas are possible to work as a doctor in the United States:
 - H1B VIA – international medical graduate physicians are restricted to work in the location mentioned in their non-immigrant petition and labour condition application.
 - J1 Visa
 - O-1 Visa
 - TN Visa (only for Canadian and Mexican citizens).
 - Immigrant visa (permanent residency, Green Card)
- Applicants must receive Educational Commission for Foreign Medical Graduates verification that the degree obtained by foreign medical graduates is listed on the World Directory of Medical Schools.
- Applicants must complete all missing medical education requirements.
- Applicants must pass the required United States' medical licensing exams.
- Applicants must go through residency programmes for foreign medical graduates.
- Applicants must obtain final certification from the Educational Commission for Foreign Medical Graduates.

Specific requirements for nurses

- Applicants can transform any bachelor's degree into a nursing degree. Migrants can become a registered nurse in two years with the Accelerated Nursing Master Entry Professional Nursing programme, which is designed for highly motivated individuals who have a prior bachelor's degree in a non-nursing field. Once admitted, students must maintain a 3.0 or greater cumulative grade point average throughout the programme. This accelerated, year-round programme allows qualified individuals to graduate with a Master of Science in Nursing following completion of two years of full-time study.
- Participation in this combined undergraduate and master's degree programme at Western Kentucky University will allow individuals to concurrently complete a Bachelor of Science in Nursing and a Master of Science in Nursing. Following completion of the Master Entry Professional Nursing programme, individuals are eligible to sit for the licensing exam.

Germany

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
There are no established channels for job recruitment in Germany. It is usually through a subsidiary or business partner company in Sri Lanka or through LinkedIn social media network.	- Lack of German or English fluency to converse - German Tech students not fluent in German - IT sector has fewer or no barriers for German language fluency - Migrant workers from Poland, Croatia, Philippines and India provide cheap labour, with advantage of language proficiency in English - Inability to find opportunities to match with skills and qualifications (some qualified Sri Lankan lawyers work at hotels or restaurants)	- Language proficiency in German - English language proficiency	Work visa is acquired through the employer for a contract period of 2–3 years. Postgraduate or master's programme students can obtain a visa through a university sponsorship.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional or skilled Health sector: nurse, caregiver (knowledge in German is essential) IT sector: Software and hardware engineer (more hardware and software engineering and cyber security-related opportunities, including in Estonia, a neighbouring country to Germany that also has more opportunities for IT sector migrants)	German language skills are essential for all job categories. Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. This includes the degree and diploma in nursing and Sri Lankan nursing registration as well as a certificate course in caregiving for adults. German Tech and technical colleges and related vocational training qualifications are recognized (NVQ levels 4–7). IELTS and German language proficiency are essential.	Minimum work experience of 3–5 years for all professional and skilled categories is required. Work experience commendation certificates are much recognized in the similar capacity or field.
Skilled and semi-skilled Construction and automobile industries (as an industrial hub, Germany has more opportunities for the semi-skilled migrants in technical jobs, such as electrician, plumber and welder in construction field as well as motor mechanics and technicians in the automobile industry)		

Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years
Professional and skilled Health sector: adult caregiver, mental health caregiver Cyber security (highly paid jobs with no language barrier) Green energy and technology engineer, technician in the industrial sector

German labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Health and care	Skilled, professional	Doctor	Applicants must have graduated from medical studies from a country of the European Union, the European Economic Area or Switzerland, or they must have graduated from medical studies from another country or successfully passed examination of professional knowledge (Kenntnisprüfung German language exam) in Germany. They must have medical German at C1 level and pass the Medical German Language Test.	In the Shortage Occupation List in 2023, and demand for these jobs are expected in the next few years too.	€50,000 per annum upwards for skilled professionals Students are provided work visa upon completion of the study programme. Students are allowed to work part-time while studying.
Health and care	Skilled, professional	Nursing staff	Applicants must have a university degree and a registered nurse license from Sri Lanka. They also must have good command of the German language, at level B1 or B2 from the GOETHE/TELC/OSD.		
Information technology	Skilled, professional	IT specialist	Applicants must have completed vocational training in the IT field or comparable experience. Fluent in English and German is a plus.	In the Shortage Occupation List in 2023, and demand for these jobs are expected in the next few years too.	
Information technology	Skilled, professional	Software developer Software engineer	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree in computer science, engineering or a related field. They are expected to have a basic understanding of cloud computing concepts and a strong willingness to learn. Experience with programming languages, such as Python, Java or Node.js, is expected.		
Climate technician	Skilled, professional	GIS geodata specialist	Applicants must have bachelor's degree in land management, forestry, geoinformatics, geomatics, remote sensing or similar field. Basic GIS knowledge (QGIS or ArcGIS) is preferred.		
Construction	Skilled, professional	Civil engineering Mechanical engineer	Applicants must have at least 5 years of experience in similar capacity and a diploma or master's degree in civil engineering or mechanical engineering. Several years of experience within infrastructure projects. They must be fluent in English and German, while knowledge of French and/or another language is an asset.		
Construction	Low-skilled labour	Construction worker Welder Carpenter	Applicants must have at the least 1 or 2 years of experience in civil construction is preferable. Fluent communication skills in German is preferred.		

Recommendations for Germany

- An MOU with the relevant German government authorities should be established that identifies specific job categories for Sri Lankan migrants.
- German Tech should establish a compulsory German language course in the study programme to prepare aspiring migrant workers to work in Germany.
- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to provide short duration German language courses to be learned before leaving the country.
- A quality matching framework should be adopted by the Sri Lankan Government through the universities and technical colleges.
- With more opportunities in the industrial sector, German Tech could be established as a pathway to cater to the job market in Germany.

United Kingdom

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities found in LinkedIn, web searches, personal contacts, migration consultants and British job agents.	- Lack of fluency in English to converse - Migrant workers from African countries and neighbouring Eastern European countries get more opportunities due to their language fluency - Nurses offered lower-scale jobs at residential homes and nursing homes as community caregivers until they obtain a Nursing and Midwifery Council certificate to become a nursing officer - Some employers require shadowing period of 3 months - Work permit hours are reduced by some agents deviating from the agreement	- Language proficiency in (English) - Soft skills (skills in customer care, mannerisms) - Driver's license (All domiciliary care workers need to visit homes. Sri Lanka driver's license is valid only for one year period until the British license is obtained.)	Work visa directly arranged by the employer. Applicants for student and job visa can migrate to the country along with spouse and family through dependant visa category. Student visa is available for post-graduate studies in British universities. Student visa applicants are allowed to work 20 hours per week, as are dependants. * Mostly find jobs in hospitality industry, hotels and restaurants. Visit visa and dependant visa offered to only the immediate relatives for short stays.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled Health sector: medical doctor, dentist, pharmacist, nurse and adult caregiver IT-related: software engineer, system developer	Qualifications for medical professionals and health sector-skilled employees. Sri Lankan academic and professional qualifications related to medical (Bachelor of Medicine, Bachelor of Surgery) and postgraduate, degree or diploma level for health professionals are recognized. To become eligible to work as a medical doctor, a degree in medicine recognized by the General Medical Council, which takes 5 years, a foundation course of general training, which takes 2 years, specialist training, which can take between 5 and 8 years depending on the specialty.	Minimum work experience of 3-5 years for all professional and skilled categories.
Skilled and semi-skilled Hospitality sector: chef in hotels and restaurants		Certificates related to work experience add more points during the evaluation in addition to the academic or professional qualifications.
Low-skilled <i>Low-skilled jobs are not offered to Sri Lankan migrant workers. These are filled mostly through eastern European country migrant workers (Romania, Poland, Czech Republic).</i> <i>*Opportunities for female nurses than male</i> <i>*Other professions equal opportunity given for both gender</i>		Sri Lankan experienced nurses of the government sector with high IELTS score band are generally absorbed to the National Health Service of England.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
	To pursue postgraduate studies, an individual must register with the General Medical Council. To practise medicine, an applicant must hold a registration with a license to practise. Holding a license allows, for example, prescribing medicine and treating patients. To work as a nurse, an applicant must have a degree or diploma in nursing and must be registered with the Nursing and Midwifery Council. There are four nursing specialisms (adult, children, mental health and learning disability) Should take the Academic Module for Nursing and Midwifery Council registration, along with the IELTS for UK visas and immigration. The test consists of listening, reading, writing and speaking components, with 9 the highest score possible in each category. The Nursing and Midwifery Council overall score and all subtests except for writing as 6.5 is acceptable. A certificate course in caregiving for the adult caregivers or nurses is required to obtain a Nursing and Midwifery Council certification within 6 months to 1 year period. IT professional applicants must have a local or foreign bachelor's degree programmes in ICT-related postgraduate studies. Chef applicants must have a technical college or hotel school of management or related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4–7). Language proficiency requires an IELTS score above 7; high fluency in English is a must for all applicants.	Students have to submit an IELTS score to get admission to nursing colleges in the United Kingdom minimum of 6.5 or above. Others could work as a care assistant to gain experience for 6 months – one year and get the Nursing and Midwifery Council certification to become a nurse in the United Kingdom. Medical and health professionals find more opportunities in the United Kingdom as Sri Lankan professionals are highly recognized in England due to their skills, competency and commitment to work.
Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years		

Health sector: nurse, caregiver for ageing population (Since the ageing population in UK on the rise, there will be opportunities continued for health professionals, such as nurses and caregivers.)

IT sector: software engineer in cyber security

Hotel and restaurant sector: food and beverage, housekeeping

* There will be a policy change in the United Kingdom in 2024 regarding imposing of restrictions on the dependant visa category for students.

Ireland

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process	Recommendations
Job opportunities are found through personal contacts and LinkedIn. <i>*Non-European Union citizens require work visa through recruitment agencies.</i>	- Lack of fluency in English to converse - Supply of labour from neighbouring countries, such as eastern Europe - Essential requirements for medical professionals and nursing jobs to register with Irish Medical Council	- Language proficiency in (English) - Soft skills (all jobs) - Skills in customer care, teamwork	There are several visa options: Short stay of 90 days, long stay and re-entry students and job visa seekers can migrate with spouse and family through dependent visa. Work visa are obtained directly through employers and personal contacts. Student visa applicants apply through universities. Students are allowed to work 20 hours per week. The long stay D visa is for those intending to live and work in Ireland. These include study, employment, join a family member and volunteer visas.	- English language skills development programmes should be available at the universities and colleges. - Job-specific training must be updated with the technological advancements in overseas. - Knowledge in handling of technological devices used in overseas countries should be given to all the applicants prior departure. For instance, the training given for housekeeping has to be updated with know-how to use the equipment.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years

Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience	Work experience
Professional and skilled Specialist, registrar, consultant doctor in multiple specialties: emergency medicine, paediatrics, general medicine, anaesthesia, obstetrics and gynaecology, family medicine, psychiatry	For medical professionals and health care-related jobs, the Sri Lankan academic and professional qualifications related to medical (Bachelor of Medicine, Bachelor of Surgery) and postgraduate, degree, diploma level for health professionals accepted and recognized.	Minimum work experience of 3–5 years is required for all professional and skilled categories.	Salaries range from £47,000 to £70,000 per annum for professional and skilled employees.
Health care: nurse, radiologist and pharmacist Engineering: chemical engineer, biomedical engineer, automobile and energy engineer IT software engineering: data analyst, programmer and IT support specialist, cyber security Business and finance: financial adviser, accountant and risk and compliance professional Transport and logistics: supply chain manager and analyst and transport manager Hospitality: chef, restaurant staff	Applicants must have diploma in nursing and Sri Lanka nursing registration. A certificate course in caregiving for adult caregivers. Relevant clinical experience (relevant post-qualification experience and training) and excellent communication skills and IELTS or Occupational English Test if applicable are expected. Sri Lankan academic and professional qualifications related to electrical engineering mechanical or civil engineering are recognized. Applicants must have a degree, postgraduate degree or higher national diploma level for software engineering.	Work experience certificates in the similar capacity or field are highly recognized and given more weightage during the selection process.	
<i>* There are no opportunities available for low-skilled workers.</i>			

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years			
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience	Work experience
	Business and finance applicants must have a degree or postgraduate degree in finance, management or accounting or be chartered or be Chartered Institute of Management Accountants-qualified. Transport and logistics applicants must have a degree or postgraduate degree in supply chain management or logistics. Hospitality applicants must have a Ceylon Hotel School or any other private hotel school qualification as a chef, with work experience in a hotel chain.		

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years			
IT professional			
Nurse, adult caregiver			
Green energy engineer, automobile engineer			

United Kingdom labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Construction	Low-skilled	Bricklayer Roofer Carpenter Plasterer	Applicants must have a minimum of 1 year of experience, a basic set of skills in most construction disciplines, driver's license or Construction Skills Certification Scheme for bricklayers and plasters, advanced carpentry skills for carpenters. Relevant certifications or apprenticeships in plastering is preferred.	Predicted to be included in the Shortage Occupation List		For full-time workers, the average salary in 2022 was £33,000. Part-time employees earned an average of £12,247 in 2022. Medical doctor and IT professional salary ranges from £50,000 to £280,000 per annum. The basic pay for a registered nurse ranges from £22,816 to £28,407 a year, for a 37.5-hour week.
Seafood	Low-skilled	Fisherfolk Trawler skipper Experienced deckhand	Applicants must have skills in safe navigation of the vessel, maintaining the vessel to a high standard and using fishing technique. Experience in a similar role is preferred. A relevant certification for skippers and deckhands, such as RYA/MCA/STCW (yacht master) certification, medical and first aid certificate are essential.		Training and experience in fisherfolk role can lead to career growth as a skipper or marine engineer	
Health services	Skilled, professional	Public health manager and director	Applicants must have experience in management or leadership in the relevant sector or a relevant professional qualification.	In the Shortage Occupation List in 2023, and demand for these jobs are expected in the next few years too.	Potential market if equipped with work experience and fluent in English	
Nuclear Industry	Skilled, professional	Chemical scientist	Applicants must have a bachelor's, master's or PhD degree in chemistry or related disciplines, industry and research experience.			
Domiciliary care services	Skilled, semi-skilled, professional	Residential, day and domiciliary care manager and proprietor	Applicants must have a certificate of higher education in relevant field (health, social care management), at least 1 year of experience and skills in team management.		Potential market if equipped with work experience and fluent in English	

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Biological	Skilled, professional	Biological scientist Biochemist	Applicants must have a bachelor's or master's degree in biological sciences, chemistry or relevant field or scientific discipline, industrial or laboratory experience and research, computer literacy.		Potential market	
Construction-related ground engineering industry	Skilled, professional	Engineering Geologist Hydrogeologist Geophysicist	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree or master's in engineering, geoscience, earth sciences, geology, hydrology, hydrogeology, relevant sector experience, with skills in written and verbal communication.		Potential market	
Oil and gas industry	Skilled, professional	Geophysicist Geoscientist Geologist Geochemist Technical services manager in the decommissioning and waste areas of the nuclear industry Senior resource geologist Staff geologist in the mining sector	Applicants must have a bachelor's or master's degree in geosciences, earth sciences, geology, hydrology, hydrogeology, relevant sector experience, with skills in written and verbal communication.			
Social and humanities	Skilled, professional	Archaeologist	Applicants must have a degree in archaeology or a related discipline, knowledge of relevant lab techniques and methods, with skills in time management, planning, etc. and field work experience.			
Engineering	Skilled, professional	Civil engineer Mechanical engineer Electrical engineer	Applicants must have a bachelor's or advanced degree (master's) in engineering field, experience similar engineering roles, a detailed oriented mindset, critical thinking and problem-solving skills.		Potential very high	

Recommendations for United Kingdom and Ireland

Key messages

- There is high demand in the United Kingdom for medical and health professionals, IT and hospitality sector occupations; while in Ireland it is for medical and health professionals, IT, chemical, biomedical, automobile and energy engineers, business and finance, transport and logistics and the hospitality sector.
- There is a high level of unfilled vacancies in the United Kingdom. After the pandemic, the United Kingdom has seen an unprecedented increase in work visas granted. The economy is suffering from a labour shortage, with an estimated 1 million vacancies, which is 300,000 more than before the pandemic. In the short term, the United Kingdom has high potential for new migration opportunities.
- Wages and benefits are highly attractive, at £22,816–£28,407 a year for a nurse.
- In the medium and long term, health care workers have the highest potential for finding employment. The United Kingdom has a separate visa category for health care workers and publishes a separate list of shortage professions for this category.
- UK Visas and Immigration is a division of the Home Office, which is responsible for the visas and immigration system, at www.gov.uk/government/organisations/uk-visas-and-immigration.
- A batch of 300 nurses were interviewed for jobs, but only three of them were selected due to their poor language skills.

Recommendations

- Professional and semi-skilled migration should be a concentrated focus.
- English language proficiency is a mandatory requirement for all categories of employees, who are required to pass the language proficiency test in English. Therefore, initiate public private partnerships to polish up language skills of the aspiring candidates. Along with the language skills, soft skills, communication skills, how to face interviews, etiquette and work ethics should also be included.
- Currently the most prominent pathways for work in the United Kingdom for Sri Lankans are either informal or personal. The graduate worker stream is used mostly for migration to the United Kingdom. Those who migrate directly for jobs use LinkedIn or personal pathways. Therefore, a system to connect the potential workers to opportunities must be established.
- Mutually beneficial migration should continue through bilateral labour agreements.
- Information sessions should be organized on job market prospects and application procedures, qualification and experience requirements and other entry requirements for the United Kingdom and Ireland.

Canada

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Applicants find job opportunities through personal contacts, agents, migration consultants, websites and the government website – Canada connect. Canada has one of the most generous immigration policies in the world, with many pathways for skilled workers to apply for Canada permanent residency. Express Entry is Canada's fastest and most popular immigration programme. Candidates that apply through the Express Entry system can receive permanent residence status as fast as six months. The country also offers many immigration programmes specifically designed for software engineers. Skilled migrants who come with a visit visa can search for a job and convert the visitor visa into a work permit, though they need to renew their contract annually.	• Lack of English fluency to converse • Indian IT professionals find more job opportunities due to language proficiency • Government restrictions imposed time to time on migration policy • Most professionals sacrifice their current job and engage in lower-level job • Some low-level jobseekers are qualified with degree or master's degree or professional qualifications • Difficulty level of the TOFEL and IELTS exams (Many students consider IELTS easier than TOEFL, especially the reading sections. In IELTS, the reading question samples are from magazines, books, journals and newspapers. The TOEFL reading passages are from academic textbooks and academic publications.) • Lack of soft skills and skills to follow instructions • Need for structured and organized mindset and high level of integrity • Analytical ability • Good verbal and written communication skills in English • Must pass physical, drug screen and background and pre-employment screening checks • The severe cold climate may be a challenge for some to survive.	• Language proficiency in English • Soft skills and knowledge in the use of technology • Country-specific information • Use of technology and devices	Work permits are issued in two pathways: the International Mobility Program and the Temporary Foreign Worker Program. The work visa is offered through the employer only. The visit visa (tourist) is valid for 90 days. Arrival of foreigners to Canada has increased through student visa since the Government relaxed regulations on work permit for students. Student visa through the affiliated university. The Government offers unlimited number of working hours for students for part-time jobs. Permanent residency is possible and many people migrate as a family, considering the benefits for children. Family sponsorships are allowed, including for a spouse, partner, children, parents and grandparents. The Express Entry Program is the quickest way to get permanent residency in Canada. However, one must be a highly skilled individual to get into this programme. The pathway is points-based, and applicants will score on their experience, qualifications, education and skills. This is a stream within the express entry programme. Many migrants enter the country with a visit visa and then get a work permit. Within 2 years, they can apply for permanent residency.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled Nurse, caregiver (widely available – nursing is among the most in-demand jobs due to a labour shortage that is expected to persist) Laboratorist, lab assistant, immunologist, allergiologist Software and hardware engineer (IT sector has more hardware and software engineering, cyber security-related opportunities; Canada offers migration programme for software engineers) Mechanical engineering, electrical engineering technician, construction project manager estimator, project engineer, civil engineering, project manager and civil engineering technician (most in-demand jobs) Skilled technician: electrician, plumber, welder in construction field Hospitality: chef, restaurant staff <i>*Professionals can engage in a lower category of job and then find suitable opportunities with their qualifications and skills.</i>	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. Most of the professional applicants need a degree, but that degree should be obtained in the Canadian education system. Applicants need to follow the Canadian qualifications to practise as medical practitioners and to pursue another degree in Canada to be a professional in that area. Medical practitioner applicants must have a Bachelor of Medicine or Bachelor of Surgery to practise directly because the basic level of study to practice is postgraduate medicine in the United States. International medical graduates need to complete some supervised medical training or assessment to make sure they meet licensure educational requirements. International doctors also must complete a year of supervised medical training and practice before they can be allowed to practise in Canada. Nurse applicants must have a degree in nursing and Sri Lanka nursing registration. Caregivers must have a certificate course in caregiving for the adult caregivers. * Required to follow Canadian Nursing school programme to obtain the registration to perform as a nurse. There are ample opportunities for newcomers to work in nursing in cities across the country. German Tech, technical colleges and related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4–7) are recognized. TOFEL or English language proficiency is essential for professional and skilled. Civil engineer applicants must have a vocational training institution qualification.	Minimum work experience of 3–5 years is required for professional and skilled categories. Health sector employees must fulfil training hours in Canada.

Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years
Nurse, adult caregiver (Registered nurses work in traditional and specialized health care settings or in other community settings, such as hospitals, nursing homes, extended-care facilities, community health agencies, health centres and walk-in clinics. Nurses may also be self-employed. There is a movement towards community-based health care, so in the future, there may be fewer jobs in hospitals and more in public health areas. While the pandemic created an urgent need, the demand for registered nurses stems from Canada's ageing population, which will require more health services. The increasing demand is also affected by nurses who are retiring from the workforce. For registered nurses and registered psychiatric nurses, new job openings are projected for 2019–28 (arising from expansion demand and replacement demand) to total 191,100, while 154,600 new jobseekers (arising from school leavers, immigration and mobility) are expected to be available to fill them, according to the Canadian Occupational Projections System.) IT professional in software development, cyber security and AI (more opportunities and highly paid jobs) Electrical engineer, civil engineer in construction field Green energy and technology engineer and technician Laboratory staff, including immunologist, allergiologist Education sector: pre-grade childcare assistant Construction sector: plumber, mason, welder

Canadian labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Professional, scientific and technical services	Skilled, professional	Business intelligence analyst Business development professional Manager Engineer (mining, geology, petroleum, civil, mechanical, electric, etc.) Graphic designer and illustrator Desktop publishing operator and related occupations Web designer and developer	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree or relevant certification, with or without experience. Time management and communication skills are expected.	2020–30	According to 2023 figures, the average (mean) salary in Canada is CA\$72,200 per year, or \$6,017 per month, for full-time employees. The average full time caregiver salary in Canada is CA\$35,588 per year or CA\$18.25 per hour. Entry-level positions start at CA\$29,250 per year, while most experienced workers make up to CA\$44,967 per year. The average nurse salary in Canada is CA\$71,894 per year or CA\$36.87 per hour. Entry-level positions start at CA\$57,383 per year. IT sector and engineering jobs are among the well-paid jobs in the labour market.
Public administration					
Finance, insurance, real estate, rental, leasing	Semi-skilled, skilled	Securities agent, investment dealers and broker Other financial officer	Applicants must have a degree or post-secondary education plus industry experience, a strong understanding of financial terminology, skills in handling MS office package and communication and presentation skills. They also must have proficiency in English and other languages (exceptional) and a driving license. Owning a vehicle is preferred for brokers.	2020–30	
Information, culture, recreation	Semi-skilled, skilled	Supervisor, library, correspondence and related information worker Supervisor, mail and message distribution occupations	Applicants must have a degree or a secondary education qualification, with excellent matching or recognition skills and the ability to pay close attention to detail. They also must have basic knowledge of relevant computer systems.	2020–30	
Educational services	Skilled, professional	Post-secondary teaching and research assistant	Applicants must have a degree or a college or non-university certificate. They must have research skills, with at least 1 year of experience.	2020–30	

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Construction	Semi-skilled	Construction millwright and industrial mechanic	Applicants must have the relevant professional qualification, a millwright certificate or equivalent, industry experience (3–5 years), skills in interpersonal relationships, leadership, handling MS office package, good communication and a team spirit.	2020–30	
Health care, social assistance	Skilled, professional	Specialist physician Registered nurses and registered psychiatric nurse Dentist Pharmacist Dietitians and nutritionist Health policy researcher, consultant and programme officer	Applicants must have a degree in medicine, health sciences, public health or a relevant professional qualification (licensing by the College of Pharmacists of British Columbia, for example), experience in a relevant field, relevant licensure by provincial or territorial authorities, ability to maintain effective relationships and time management skills.	2020–30	
Wholesale and retail trade	Semi-skilled, skilled	Technical sales specialist for wholesale trade	Applicants must have a school graduate degree in a business-related field, the ability to work with MS office package and have good interpersonal and communication skills.	2020–30	
Manufacturing					
Utilities	Skilled, professional	Utilities manager	Applicants must be a school graduate or have professional qualification in a relevant field, with experience in a similar sector (3–5 years), along with skills for working in a challenging environment, driving changes and strong communication.	2020–30	

Recommendations for Canada

- The Canadian Government's website for migrant workers is Canada Connect, and there is need to create awareness of it among potential migrants in Sri Lanka.
- There is also need to establish a formal pathway through the Ministry of Foreign Employment and the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment for aspiring migrant workers to discover Canadian job opportunities.
- An MOU with the relevant authorities and the Ministry of Foreign Employment in Sri Lanka, through the Canadian Embassy, would help to identify the job categories that are in demand that Sri Lankans could fill.
- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to enhance the language skills of aspiring migrants to prepare them for work in Canada as well as impart other country specifics, like information on the climate, job ethics, values and the culture to prepare them for life in Canada.
- There should be a government-to-government MOU to obtain job quotas from Canada because there is much potential.
- The most available and easily accessed job opportunities are in the blue-collar and skilled categories , which should thus be targeted.

Specific requirements for medical practitioners in Canada

To become a medical doctor in Canada, an individual needs to earn a bachelor's degree, which takes four years. After completing, enter medical school, followed by a residency programme, which typically takes three to five years. Admission to medical school is very competitive and requires having a high grade point average. An individual must pass the Medical College Admission Test with a high score. Medical school should be registered in the world directory of medical schools. The Medical Council of Canada should verify that immigrants' medical credentials are equivalent to the Canadian credential. The Medical Council of Canada Qualifying Examination Part 1 should be passed before arriving in Canada. An applicant should have 12 months of training in their home country. Licentiate of the Medical Council of Canada fees must be paid. An applicant must have a work permit, be proficient in English, pass the local licensee and the Medical Study-abroad Aptitude Test and pass the Medical Council of Canada Evaluating Examination. It is taken at the end of medical studies and before residency.

Specific requirements for nurses in Canada

An applicant must first apply to the National Nursing Assessment Service and submit documents that will allow them to register as a nurse in Canada. It is a national online application service developed by nursing regulatory bodies in Canada. Applying to the National Nursing Assessment Service is an essential first step to work in Canada and an applicant must have an account with the Service. Once this is set up, the applicant can submit all relevant documents and complete the file. The National Nursing Assessment Service will evaluate the applicant's file and provide an Advisory Report. There is a demand for registered nurses with skills and experience in specialty areas, such as emergency, critical care and operating room, and for nurses willing to work in smaller or isolated communities. Applicants must have completed a nursing programme that is equivalent to a four-year bachelor's degree in nursing or a practical nursing diploma, and they must have evidence of their nursing practice. This is in the category for which the nurse applicant is applying within the three years prior to issuance of a Certificate of Registration. Applicants applying for registered nurse must have completed the Canadian Practical Nurse Registration Exam for those applying for a registered practical nurse. Also, completion of the Registered Nurse and Registered Practical Nurse Jurisprudence Examination. Evidence of language proficiency in either English or French is required.

France

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process recommendations
France is a highly restricted and controlled job market for migrant workers. Priority is given to workers from the French colony countries. Highly skilled local workers can apply for job opportunities listed in websites. If employers don't find required qualifications from such candidates, they make a request for the Government to find a suitable person from outside and offer free visa for them. Job opportunities are found mostly through personal contacts.	- Lack of fluency in French and English - French language required for health sector professionals, such as dentists and nurses	- Language proficiency in French (required for professional categories) - English language proficiency (required)	A "high tech visa" is available for professional categories. The work visa provided directly through the employer. Permanent residency can be applied only through refugee visa at the moment. A social security number is needed for refugee visa. Students can apply to bachelor's or master's degree programmes. Students are allowed to work part-time while studying. After completing their degree, students can apply for jobs and settle down in France with a work visa. *Visit visa to France does not allow for work permits.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled IT professional in system development and hardware functions Dentist, nurse, health care assistant *There are few semi-skilled opportunities for plumbers, electricians, etc. *There are fewer Sri Lankan skilled workers in France due to the recruitment restrictions for migrant workers.	<i>(French language skills are preferred for all the categories of jobs.)</i> Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized for health and IT sector professionals. The Higher National Diploma level for nursing is recognized. For semi-skilled applicants, the German Tech, technical colleges and related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4-7) are recognized. IELTS and French language proficiency are essential.	A minimum work experience of 3-5 years is required for all professional and skilled categories.
Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years		

The focus will continue to provide opportunities to the colonial countries for semi-skilled and low-skilled workers.

High tech visa, with a 2-year contract and extendable visa

Adult caregiver, nursing officer in health sector

French labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Health, caregiving	Skilled, professional	Doctor	A medical degree from a nationally recognized university is required, with 5 years of clinical experience. Applicants must have finished medical school and specialty training and must have a certificate demonstrating conformity with European Union directives. Applicants also must be proficient in French to practise as a medical practitioner in France. And they must have good French language level, such as B2.	2022–30	Minimum salary of €1,700–€4,000 per month for skilled and professional jobs
Health and care	Skilled, professional	Nurse Nursing assistant	A bachelor's degree in nursing is enough for applicants who studied in the European Union. Anyone with a nursing degree from a non-European Union country needs to have their degree evaluated and will most likely need to continue their study in France. Proof of French language skills is required.	2022–30	
Health and care	Skilled, professional	Midwife	At least two years of professional experience as a midwife are required, along with recent clinical experience (at least six months within the past 24 months). If working as an independent midwife, previous experience must include extensive numbers of deliveries as well as prenatal and postnatal care and relevant experience in hospital settings.		
Health and care	Skilled, professional	Hospital administrator	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree in health administration or a related field, such as nursing, health management, public health or public policy. While a bachelor's degree is an entry-level requirement for most hospital administration jobs, many employers might prefer candidates with a relevant master's degree.		
Health and care	Low-skilled	Caregiver Maintenance worker Domestic worker	No high school diploma is required. But applicants must have completed a four-year programme and pass the certification exam for home carers for older persons or people with disabilities. Experience in similar capacity is preferable.		

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Information technology	Skilled, professional	Security analyst IT technician Software developer Software engineer	An academic degree in computer science, IT or equivalent is required. Applicants must have 5 or more years of experience in technology and be fluent in English. French is a plus.		
Transportation	Low-skilled	Driver of all types	At least 5 years of experience working as a professional driver is required.		
Education	Skilled, professional	School teacher Childcare specialist	Bachelor's degree in the subject an applicant wants to teach is required, as well as a certificate or degree in education, preferably a master's degree.		

Recommendations for France

- Sri Lanka should identify long-term opportunities for the future and work towards establishing ties with the Government for migrant workers to access jobs in France.
- Sri Lanka should establish government-to-government MOUs to channel opportunities for the professionals and skilled jobseekers.
- French language courses should be offered through public-private partnerships for students at vocational training colleges, nursing schools and language academies.

Australia

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities are found through migration consultants, affiliated universities, LinkedIn, websites and personal contacts. Australia opened up for skilled migration after the COVID-19 pandemic and in several visa categories to fill the labour shortages. The federal Government is promoting skilled migration to Australia. In 2023, a policy was introduced to attract professionals to Australia. Department of Home Affairs officials will be deployed to communities to aid directly with employers and communities experiencing critical skills shortages. This initiative will support employers to find the skilled professionals they need to grow and develop their businesses. <i>*More opportunities are available in booming cities in the outskirts of Melbourne and Sydney.</i>	- Poor command of English language - Most applicants look for jobs in Melbourne and Sydney (few applicants focus on the opportunities opening up in peripheral cities, like Adelaide, Perth and Darwin) - IELTS scoring must be in the high band, at 7+ - Persons with a student visa must find a part-time job and accommodation on their own - Varying cost of living - Doctors must fulfil additional qualifications In 2022, 5–16 per cent of employed migrants were paid less than the national minimum wage. Between 1 per cent and 8.5 per cent of recent migrants were paid at least AU\$3 less than the hourly minimum.	- Proficiency in oral and written English language - Soft skills, such as critical thinking, agile leadership, digital literacy, flexibility, learning mindset and data literacy - Awareness and knowledge of the technology used in Australia	The Australian Department of Home Affairs issues visas through applications. Applicants must meet the relevant English language requirements. An online skills assessment test is required to discover the eligibility for a visa that will allow an applicant to migrate to Australia permanently. At the end of the eligibility assessment, a point score is provided. A minimum of 65 points is required to be eligible to apply for an Australian skilled migration visa. Skilled independent visa lets invited workers with skills to live and work permanently anywhere in Australia. Skilled nominated visa is an employer-sponsored visa for a skilled position by an approved sponsor. Student visa requires a university invitee letter. Students are provided a work visa upon completion of their study programme. Students are allowed to work part-time while studying. The time they should spend applying for a work visa is different based on the practical issues. Dependants can be accommodated and start working. Work visa and skilled migration are required for permanent residency.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Immediate and mid-term, 1–2 years Skilled workers (list of jobs with skill shortages)	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized in Australia as a basic qualification. Applicants must be younger than 45 years.	Minimum work experience of 3–5 years is required for all professional and skilled categories. Doctors are required to have 5–8 years of experience as a practitioner. Nurses must have 36 months of paid clinical experience for the past five years. Applicants must have an educational equivalence that meets the standards of the Australian Health Practitioners Regulation Agency to practise as a registered nurse, and they are required to renew the registration annually.
Professional and skilled Medical practitioner on the Priority Skilled Occupation List Nurse, caregiver in hospitals and aged care homes Fluency in English language is essential. Construction sector: civil engineer, electrical engineer, architect Software and hardware engineer (IT sector has more hardware and software engineering and cyber security-related opportunities) BPO companies Education sector: tutor, lecturer, lab assistant Finance and banking: accountant, auditor Hospitality sector: pastry chef, demi chef (assistant chef) Skilled technicians Electrician, plumber, welder in construction field	There are additional qualifications to be fulfilled in Australia for a few professions: doctors and nurses must take several exams that are conducted by Australia before entering a professional job, but they also can get exemptions for the subject that they completed from Sri Lanka. Based on direction from the Australian Government, applications for medical practitioners (doctors) will be prioritized, including individuals providing critical or specialist medical services, critical skills required to maintain the supply of essential goods and services or delivering services in sectors critical to Australia's economic recovery. Nurses can have a bachelor's degree in nursing but they must have the Sri Lanka nursing registration and bridging courses in Australia. To become a registered nurse in Australia, applicants need a Bachelor of Nursing from a university. Nursing degrees are a mix of theory, simulation lab work and clinical placement in various settings. Registration to practise as a nurse is done by application to the Nursing and Midwifery Board of Australia, which will conduct a skills assessment test. Caregivers must have a certificate course in caregiving for adults. In the construction sector, civil engineers and architects must have a bachelor's degree, a postgraduate degree or Higher National Diploma in Accountancy with experience. Software and hardware engineers need a bachelor of science degree in IT and have experience. University lecturers and tutors must have lecturing experience at local or foreign universities or as a lab assistant in major disciplines, such as microbiology, management, accountancy and finance, economics and IT. Accountant and auditor applicants must have a bachelor's degree in accounting and finance from the Institute of Chartered Accountants of Sri Lanka or Chartered Institute of Management Accountants or Association of Chartered Certified Accountants qualifications. Technicians need qualification from German Tech, technical colleges or related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4–7). People who have trained in vocational training institutions and Higher National Diploma in Accountancy fall under skilled workers category in Australia. In the hospitality sector, pastry chefs and demi chefs (assistant chefs) are required to have experience in the hotel sector along with paper qualifications. As for language proficiency, the IELTS score must be in the high band (6.5–7+), but English language proficiency is essential. To become a registered nurse in Australia, applicants must have an English language score of 7.0 in all modules (or OET B).	

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years

* The Australian Government is directing immigrant workers to cities beyond Sydney and Melbourne that are in need of labour and those economies that cannot fill jobs with local workers.

The migration programme also continues to focus on growing the Australian economy and filling skill gaps.

* Australia recently amended its migration worker policy to open up more opportunities for skilled professionals in 2023 and 2024.

Nurse, midwife, caregivers for adults (because the ageing population is large, there will be increased demand for caregivers for older persons)

Cyber security and system development in IT sector

Business process outsourcing and online jobs (hybrid)

Green energy, technology engineer, technician

Pastry chef, demi chef, bar worker, steward

Australian labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Accounting	Skilled, professional	Accountant	A degree in accounting or related field or equivalent or a combination of experience and education or training and undertaking or willing to commence chartered accountant or certified public accountant studies is required. As well, proficiency in accounting systems, preferably Sage, along with 2-3 years of working experience within a financial support position. Applicants must have demonstrated understanding and experience in the application of accounting principles, concepts and practices.	Both short and medium term	High market demand	Australia's median yearly salary in 2022 was AU \$79,800. Australian Bureau of Statistics figures from late 2022 show the median weekly earnings (pre-tax) in Australia was AU\$1,250, with median hourly earnings of \$37 per hour. The Hays Salary Guide 2023-24 indicates most organizations (95 per cent) are planning to increase salaries in the next 12 months, with 66 per cent anticipating rises of more than 3 per cent. Nationally, the gender pay gap sits at 13.3 per cent, which is the lowest on record but still means women lose out on AU\$13,182 in earnings per year on average, when compared to men.
Information technology	Skilled, professional	Software and applications programmer, ICT Business and systems analyst	Applicants must possess a degree or diploma in computer science or a lesser qualification with a minimum of 5 years of experience in a similar role. They must have excellent knowledge of software development processes, procedures and the overall software product lifecycle. They must have significant experience in Agile- or SCRUM-based software development projects and techniques, preferably in a web-based development domain. They must have significant experience working in multiple small teams to successful system outcomes. And they must have significant experience with modern tooling, such as Jira, Confluence, Gitlab, VSCode, Azure DevOps and Visual Studio.	Both short and medium term	High market demand	

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Health	Skilled, professional	Registered nurses Enrolled and mothercraft nurses	Applicants must have current registration with Australian Health Practitioner Regulation Agency and a Bachelor of Nursing (for registered nurses). Enrolled and mothercraft nurses must have an AQF associate degree, advanced diploma or diploma (ANZSCO skill level 2). They must have 1–2 years of experience and a commitment to quality patient care. Compliance with Australian Commission on Safety and Quality in Health Care national standards is expected. They also must have sound clinical decision-making and problem-solving skills. And they must have excellent communication and customer service skills and work well independently and within a team. Basic computer skills are expected.	Both short and medium term	High market demand and rigorous entry criteria	
Hotel and hospitality management	Skilled, low-skilled	Chef, cook	Experience and a minimum of Certification III in commercial cookery are required.	Both short and medium term	High market demand	
Hotel and hospitality management	Skilled, low-skilled	Cafe and restaurant manager	Applicants must have previous role experience (2–4 years) in a similar fast-paced environment (cafe and a la carte restaurant service). And they must have proven leadership experience in a similar-paced environment, with a focus on building teams and driving a high level of service – they should have the wow factor. Exemplary presentation in grooming, presentation and manner are expected, as is an energetic outlook and solutions-focused.	Both short and medium term	High market demand	
Construction Industry	Skilled, professional	Industrial, mechanical and production engineer, civil engineering professional, chemical and materials engineer and mining engineer	Applicants must have an electronical, electromechanical, civil or mechanical high school degree or similar (degree in relevant field). They must have passion, ambition and a commitment to driving positive change. A willingness to learn and build effective communication and relationships inside the business are expected.	3–5 years	High market demand	

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Education	Skilled, professional	University lecturer and tutor	Applicants must have a tertiary-level qualification in the field, with work experience teaching similar subject matter content at the high school level, preferably at the Victorian Certificate of Education level, a foundation studies programme or at the university level. Applicants should be a dynamic individual who is engaging and innovative in their approach and who can smoothly transition into an already established position.	3–5 years	High market demand	
Industrial	Skilled	Motor mechanic	Applicants must be a fully qualified motor mechanic with a recognized motor mechanic trade certificate and full tool kit or they must be a highly skilled motor mechanic with many years (4–5 years preferred) of extensive mechanical experience working on a range of classic English, European and American cars. Servicing and repair experience with a wide variety of vehicles is expected, along with diagnostic and fault identification experience.	3–5 years	High market demand	
Health	Skilled, professional	Medical laboratory scientist	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree or higher degree in science or medical laboratory science or an equivalent qualification, with subjects relevant to pathology from a recognized tertiary institution. They also must have demonstrated knowledge and experience in the delivery of pathology services relevant to the laboratory, including use of laboratory information systems, patient systems and quality control systems and computer programmes, such as Microsoft Office suite.	Both short and medium term	High market demand and rigorous entry criteria	
Health	Skilled, professional	General practitioner and resident medical officer	Applicants must have a general registration with the Australian Health Practitioner Regulations Agency and a minimum of 1 year clinical experience. They also should be competent in providing basic life support measures and have effective interpersonal and communication skills. Proven ability to work effectively in a team and independently as required are also expected.	Both short and medium term	High market demand and rigorous entry criteria	

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Health	Skilled, professional	Specialist physician	Applicants must have a medical degree with extensive postgraduate experience. They should have a specialist registration or ability to acquire specialist registration with the Australian Health Practitioner Regulations Agency. They must have specialist qualification as a physician with a Fellowship of the Royal Australasian College of Physicians or equivalent. And they must have current medical indemnity insurance. Further training and qualifications to specialist level acceptable to the Australian Medical Board and the relevant professional body or association is expected. They also are expected to have a strong understanding of examination methodologies and diagnostics and extensive knowledge of infectious diseases, the symptoms and epidemiology. Comprehensive and current knowledge of medications, side-effects and contraindications is necessary, as is the ability to supervise, manage and mentor other medical officers.	Both short and medium term	High market demand and rigorous entry criteria	

Recommendations for Australia

Key messages

- Australia provides details about opportunities and awareness about the job visa process. Connect with the federal and central government websites for more details, at smartmoveaustrailia.gov.au.
- There is high demand for skilled and semi-skilled workers in four sectors: health, IT, accounting and hospitality.
- In the medium and long term, health care workers have the greatest potential in Australia.
- The most prominent pathways for work in Australia are either informal or personal. People who migrate directly for jobs use LinkedIn or personal pathways. Some also use migration consultants or affiliated universities.
- English language proficiency is a mandatory requirement for all categories of employees.

Recommendations

- The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment should connect with the federal and central government websites for job opportunities for Sri Lankan migrant workers, at smartmoveaustrailia.gov.au.
- The tertiary-level education and training providers should include awareness of the career paths and employment opportunities in overseas countries.
- In addition to technical training, graduates from the universities and technical colleges should be provided with soft and multitasking skills.
- Aspiring migrants should be provided assistance to fulfil entry qualifications and skill sets demanded in destination countries, such as business skills, multitasking skills and job-specific technical skills.
- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to provide short-duration English language courses for persons expecting to work abroad.
- Demand-side information should be provided through country-specific job portals.

Specific requirements for nursing officers

The Australian Health Practitioner Regulation Agency assesses applications for registration from internationally qualified nurses and midwives on behalf of the Nursing and Midwifery Board of Australia. The Board is governed by the Health Practitioner Regulation National Law in each state and territory and is responsible for the final decision on each application.

All internationally qualified nurses and midwives who want to register and work in Australia as a registered nurse, enrolled nurse or midwife must complete an orientation to the Australian health care setting. There are two parts to the orientation: Part 1 must be completed before registration and Part 2 must be completed after registration.

The information provided by candidates during the self-check is checked by the Australian Health Practitioner Regulation Agency at the portfolio stage. At this stage, candidates must provide additional personal and contact information as well as identification and qualification documentation.

The Australian Nursing and Midwifery Accreditation Council takes into consideration work experience when assessing an applicant's qualifications, which is then used to determine suitability for skilled migration. Under the Health Practitioner Regulation National Law, the Nursing and Midwifery Board can only take into account an applicant's qualifications when establishing whether their qualifications are substantially equivalent to an Australian qualification. This is why some applicants may be approved for skilled migration but do not meet the registration requirements of the Nursing and Midwifery Board. International applicants must meet the registration standards and qualification criteria to be eligible for registration.

Programmes of study are available that are bridging courses for internationally qualified nurses and midwives who were required by the National Board to undertake a bridging programme and assessment in accordance with section 53(c) of the Health Practitioner Regulation National Law. They encompass:

- registered nurse-approved programmes of study for bridging for internationally qualified nurses and midwives.
- enrolled nurse-approved programmes of study for bridging for internationally qualified nurses and midwives.
- midwifery-approved programmes of study for bridging for internationally qualified nurses and midwives.

*Bridging programmes are now only available to internationally qualified nurses and midwives who were required by the National Board prior to 2 March 2020 under s 53(c) of the Health Practitioner Regulation National Law to undertake a bridging programme following an assessment of their qualifications. These midwives must have relevant valid documentation permitting completion of an approved bridging programme, (originally) issued prior to 2 March 2020.

A multiple-choice question exam assesses a candidate's professional knowledge. There are separate exams for internationally qualified nurses and midwives intending to register in Australia as a registered nurse, enrolled nurse or midwife: The Objective Structured Clinical Exam is a clinical exam to assess whether candidates demonstrate the knowledge, skills and competence of a graduate-level nurse or midwife from a Nursing and Midwifery Board of Australia-approved programme of study.

Specific requirements for medical doctors

There are four minimum requirements to work as a doctor in Australia with a recognized medical degree:

- job offer;
- skills will be assessed and must be on a registration pathway;
- English proficiency; and
- a visa to work in Australia or permanent residency.

Primary medical qualification must come from a school that is recognized by both:

- Australian Medical Council and
- World Directory of Medical Schools – the University of Colombo Faculty of Medicine is available in this directory.

This applies even if an applicant is a permanent resident or citizen of Australia or New Zealand when enrolled.

Securing a job

Applicants must receive a job offer before applying for registration or a visa, in the following three areas:

- non-specialist;
- specialist; and
- doctor-in-training.

The Australian Medical Council will assess skills as part of the application for registration. For more information on working conditions for student visas, see

<https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/visas/getting-a-visa/visa-listing/student-500/temporary-relaxation-of-working-hours-for-student-visa-holders>.

Dependants of student visa holders can also work, but at fewer hours. For more information on visa types and skill sectors, see

<https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/what-we-do/skilled-migration-programme/what-we-do/legislative-instrument>.

Kuwait

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Professionals and skilled persons typically seek opportunities through personal contacts and direct job orders through Sri Lanka agents. A visit visa (tourist) is used to enter the country and search for a job .	- Indians and Filipinos dominate the labour market with language proficiency and presentable personality - Indian investors offer jobs to their own-country people - Employment granted through foreign employment agents without connecting with the Kuwait Embassy (non-legitimate channels)	- Language skills (mainly a good command of English and the native language) - Presentable personality and appearance - Interview technique - Knowledge of climatic conditions in summer - Awareness of technology used in the country - Culture and food	The employer provides a work visa for a contract period of 2–3 years for domestic workers, professionals and semi-skilled persons.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years

Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Low-skilled Domestic worker (female only)	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. Applicants must have the Higher National Diploma for technicians from German Tech or technical colleges or related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4–7).	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. Applicants must have the Higher National Diploma for technicians from German Tech or technical colleges or related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4–7).
Professional Accountant, engineer, architect, ICT professional, doctor, teacher, hospitality sector assistants , pharmacist, X-ray technician	And applicants must have English language proficiency. Work experience and skills assessment test-based evaluations are done by employers depending on the profession.	And applicants must have English language proficiency. Work experience and skills assessment test-based evaluations are done by employers depending on the profession.
Skilled and semi-skilled Electrician, automobile engineer, AC repair and maintenance, boat repairing, heavy vehicle driver, cleaner		

Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years

Health sector, tourism-related, hospitality, ICT sector, education sector, construction sector
 Technical-related: electrician, automobile engineer, air-conditioning specialist, boat repairer

Kuwaiti labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Construction	Low-skilled	Low-skilled labour	Applicants must have a minimum education level of tenth grade and 1 year of experience. English proficiency (beginner) is expected.	In the Shortage Occupation List in 2023, and demand for these jobs are expected in the next few years too.	High demand in short and medium term	Low-skilled workers earn 75–170 Kuwaiti dinar per month. Skilled workers earn 400 dinar per month. Professional workers earn 2,000–4,000 dinar per month.
Construction	Skilled, professional	Erection engineer Construction engineer Project manager Civil design engineer Building management system engineer	Applicants must have 6–10 years of experience in a similar capacity. Work experience in oil and gas or petrochemical industries is a plus. The education requirements vary depending on the job. For example, erection engineers must have a Bachelor of Technology or Engineering (Electrical); construction engineers must have a bachelor's degree in engineering or Higher National Diploma or a diploma in engineering; project managers can have any level of graduation; civil design engineers need a Bachelor of Technology or Engineering (Civil); BMS engineers need a diploma (electronics, mechanical) or a Bachelor of Technology or Engineering (Electrical, Mechanical) or a bachelor's degree in electrical engineering, mechanical engineering, or a related field. Applicants should be men only. BMS engineer applicants can be any Arab national, Indian, Pakistani or Sri Lankan.			The average monthly salary of a Kuwaiti man in the public sector is 1,929 dinar (US\$6,277). This is 43 per cent more than the average wage of 1,350 dinar (US\$4,393) paid to Kuwaiti women in the public sector.
Construction	Skilled, professional	Protection maintenance engineer Construction specialist Plumber and electrician	Applicants must have a minimum of 5 years of experience. Protection maintenance engineers must have a Bachelor of Engineering or Bachelor of Technology degree in electrical engineering from a National Board of Accreditation-approved institution eligible for Kuwait Society of Engineers membership registration. Construction specialists must have a Bachelor of Technology or Engineering, while plumbers and electricians can have any level of graduation. There are no preferred nationalities generally, but Indians are preferred for plumbers and electricians.			German Tech and related vocational qualifications (NVQ levels 4–7) are recognized and highly paid. Salaries are high, at a minimum of 500,000 Sri Lankan rupees per month for technicians.

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Domestic worker	Low-skilled	House maid House nurse Babysitter	Applicants must have previous experience working as a maid or in a related field. They must have fluency in a certain language (such as English or Arabic). And they should have the physical ability to lift and stand for long periods of time. They must follow instructions and work efficiently.		In the Shortage Occupation List in 2023, and demand for these jobs are expected in the next few years too.	
Information technology	Skilled, professional	Web designer and developer	Applicants must have 3–6 years of experience and a diploma. There is no nationality preference.			
Health	Skilled, professional	BSC nurse	Applicants must have 3–7 years of experience and a Bachelor of Science (Nursing).			
Hospitality management	Semi-skilled, skilled	Waiter Waitress Hostess Bartender and cashier	Applicants must have 2 years of work experience in hotel operations and a relevant degree or diploma in hospitality or tourism management.			
Accounting, finance and administration	Semi-skilled, skilled	Accountant Office administration (female) Sales executive	Applicants must have prior experience. Accountant applicants must have a Bachelor of Commerce, Bachelor of Business Administration (Management), Bachelor of Arts (Economics) or a Chartered Accountant. For office administration, any graduation diploma is needed. Sales executives must have a Bachelor of Science; and business development managers must have a Bachelor of Technology or Engineering.			

Recommendations for Kuwait**Key messages**

- There is stiff competition from Indian and Philippine migrant workers for jobs. Fluency in English and Arabic languages are strong positive factors.
- In addition to construction, ICT and hospitality are two important sectors for Sri Lanka to promote migration to Kuwait.

Recommendations

- Immediate vacancies for 2023, such as in the ICT, hospitality, health and construction sectors, should be targeted.
- Strategies are needed to exploit the market potential for the next 3–5 years for jobs in ICT, hospitality and health care (nurses).
- Mutually beneficial migration should be continued through bilateral labour agreements.
- Demand-side information should be made available through country-specific job portals.
- Categories of professionals who can be sent to Kuwait should be determined and then send them through the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment (currently, the job categories that are catered to are in the skilled and semi-skilled sectors).
- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to provide short-duration Arabic language courses for persons heading to Kuwait. Along with specific languages, there should be a course on the rules and regulations, culture and other values of the country that would be important for migrant workers to keep in mind when they are working in Kuwait. Knowledge about the visa process, laws and day-to-day living in the country must be provided.
- The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment training programmes should be structured to include awareness of language for all semi-skilled and low-skilled workers.
- At the final year of academic and tertiary school education, students should be given career guidance to identify foreign employment opportunities, language fluency in English as well as other leading language skills (German, French, Chinese, Italian and Arabic).

Italy

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities are found through personal contacts, LinkedIn and job sites.	- Language barrier to converse fluently in Italian (required in workplaces) and English - Migrants working illegally as blue-collar workers without work permits	- Language proficiency in Italian - English language proficiency - Familiarity with advanced technology and digital skills - Flexibility and the ability to work in a team	The work visa is acquired through the employer. Nulla Osta and resident permit are necessary (proof of sufficient financial means also required). Student visa is possible for postgraduate and master's degree programmes at Italian universities. Students are provided a work visa upon completion of their study programme. Students are allowed to work part-time while studying. There are 2 types of student visas, depending on the duration of the study programme: (i) visa type C, for short-stay or travel, which is valid for one or more entries and for a period not exceeding 90 days and (ii) visa type D, for long stays, which is valid for more than 90 days.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years			
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)		Work experience
Professional and skilled Hospitality sector: food and beverage, hotel management, housekeeping skills related opportunities, chef and waiter, catering services; food preparation, cooking and distribution worker Health sector: nurse and caregiver Operational support services for businesses, transport, logistics and warehousing services Construction sector: civil engineer, architect IT sector: software engineer Hairstylist in salons	Qualifications for professional and skilled categories <i>(Italian language skills are preferred for all job categories.)</i> Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. Applicants can have degrees from German Tech or technical colleges or related vocational training qualifications for skilled and semi-skilled jobs (NVQ levels 4-7). Hotel management school qualifications for the hotel sector is essential.		Minimum work experience of 3-5 years is required for the professional and skilled categories. Past experience in a similar capacity for handling the responsibilities is expected. Low-skilled delivery jobs do not require work experience.
Semi-skilled – industrial Transport and logistics: heavy vehicle truck driver, forklift driver, taxi driver, driver of cars, vans Construction: stone, brick, fire-brick mason, metal structure fitter, machine toolmaker Electrician in civil construction and similar professions Operator of automatic and semi-automatic industrial machine tools Industrial machinery mechanic and fitter and similar professions Worker assigned to industrial product packaging machines Installer and repairer of electrical and electromechanical equipment Plumber, water and gas pipe installer Low-skilled Delivery of goods	Nursing applicants must have a degree or diploma in nursing and the Sri Lanka nursing registration are required. A certificate course in caregiving is needed for the adult caregivers. A IELTS high score and Italian language proficiency are essential.		

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years	
Hospitality sector: accommodation and catering service, food and beverage manager, chef, steward, waiter Health care assistants, nurse, caregiver Semi-skilled jobs in construction, heavy-vehicle driver Low-skilled workers: delivery of goods, domestic helper for child care	

*There will be 450,000 job openings for 2023-25 through the migration policy changes in Italy. The most common type of employment contract on offer is for a fixed term and full time (55.5 per cent). The qualification most requested is an upper-secondary school diploma.

Italian labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Information technology	Skilled, professional	ICT technician Mathematics and computer science specialist	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree in technical field, 5 years plus experience in the relevant field and language proficiency in English.	2022–26	As much as 49 per cent of vacancies remain unfilled	Professional and skilled jobs earn €45,000 upwards per annum. Semi-skilled jobs earn €24,000 upwards per annum.
Organizational and financial activities	Semi-skilled labour	Technician	Applicants must have advanced technical skills and other personal skills, such as problem-solving, troubleshooting and time management.	2022–26	Required skill set includes business and management skills	*Average wages in Italy increased to €2,627 per month (US\$2,861) in 2022. The maximum rate of average wage for employees was €2,502 per month and the minimum was €1,176 per month in 2022.
Environment	Skilled, professional	Environmental engineer Environmental IT specialist Environmental lawyer Mobility manager Energy manager Eco-designer Expert in electric motor systems	Applicants must have a relevant degree or professional qualification, field work experience in the relevant sector, strong communication and language skills and proficiency in MS office package.	2022–26	This is a high demand sector at global level and requires national level efforts to increase supply	For part-time student workers, the minimum per hour wage is €7. They can work a maximum of 4 hours a day and 20 hours a week. This will allow them to earn up to €140 a week and €560 a month.
Sustainable architect	Skilled, professional	Architect Designer of sustainable building	Applicants must have an accredited degree in a relevant field, proficiency in relevant design software, industry experience in similar capacity (3–5 years) and skills in team-playing, writing and verbal presenting in English.	2022–26	This is a high-demand sector at the global level and requires national-level efforts to increase supply.	

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Construction and the maintenance	Low-skilled labour	Labourer Construction finisher	Not specified	2022–26	Initiate some awareness programmes to divert some of the low-skilled migrant workers to Italy.	
	Skilled, semi-skilled, professional	Construction engineer and technician	Applicants must have an accredited degree or professional qualification in a relevant field. They should have skills in communication, problem-solving, troubleshooting, time management, English language and information technology.	2022–26	Initiate some awareness programmes to divert some of the low-skilled migrant workers to Italy.	
Mechanics	Semi-skilled labour	Installers of low environmental impact air-conditioning systems	Applicants must have a secondary school education in a technical field, 5 years of experience in the field of maintenance services or related area and working knowledge in English as well as computer skills.	2022–26	It is worth concentrating on this segment because the supply of workers can be increased within a short period.	

Recommendations for Italy

Key messages

- High demand for migrant workers in Italy e.g., migrant workers account for 8 per cent of the population.
- Estimated demand for migrant workers: 450,000 job openings for 2023–25.
- Most available job opportunities are in hotels, restaurants, cafes, construction, salons, health care and IT.

Recommendations

- Jobs for skilled and semi-skilled migrants should be targeted, especially ICT technicians, environment engineers and energy managers.
- With language a major barrier, public-private partnerships should be set up and encouraged to provide short-term courses that cater to the different language needs, including Italian.
- Italy is a very popular place to migrate to, and many people go through an illegal route. The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment should initiate a formal route, such as what it has done for the Middle East, for interested individuals to access Italy for job opportunities. The formal access will minimize those who enter Italy illegally.
 - a. Encourage foreign employment agencies to set up links to send people in accordance with rules and regulations specific to Italy, for available job opportunities.
 - b. Initiate a government-to-government agreement to identify the calibre of skills that can be sent from Sri Lanka.
 - c. Because Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are accepted for many jobs, there is an opportunity to send high-calibre professionals.
- Italian language training should be provided at the technical colleges, with short courses offered through the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment for spoken language.
- Demand-side information should be made available through country-specific job portals. Currently, job opportunities are found through personal contacts, LinkedIn and job sites.

Qatar

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities are found in the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website.	- Lack of English fluency to converse - Indian investors offer jobs to their own country people	- English language proficiency - Soft skills and mannerisms	The work visa is acquired through the employer for a 2-year contract period.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled Nurse and caregiver Construction: civil engineering, mechanical engineering, maintenance, electrical engineering, civil engineering, AC repairing, ship and boatbuilding Hair dressing and salon staff Hospitality: waiter, steward and chef	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. Nursing applicants must have a degree or a diploma in nursing and the Sri Lanka nursing registration. Construction sector applicants must have technical college or related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4-7). And hospitality sector applicants must have taken hotel school management courses. English proficiency is essential for all applicants.	Minimum work experience of 3-5 years is required for all professional and skilled categories.
Low-skilled Domestic worker		

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years
Construction sector Hospitality sector

Qatar labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Human services	Skilled, semi-skilled	Cook Waiter Other hotel service staff Security guard Gardner Foreperson	Applicants must have a degree or equivalent qualification in relevant subjects or a high school diploma or equivalent. They must have previous experience in a similar role and knowledge on security positions. Security guard applicants must be physically fit.	Forecasted until 2025	Concentrate on hospitality sector	The basic salary is 5,000 Qatari riyal per month.
	Low-skilled	Driver Cleaner	Applicants must be qualified with a secondary school diploma, have a valid driver's license (for drivers) and prior experience in a similar role. They are also expected to have verbal and written communication skills.		Supply side is very positive for this segment of migrant workers.	
Construction	Semi-skilled, low-skilled	Construction supervisor, foreperson Construction worker Welder Plumber Electrician Air-conditioning technician Tiler Mason Carpenter Crane operator	Applicants must have a preferred degree, high school or vocational education or an apprenticeship or valid certifications related to the subject. They also must have industry experience (especially Gulf country experience).	Forecasted until 2025	Should continue with this segment	
	Skilled, professional	Maintenance, civil engineer	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree or diploma in a relevant field and 6 or more years of experience in a relevant field. They also must have language proficiency and computer and soft skills. Having a Qatar driver's license is an added advantage.		Should fully concentrate on this segment	

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Health	Skilled, professional	Nurse Paramedic	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree in medicine or a relevant diploma or degree as well as other relevant certification or valid professional license (Qatar Council for Healthcare Practitioners license or valid Qatar identification and National Occupational Classification) related to the role is preferred. In some cases, a master's degree will be preferred. Industry experience, proficiency in English and computer skills and skills in communication are expected.	Forecasted until 2025	Should fully concentrate on this segment	
Education	Skilled, professional	Teacher	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree at the least in a relevant field and a valid teaching license from a reputed organization or country. They must have at least 2 years of experience and excellent classroom management skills.	Forecasted until 2025	This is an important area to promote.	

Recommendations for Qatar

Key messages

- **In addition to construction, ICT, health and hospitality are two important sectors for Sri Lanka to promote migration to Qatar.**
- **Fluency in English and Arabic languages are strong positive factors.**

Recommendations

- Strategies should be crafted to explore the market potential for the next 3–5 years in the hospitality and construction sectors.
- Mutually beneficial migration should continue through bilateral labour agreements.
- Promoting skilled and semi-skilled migration to Qatar should be targeted.
- Demand-side information should be provided through country-specific job portals. Currently, job opportunities are found through the job agents, foreign employment agencies and personal contacts.
- Coaching should be available for semi-skilled aspiring migrants on etiquette, work ethics and laws of the country. Short-duration coaching in the English and Arabic languages for aspiring migrant workers should be made available through public-private partnerships.
- The most common migrants to Qatar are in the labour, semi-skilled and skilled categories in the industrial sector, although opportunities exist in the health sector for nurses and caregivers as well as in the hospitality sector, therefore they should be targeted.

Japan

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities are found mostly through personal contacts and the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website.	- Lack of Japanese language proficiency - Migrant workers paid less than Japanese workers as a policy	- Language proficiency in Japanese (critical) - English language proficiency - Knowledge about laws and regulations in Japan	The work visa is acquired through the employer for a 2- to 3-year contract period. A student visa is possible for postgraduate and masters programmes at universities. Students are provided a work visa upon completion of their study programme. Students are allowed to work part-time while studying.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
<i>*Japan does not offer opportunities for high-tech professionals, only for semi-skilled immigrant workers.</i> Professional and skilled Nurse, caregiver (but knowledge in Japanese language essential) Skilled Food service industry Technician, welder, binder, electrician under E7 visa <i>*Japan as an industrial hub has more opportunities in the automobile industry, shipping companies, recycling plants and construction industry for welders, masons and carpenters.</i>	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized, including from German Tech and technical colleges or related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4-7). Applicants must have a degree or diploma in nursing and completed the caregiver skill test. Japanese language proficiency is essential. For skilled applicants, Japanese language proficiency is an advantage.	Minimum work experience of 3-5 years is required for all professional and skilled categories Semi-skilled applicants must have 2-3 years of work experience in a similar capacity.

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years
Adult caregiver Food industry Automobile industry, shipping companies, recycling plants and construction industry for welder, mason and carpenter

Japan labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Industrial	Skilled, professional	Application engineering Project management (director) Sales and marketing (business development manager) Senior management	Applicants must have a degree in a related field and English skill TOEIC 550. Experience in related fields is preferable. Applicants are expected to have strong skills in leadership, decision-making, interpersonal relations and organizational and communication capacity.	Short and medium term	Potential market	Average monthly salary in Japan ranges from US\$1,000 to US\$17,000. Professional and skilled workers earn US\$5,000 or more. The average salary varies by education qualification.
Financial services	Skilled, professional	Audit and compliance Investment banking (associate) Private equity Project finance Real estate asset management Relationship management (managing director) Risk management	Applicants must have a bachelor's or master's degree in a required field of study (finance, accounting or business). They must have 1-3 years of experience in the financial service industry and be fluent in English and Japanese languages. Strong skills with MS Excel and PowerPoint, excellent communication and interpersonal skills, with the ability to work across internal and external teams are expected. They should be a self-starter with strong desire to succeed in a fast-paced, high-pressure, results-driven environment. And they should have the ability to multitask, with strong attention to details.	Short and medium term	Potential market	
Technology, internet and telecommunications	Skilled, professional	AI and data science (manager) Cloud security and infrastructure (senior manager) Consulting implementation and management Digital marketing Digital transformation Enterprise software Financial services it II consulting (director) Project management Sales	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree or higher, with a major in science, software engineering, digital marketing, IT or computer science. English skill at the business level is expected, along with problem-solving and analytical skills and excellent communication and interpersonal skills. Experience with quality management systems and processes are added value. Fluency in English and Japanese language skills are an advantage.	Short, medium and long term	High demand	

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Comments	Salary benefits
Consumer goods and retail	Skilled, professional	Business strategy and commercial (manager) Customer relationship management Digital marketing E-commerce (director) Marketing and branding Sales and business development Supply chain and procurement Trade marketing (manager)	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree in business administration, logistics, supply chain or related field. Experience with multiple e-commerce platforms, such as Shopify, BigCommerce and WooCommerce, are preferred. Excellent verbal and written communication skills is expected, along with proven negotiation skills, excellent interpersonal and customer service skills and excellent time management skills, with a proven ability to meet deadlines.	Short and medium term	Potential market	
Health and life science	Skilled, professional	Clinical development (manager) Healthcare service and management Hospital management Medical (doctor) Regulatory affairs (director) Sales and marketing	Applicants must have a relevant bachelor's degree, valid industry certification and clinical or industry experience. Japanese and English language skills are expected.	Medium and long term	High demand	

Recommendations for Japan

Key messages

- Most available job opportunities are in the skilled and semi-skilled categories for migrant workers.
- More job opportunities are in the industrial (automobile, construction), ICT, adult care and food sectors.

Recommendations

- Japanese language coaching must be provided to technical college students. Skills-development programmes should be made available in Japanese language coaching and knowledge about laws and regulations in Japan.
- Private Japanese language tuition for aspiring migrant workers to access should be encouraged.
- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to provide Japanese language knowledge for aspiring migrants. Along with the specific languages, there should be a course on the rules and regulations, culture of the country and other values that would be important for migrant workers to keep in mind when they are working in Japan.
- An MOU should be established with the relevant government authorities to send migrants for specific job categories formally.
- Demand-side information should be provided through country-specific job portals. Currently, job opportunities are found through personal contacts and the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment.

Oman

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities are found through employment agencies, Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website and personal contacts.	- Lack of English fluency to converse - Finding reliable employment agency	- Language proficiency in (English) - Soft skills	Work visa is acquired through the employer.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled Software engineer (Java, .net) Health sector: nurse, lab technician, radiologist, pharmacist	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. Nursing applicants must have a degree or diploma in nursing and a Sri Lanka nursing registration. Caregivers for adults must have a certificate course in caregiving. For semi-skilled workers, German Tech, technical college or related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4-7) are recognized. All applicants must have high IELTS score and English language proficiency.	Minimum work experience of 5-8 years is required for professional categories.
Semi-skilled Domestic worker (female)		Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment websites and personal contacts.

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years
Software engineer, developer in the IT sector Domestic worker

Oman labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Transportation	Low-skilled	Transport in charge, driver	Applicants must have 3–5 years of experience and a secondary school education (academic or general).	In the Shortage Occupation List in 2023, and demand for these jobs are expected in the next few years too.	The official minimum wage in the country is 325 rials per month, equivalent to US\$845. The average salary in Oman in 2023 is about US\$1,500 to US\$2,000 . Skilled foreign workers are paid several times as much, and in management positions, salaries often pay US\$9,000–US\$1,000,000 per month.
Manufacturing	Skilled, professional	Sales manager, sales executive Production planning engineer Quality assurance engineer Product sales engineer	Applicants must have a diploma or graduate certificate in mechanical engineering. Courses in NDT techniques, such as MP/UT/DP, and familiarity with international NDT codes is expected. Sales manager or executive applicants must have a Bachelor of Business Administration (Management) or 5–10 years of experience in a similar capacity.		
Construction	Skilled, professional	Construction engineer Quantity surveyor Construction manager or supervisor	Applicants must have 12–15 years of experience and a Bachelor of Technology or Engineering degree. Multidiscipline activity knowledge in mechanical, civil, electrical and instrumentation in the oil and gas construction field is an added advantage. Applicants for construction manager and supervisor must have proven work experience in a relevant role, along with a bachelor of science in construction management, architecture, engineering or related field.		

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Construction	Low-skilled labour	Welder and construction worker	Applicants must have proven experience in a relevant field and experience in operating equipment, such as trench rammers, drills and pneumatic hammers (construction workers). Welders must have knowledge on welding equipment and procedures (TIG, MMA, etc.).		
Mining	Skilled, professional	Health and safety manager Mine geologist	Health and safety manager applicants must have a Bachelor of Technology or Engineering manager. Any graduate degree is accepted for mine geologist applicants. All applicants are expected to have 5–10 years of experience.		
Hotel and hospitality management	Skilled	Guest relation supervisor Guest relations officer Restaurant manager	Applicants must have proven experience in a similar capacity and familiarity with hospitality industry standards. They also must have proficiency in English, with knowledge of additional languages a plus. They must be computer literate and have a customer-oriented and professional attitude, an outgoing personality and outstanding communication abilities, along with excellent organizational and time-management skills. A diploma or a bachelor's degree in hospitality management is preferred.		
Hotel and hospitality management	Semi-skilled, skilled	Waiter or waitress Pastry chef Room attendant	Applicants must have similar experience with luxury hotels, a good personality with excellent communication and strong service-minded skills, along with a good command of spoken and written English.		

Recommendations for Japan

Key messages

- ICT and health are two important sectors for Sri Lanka to promote migration to Oman.
- Fluency in English and Arabic languages are strong positive factors.
- Most opportunities are for blue-collar, skilled and semi-skilled jobs, like software engineers and developers, nurses, lab technicians, radiologists and pharmacists.
- Most of the current emphasis is on domestic workers and the health sector, but opportunities are available in the IT sector as well.

Recommendations

- The formal pathway through Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment should be enhanced for aspiring migrants to access jobs in Oman.
- A page in prominent Sinhala and English newspapers should be developed by the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment to highlight job opportunities in Oman for interested parties.
- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to provide language courses for aspiring migrants to attend before departing for Oman. Along with language training, there should be a course on the rules and regulations and culture of the country and other values that would be important for migrant workers.
- German Tech students and other technical college students must participate in language course in their study programmes.
- Knowledge in handling technology equipment in the workplace (video demos) should be nurtured.

Singapore

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
When traveling with visit visa, persons can find employment opportunities through agents and direct vacancies. Otherwise, job opportunities found through personal contacts.	- Lack of English fluency to converse - Migrant workers from Thailand, Bangladesh and India go to Singapore on visit visa (tourist) and settle down and have the advantage of language proficiency in English - High cost of living	- Language proficiency in English - Knowledge about rules and regulations in Singapore	Work visa is acquired through the employer for 2-year contract period, which is extendable Students are offered visa to study and work part-time. Visit visa (up to 90 days)

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years

Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Professional and skilled IT sector Engineering Accounting Hotel management Shipbuilding Nurse, midwife, caregiver	Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized.* Nursing applicants must have a degree or diploma in nursing and a Sri Lanka nursing registration along with a job offer from an in-patient health care facility. Foreign-trained nurse and midwife applicants must be registered or enrolled with the Singapore Nursing Board. To practise in Singapore, both local and foreign-trained nurses must pass the Singapore Nursing Board Registered Nurse Licensure Examination. Caregiving applicants must have a certificate course in caregiving for adults and be registered with the Singapore Nursing Board. English language proficiency is essential (some employers require an IELTS score).	Minimum work experience of 2-5 years is required for all professional and skilled categories.
Semi-skilled Domestic helper (E pass visa category) Domestic helper (S pass visa category)	<i>*A vocational training certificate and NVQ are not recognized in Singapore; it still being negotiated.</i>	

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years

Cyber security in IT sector (more opportunities and highly paid jobs)
 Nurse, health caregiver (Singapore Government figures show the number of people aged 65 or older made up almost 17 per cent of its resident population in 2022. Demand for skilled caregivers is increasing steadily.)
 Skilled worker in dockyards for marine shipbuilding
 Domestic helper, cleaner

Singapore labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Information technology	Skilled, professional	Artificial intelligence specialist AI developer AI engineer AI scientist	Applicants must have a master's or PhD degree in computer science, artificial intelligence or related field and be familiar with deep learning frameworks (such as TensorFlow, PyTorch, etc.) and commonly used model evaluation and tuning, performance acceleration techniques. They must be familiar with commonly used AI generation model frameworks, including GAN, VAE, VQGAN/Diffusion, etc. They are expected to have at least 5 years of experience. They must have experience with GPT or other large language models. Proven experience in developing and implementing AI algorithms and models for natural language processing, machine learning, deep learning and related fields are preferred.	In the Shortage Occupation List in 2023, and demand for these jobs are expected in the next few years too.	Skilled employees can earn around US\$5 ,000 per month. Domestic workers can earn US\$500-\$600 per month. The average caregiver salary in Singapore is S\$32,400 per year or S\$14.16 per hour. Entry-level positions start at S\$29,250 per year, while most experienced workers make up to S\$44,880 per year.
Information technology	Skilled, professional	Robotics software engineer	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree in computer science, computer engineering or related field and at least 4-5 years of experience in software development and 2 years of experience leading a software development team. Experience with robotics software development, including experience with ROS or ROS 2, is expected. Applicants also must have strong skills in automated control equipment software problem-solving, software debugging and commissioning, along with a good knowledge of SQL databases.		
Information technology	Skilled, professional	Data scientist Data analyst	Applicants must have a bachelor's or master's degree in data analytics, information technology, computer science or another quantitative field. They must have strong SQL query scripting skills and be knowledgeable in database technologies, with proficiency in data modelling, data wrangling and data preparation. They also must have proficiency in using one of the programming languages (C++, C#/.NET, Java, Python). Applicants also are expected to have experience in using one or more of the following techniques or methods: statistical and predictive modelling techniques, clustering and classification techniques, text analytics, simulation and optimization methods. And they must be proficient in using business intelligence tools (Power BI, Tableau or Qlik Sense).		

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Information technology	Skilled, professional	Full-stack engineer, full stack developer, full stack software developer, full stack web developer	Applicants must have at least 5 years of Python back-end development experience and strong experience in at least one Python web framework (FastAPI, Tornado, Django, etc.) They are expected to have deep-level understanding of architecture and best practices for web applications, solid knowledge of methods of communicating data to web apps (REST, GraphQL, websockets, etc.) and proficiency with API testing frameworks or TDD. They get bonus points for experience with Linux, UI/UX, Docker, Jenkins, Ansible and front-end tech (React, Javascript, HTML).		
Information technology	Skilled, professional	UI or UX designer	Applicants must have at least a degree in computer science, multimedia design or equivalent and have good working knowledge of JavaScript and jQuery as well as Adobe Applications (Adobe XD and Dreamweaver). They must have proficiency in web technologies (HTML5 and CSS3) and be familiar with browser testing and debugging. A minimum of 2 years of working experience in a related field is preferred.		
Information technology	Skilled, professional	DevOps engineer	Applicants must have a degree in these desired majors in computer science, computer engineering, electrical computer engineering, electrical engineering and computer sciences, information systems, information technology, information technology systems engineering, management science and engineering or other related fields of study. They must have knowledge of one of the high-level programming languages (C++ or Python) and work experience with Unix-systems and virtualization tools and a deep understanding of them, as well as knowledge of network technologies (TCP or IP).		
Information technology	Skilled, professional	Cybersecurity specialist Cyber security analyst Security engineer	Applicants must have a degree or diploma in information technology, information systems, IT security, computer science or related field, with relevant product or professional security certifications preferred. Relevant experience as security consultant or security engineer for project delivery in system integration environment is preferred.		
Health	Skilled, professional	Registered nurse	Applicants must be registered with the Singapore Nursing Board and have a minimum of 2 years of experience in acute or primary health care.		
Health	Skilled, professional	Staff nurse	Applicants must have a diploma in nursing or equivalent specialty that is recognized by the Singapore Nursing Board. Registration with the Singapore Nursing Board is preferred. Candidates without any prior experience are welcome.		

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Salary benefits
Health	Low-skilled	Health care assistant	Applicants must have at least a secondary education or equivalent. At least 1 year of working experience in an acute or community hospital or nursing home that is WSQ Certified is preferred. They should possess interpersonal skills and passionate about working with older persons. They are expected to have housekeeping and interpersonal skills, vital signs health care experience as well as experiences with interventions, nursing medical records, nursing care and personal care.		
Health	Skilled, professional	Medical doctor	Applicants must be a fully registered medical doctor with the Singapore Medical Council and have excellent communication skills. Bilingual or dialect capacity is preferred for speaking with patients.		
Finance	Skilled, professional	Financial officer	Applicants must have a Bachelor of Science in finance, accounting or economics. Professional qualification as a chartered financial analyst or certified public account is considered a plus, as is proven work experience as a finance officer or similar role.		

Recommendations for Singapore

Key messages

- There is high demand for high- and semi-skilled occupations in the ICT, health care and shipbuilding sectors.
- There is stiff competition from migrant workers from neighbouring countries (India, Bangladesh, Thailand, etc.), particularly in English language fluency.
- NVQ qualification is not recognized.

Recommendations

- English language skills should be enhanced through specific short duration courses through public-private partnerships.
- Applicants should be warned about illegal foreign employment agencies that may embezzle their money. They should be encouraged to work only with reliable agencies. This warning can be given via the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website or through the main line media.
- Job quotas for professional and skilled categories should be negotiated through government-to-government agreements.
- The skilled and semi-skilled job opportunities should be targeted by expanding education and training into the high-demand sectors, such as ICT, health care, finance and shipbuilding.
- Job opportunities exist in the professional categories, thus they should be targeted.

Republic of Korea

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Low-skilled labour opportunities in construction sites (E9 category jobs) are found through the government-to-government MOU. Seasonal worker opportunities for 4-5 months are possible and found through Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment websites and personal contacts, as are semi-skilled opportunities in shipbuilding sites. Only men allowed as job applicants.	• Korean language fluency • Sri Lanka's negative reputation for undocumented migrants • Some migrants frequently change their job and move to other countries, violating the contractual obligations • Vietnamese and Philippine migrants grab opportunities as blue-collar workers	• Soft skills in relation to working as teams • Language skills in Korean • Language proficiency in English	The 2-year contract period is extendable up to 5 years, and the employer provides the visa.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Skilled and semi-skilled Manufacturing, food manufacturing, construction, fisheries Mechanical engineering, maintenance or electrical engineering, civil engineering, automobile engineering, construction, shipbuilding in dockyard Low-skilled Men are recruited for the Republic of Korea through the Government's quota migration programme. *The Republic of Korea does not recruit female employees for labour as a government policy because jobs are considered difficult, dirty or dangerous). Local employees are paid more than the foreign employees as a government policy. Seasonal job opportunities Short duration (4-5 months)	Applicants must have a degree or diploma-level programme in the relevant field. German Tech, technical colleges and related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4-7) are recognized. Skills assessment test and Korean language fluency test are required.	Minimum work experience of 2 years is required for all skilled and semi-skilled categories.

Long-term opportunities, 3-5 years
Construction, blue-collar categories Construction site-related skilled and semi-skilled jobs Mechanical engineering, electrical engineering, civil engineering, shipbuilding in dockyards, maintenance officers

Republic of Korea labour market demand

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and Skill requirements	Time period	Time period	Salary benefits
Manufacturing	Low-skilled	Low-skilled labour	Applicants must have at a minimum the General Certification of Secondary Education (grade C) and experience in fast-moving consumer goods manufacturing environment is preferred. Korean language and mechanical background are desirable but not essential.	In the Shortage Occupation List in 2023, and demand for these jobs are expected in the next few years too.	High demand	Mechanical engineering, maintenance or electrical engineering are highly paid, US\$1,500–\$3,000 per month. Special training programmes are required for low-skilled migrant workers. They can obtain a visa only after completing that training programme.
Agriculture	Low-skilled	Low-skilled labour	Applicants must have at a minimum the General Certification of Secondary Education (grade C). Korean language and a mechanical background are desirable but not essential.			
Education	Skilled, professional	English teacher	Applicants must have a bachelor's degree or diploma from an accredited institution and be a citizen from a native English-speaking country (such as the United States, Canada, New Zealand, Australia, United Kingdom, Ireland or South Africa). Persons not from an English-speaking country but who have a teacher's license in English can apply. All applicants must meet the health requirements and pass a drug test.		Very competitive	
Education	Skilled, professional	English content development	Applicants must have at a minimum a bachelor's degree from an accredited four-year university and experience as a writer of English study materials (must be verifiable). The ability to write engaging content clearly and accurately is a must. Extensive knowledge of the conventions of English grammar and usage are required. Applicants must be a native speaker of English.			
Education	Skilled, professional	English editor, writer and translator	Applicants generally should have a degree in the humanities, liberal arts, linguistics, journalism, English literature, education or business administration. Bachelor's or higher degree is a must. The TESOL or CELTA is preferred but not necessary. Native English speaker is needed for most of the English editing and proofreading jobs.			

Recommendations for Singapore**Key messages**

- High demand for migrant workers in manufacturing sector for skilled, semi-skilled and low-skilled jobs.
- Recruitment for low-skilled jobs is mainly through the Government's quota migration programme.
- No foreign women are recruited for jobs considered difficult, dirty or dangerous.

Recommendations

- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to provide Korean language courses for migrants (skilled or low-skilled, for at least 3–6 months in duration). Along with language training, there should be a course on the rules and regulations, culture of the country and other values that would be important for migrant workers to keep in mind when they are working in the country.
- Mutually beneficial migration should continue through bilateral labour agreements.
- Demand-side information should be provided through country-specific job portals.
- Illegal immigration should be discouraged by establishing formal channels with an MOU with the relevant authorities in the Republic of Korea.
- Information on opportunities for skilled and semi-skilled jobs should be accessible in the technical colleges through career guidance.

Cyprus

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Salary benefits	Visa process
Job opportunities found through agents and the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website.	- Lack of English fluency to converse - Use of advanced technology	English language proficiency	Domestic worker minimum salary is €350 per month.	The work visa is provided through the employer for a 2-year contract.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years		
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience
Skilled and semi-skilled Caregiver Hotel management (waiter, cook, bartender, baker) Domestic worker	Applicants must have a diploma in nursing or a certificate course in caregiving for the adult caregivers from German Tech, technical colleges or related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4–7). And they should have a skill assessment test score.	Minimum work experience of 1–2 years is required in skilled categories in similar capacity.

Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years
Adult caregiver Hotel management Domestic worker

Recommendations for Cyprus

Key messages

- Caregiver and hospitality are two important sectors for Sri Lanka to promote migration in Cyprus.
- Fluency in English and Greek or Turkish are strong positive factors.
- Most opportunities are for blue-collar, skilled and semi-skilled jobs like caregivers, hotel staff and domestic workers.

Recommendations

- The formal pathway should be enhanced by the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment for aspiring migrants to access jobs in Cyprus.
- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to provide language courses for aspiring migrants to attend before departing for Cyprus.
- Knowledge in handling technology and equipment in the workplace (video demos) should be provided.

New Zealand

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities are found through migration consultants, personal contacts and the LinkedIn social media network. There is a trend in applying for student visa to New Zealand for bachelor's or master's studies (scholarships). *Visa process to Australia and New Zealand was viewed by interviewed Sri Lankans as complicated.	• Lack of knowledge about the visa process among applicants • Providing proof on financial status during the application process • High cost of migration, with migration consultants overcharging the applicants during the application process • Proficiency in English language for semi-skilled and low-skilled workers • Competition with Indian immigrants to obtain opportunities • Applicants' age should be younger than 55 years only	• Language proficiency for semi-skilled and low-skilled workers • Getting a high score with IELTS for professional and skilled employment opportunities, such as nursing	Open for • student visa • skilled migration work visa • visit visa The work visa is acquired through the employer, and dependants can be accommodated. Dependants can also apply and get a work visa. Children will get a student visa up to age 18. Students are provided a work visa upon completion of their study programme. They are allowed to work part-time while studying, at a maximum of 20 hours per week. • Student visa undergraduate qualifications for applicants aged 18–30, Level 4 – Certificate • Level 5 – Diploma, Level 6–7 First degree, Level 8–10 Postgraduate qualification for applicants aged 20–52 • Green list – Level 7 permanent residency for professionals (engineering diploma or degree, NDT qualifications); post study work visa will be eligible after 1 year. • Level 9 – Master's degree holders can apply for a postgraduate programme Sponsors must be there for personal contacts. There is opportunity to apply for permanent residency after 3 years. For more information, see www.immigration.govt.nz/new-zealand-visas.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1-2 years			
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience	Salary benefits
Professional and skilled Health sector: nurse, adult caregiver, radiologist IT: software and hardware engineer; cyber security Banking and finance: management accountant, financial accountant, auditor Education sector: lecturer at university colleges Construction: civil engineer, architect Hotel sector: chef, steward Semi-skilled and low-skilled Agriculture farms, dairy farm workers, fruit plucking vacancies are opening up in Fiji island as well.	Qualifications requirements are more similar to Australian Government requirements. Sri Lankan academic qualifications and professional qualifications are recognized. Medical doctor applicants must go through an examination process in New Zealand. To qualify as a candidate for medical physician jobs, applicants must have a medical degree and postgraduate qualification in a field of specialization acquired upon completion of a structured postgraduate training programme. The Medical Council of New Zealand requires international medical graduates applying for registration to have certain documents verified by the Educational Commission for Foreign Medical Graduates through their website EPIC, which is a primary-source verification service. Nurse applicants must have a degree in nursing and a Sri Lanka nursing registration. To become a registered nurse, applicants must successfully complete a three-year Bachelor of Nursing course (level 7 on the New Zealand Qualifications Authority Framework) or a two-year graduate entry master's degree (level 8 on the New Zealand Qualifications Framework) that is approved by the Nursing Council of New Zealand. They also must pass a Nursing Council of New Zealand examination for registered nurses. Applicants who have successfully completed an approved programme of study in New Zealand can apply for registration as a nurse in the scope of practice for which their qualification is prescribed. For enrolled nurse and registered nurse applicants, this will involve passing the state final examination. Caregiver applicants must have a certificate course in caregiving for adults. These programmes are mostly conducted by private institutions in Sri Lanka. IT sector software and hardware engineer applicants must have a bachelor of Science in IT degree, a Master of Science from a local or foreign university or a 4-year degree with work experience of 1-2 years.	Minimum work experience of 3-5 years is required for all professional and skilled categories. Many regulatory authorities, including Australia, Canada and New Zealand, require medical doctors to have basic training in internal medicine of at least 3 years duration prior to specialist training. General practitioners must have an average postgraduate training duration of 5 years (including internship). And specialists must have an average postgraduate training duration of 8 years (including internship) and prevocational training of 1-2 years. Basic specialist training must be 3 years, with advanced specialist training of 3 years. All other professional and skilled professions must have a minimum work experience of 3-5 years.	NZ\$24,000-NZ\$434,000 per annum for skilled professionals. A doctor in New Zealand earns an average salary of between NZ\$72,000 and NZ\$182,000 a year. A junior doctor in New Zealand makes around NZ\$80,000-NZ\$140,000 yearly, whereas consultants can earn between NZ\$155,000 and NZ\$219,000 a year. Those working in the private sector could earn up to NZ\$600,000. Work visa is acquired through the employer, and dependants can be accommodated. Students are provided work visa upon completion of their study programme. They are allowed to work part-time while studying, at a maximum of 20 hours per week. *The visa process is complicated. Sponsors must be there for personal contact.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years			
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience	Salary benefits
	Accountants and auditor applicants must be practising accountants and auditors with a Bachelor of Science in Accounting and Finance, Institute of Chartered Accountants of Sri Lanka or Chartered Institute of Management Accountants or Association of Chartered Certified Accountants qualifications. Lecturer applicants must have lecturing experience at a local or foreign university in major disciplines, such as management, accountancy and finance, economics and IT. Construction sector civil engineer and architect applicants must have a local bachelor's or postgraduate degree or Higher National Diploma in Accountancy with experience and have a Chartered Professional Engineer registration. Electrician and maintenance engineer applicants must have technical colleges or related vocational training qualifications in Sri Lanka (NVQ levels 4–7). Hospitality sector applicants must have previous experience in the hotel sector rather than the paper qualifications. All applicants must have language proficiency, with an IELTS score in the high band (6.5–7+); English language proficiency is essential. To become a registered nurse, applicants must have an English language score of 7.0 in all modules (or OET B) and a skill assessment test score of a minimum 65.	Chartered professional engineer is a protected title, and those holding this title are registered with the Registration Authority for Chartered Professional Engineers. Applicants must be younger than 55 years.	For more information, see www.immigration.govt.nz/new-zealand-visas
Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years			
Professional and skilled Nurse, adult caregiver Software engineering and cyber security positions in IT sector Chef for restaurants and hotels in hospitality sector Lecturer in the university education sector Low-skilled labour on agriculture farms			

Recommendations for New Zealand

Key messages

- There is a high demand for migrant workers in skilled and professional occupations, such as health (doctors and nurses in the aged-care sector, IT, higher education and hospitality sectors).
- New Zealand offers high salaries, ranging from NZ\$24,000 to NZ\$434,000 per annum for skilled professionals.
- Sri Lankan academic and professional qualifications are recognized.

Recommendations

- The professional and semi-skilled jobs should be targeted, with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment facilitating professional-category skilled-migration opportunities to New Zealand through IELTS training.
- The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment should improve awareness of the visa process.
- English language skills (IELTS score of 6.5–7+) should be improved among the skilled and professional categories through public-private partnership (universities, private training providers, etc.).
- Most available job opportunities are in the health care, IT and education sector and thus education and training should be expanded into these high-demand sectors.
- Mutually beneficial migration should be negotiated through bilateral labour agreements.

Specific requirements for nursing officers in New Zealand

Applicants who have the legal authority to practise as a nurse or midwife in New Zealand are subject to certain entitlements under the Trans-Tasman Mutual Recognition Act, 1997 (Cth) and should apply for registration with the National Board. The Medical Council of New Zealand requires international medical graduates applying for registration in New Zealand to have certain documents verified by the Educational Commission for Foreign Medical Graduates, through their website EPIC, which is a primary-source verification service. Postgraduate students from other countries can apply for a Doctor of Medicine and a Master of Science dual programme in New Zealand. Aspiring students must take the New Zealand Registration Examination. After passing the examination, they need two to three job letters from the hospitals of New Zealand. Thereafter they will be eligible for permanent residency. A Bachelor of Medicine and Bachelor of Surgery are accredited by the Australian Medical Council on behalf of the New Zealand Medical Council. There are only two universities in New Zealand that offer the Bachelor of Medicine and Bachelor of Surgery degree to international students. An applicant from the third category intending to gain a New Zealand Nursing Registration must enrol in the Waikato Institute of Education's English Studies for Nursing Registration programme. After completing the programme, they can sit for the IELTS test but must obtain a score of at least 7.0 in all four academic test modules. Many regulatory authorities, including Australia, Canada and New Zealand, require basic training in internal medicine of at least three years' duration prior to specialist cardiology training. Internal medicine is classed as the primary specialty and cardiology the secondary specialty (or subspecialty).

Become a chartered professional engineer in New Zealand

A chartered professional engineer is an experienced engineer who has been assessed as meeting a quality mark of competence. It shows the engineer can deal with complex engineering problems that require expert technical knowledge. They must be reassessed at least every six years to maintain their chartered professional engineer status. Although chartered professional engineers need to demonstrate New Zealand-specific technical experience, it is a competency mark with international accreditation. Chartered professional engineer is also a protected title, and those holding this title must be registered with the Registration Authority for Chartered Professional Engineers and must adhere to a code of ethical conduct. Over the past few years, the New Zealand Government has been working on potential changes to the way engineering is regulated. In March 2022, the Cabinet agreed to a new licensing regime for engineers doing safety-critical work, but this will take some years to be fully implemented. In the meantime, any engineer who thinks they may want to become a chartered professional engineer should apply for assessment, even if they might need to be licensed in the future.

Rumania

Recruitment pathways	Challenges and barriers	Skill gaps to be bridged	Visa process
Job opportunities are found through the MOU with the Romanian Government, the foreign employment agencies and foreign employment agents.	- Language barrier due to the need to converse fluently in English - Competition from migrant workers from Poland, Croatia, Philippines and India in Romania due to low-cost labour and language proficiency in English	- Language proficiency in English - Knowledge of technology used in the country	Work visa is acquired through the employer for a 2-year contract period. This process is coordinated by the Ministry of Health.

Immediate and mid-term opportunities, 1–2 years			
Job category	Required qualifications (acceptance for local qualifications)	Work experience	Salary benefits
Skilled Opportunities in the construction sector: welder, bender, steel fabricator, electrician, wall painter, shuttering carpenter, gypsum worker, plumber, pipe fabricator, mason, tile mason, construction helper Hospitality sector: waiter, steward, kitchen helper, delivery (driver), cook, assistant cook	The German Tech, technical college and related vocational training qualifications (NVQ levels 4–7) are recognized. Driver applicants with experience must have a heavy-vehicle driving license. All applicants must have fluency in English.	A minimum work experience of 3–5 years is required for all skilled categories. Hotel management experience required for the hospitality sector. And low-skilled applicants are not required to have a service certificate, but they must sit for the skill assessment test.	Skilled and semi-skilled labourers earn US\$600–\$1,200 per month.
Semi-skilled Drivers: JCB operator, excavator, asphalt operator			
Low-skilled Domestic helper			

Long-term opportunities, 3–5 years
Skilled worker in construction, heavy-vehicle drivers

Recommendations for Romania
Key messages Most available job opportunities are in the skilled and semi-skilled sector currently
Recommendations - Compulsory English language training should be included in the curriculum at the technical and vocational centre study programmes or initiate public-private partnerships to provide language courses for migrants before their departure. - A formal channel should be established through the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment for interested migrant workers to access jobs in Romania.

Israel

Sector	Skill category	Occupation category	Education and skills requirements	Time period
High tech	Skilled, professional	Developer AI specialist Python programmer Algorithm developer Cybersecurity analyst, specialist, researcher DevOps engineer	Applicants must have a bachelor's or master's degree in computer science or related discipline and deep knowledge of computer architecture and computer languages. They also are expected to have industry experience plus communication, independent working and team-playing skills and proficiency in English.	Current
Health and nursing care industry	Skilled, professional	Doctor Nursing Caregiving	Applicants must have a degree in medicine or relevant professional qualification, the required industry license and experience. They also must have strong verbal and written communication, interpersonal, teamwork and organizational skills and proficiency in English.	
Social welfare	Low-skilled	Social worker (nanny or child protective services, foster care)	Applicants should have previous experience with a similar role and personal skills, such as patience and understanding.	
Construction	Semi-skilled	Building and construction related	Applicants should have a high school or relevant industrial qualification plus experience in the construction sector.	
Other	Skilled, professional	Project manager	Applicants must have strong management and communication skills, with 2–4 years of industry experience, skills in leading a project or team and strong technical understating. And they should be a self-learner.	

Recommendations for Israel

Key messages

- High tech, nursing care and construction industries require foreign labour mainly for skilled and semi-skilled occupations.
- Fluency in English and Hebrew are strong positive factors.

Recommendations

- Public-private partnerships should be initiated to provide English and Hebrew language courses before migrants depart for jobs in Israel.
- More information on labour market demands for migrant workers in Israel must be made available.
- Knowledge in handling technology and equipment in the workplace (video demos) and multitasker skills must be provided through training courses.
- The presence of migrant workers in Israel is not as prevalent as in other countries. Opportunities are opening up in the health sector, especially for caregivers. The Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment should create awareness of these opportunities on their website or through mainline media.

Summary matrix: Region- and country-specific high demand sectors and occupations

Region	Country	Health			Engineer			Hospitality		Construction			Manufacturing	Other	
		Doctor	Nurse	Adult caregiver care	ICT	Green energy	Civil, electrical, mechanical, engineer	Skilled	Semi-skilled	Skilled	Semi-skilled	Unskilled	Semi-skilled and unskilled	Ship building	Hairstylist
North America	United States		H	H	H	H		H							
	Canada			H	H	H		H	H	H	H				
Europe	United Kingdom	H	H	H			H								
	Italy			H	H	H		H	H	H	H				H
	Germany		H		H	H									
	France	H	H	H	H										
East Asia and Pacific	New Zealand	H	H	H											
	Australia	H	H		H	H		H	H	H			H		
	Japan			H	H		H		H				H	H	
	Republic of Korea									H	H		H	H	
	Singapore	H	H	H	H			H						H	
Middle East	Saudi Arabia		H		H		H	H	H	H	H	H			H
	Kuwait		H		H		H	H	H	H	H	H			H
	Qatar		H		H		H	H	H	H	H	H			H
	Cyprus			H				H	H						
	Oman		H		H		H								
	United Arab Emirates				H		H	H	H						
	Israel	H	H	H	H	H					H	H			

Note: H = high demand. As shown in the summary matrix, health, ICT and hospitality sectors emerge as high-demand sectors for highly and semi-skilled migrant workers in all four regions. In the Middle East, however, the demand for high-, semi- and low-skill occupations are concentrated in the construction and hospitality sectors. Similarly, in the Asia-Pacific region, demand for migrant workers include the manufacturing and shipbuilding subsectors. The demand for high and semi-skilled workers in the five sectors are expected to grow over the next five years. Therefore, supply-side responses can be planned more efficiently and effectively. In responding to demand-side developments, policymakers need to pay special attention to the competitive pressures from competing countries and suppliers, such as Bangladesh, India, Nepal, Pakistan and the Philippines.

► 5. Recommendations

Gap	Action	Sector or authority	Time period
1. Training and capacity development needs from the supply side			
Language proficiency of migrant workers needs to be levelled up.	Initiate public-private partnerships to provide language training for potential migrants. English language is the first priority and other country-specific languages, such as English, German, Japanese, Korean, Arabic and Italian.	Tertiary & vocational education Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment	Continuous: Long term (establishing and academy)
Currently, language proficiency is a primary barrier to fulfilling vacancies in the semi-skilled or skilled categories. This also affects health and care worker sectors.	Ensure that language training course trainees have adequate fluency to carry out day-to-day spoken and written tasks. The length and the breadth of the training courses should be expanded to achieve this goal.		Short term (coaching specific migrant workers on the necessary requirements before their departure)
Not only English language but also German, French and Korean, Japanese and Italian languages for those who want to migrate to these countries are needed (for at least 3-6 months in duration).	Include English language modules in the TVET curriculum.	Tertiary & vocational education Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment	
Currently, only German Tech has technical courses, but does not have German language as a subject.	Expand English language training in school curriculums.		
	Impart knowledge of the specific cultural, ethical and value systems of countries to prepare aspiring migrants. Country-specific expatriate teachers must be recruited for teaching relevant languages.	Tertiary & vocational education Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment	
	Enhance professional candidates' qualifications with advanced and extended English language courses with technical jargon in preparation for potential migrants.		
	Provide training of relevant technical terminology in English for the professional and semi-skilled sectors.	Tertiary & vocational education Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment	
	Adopt a quality matching framework by the Government through universities and technical colleges.		
	Encourage German Tech to introduce a course in German language as well as etiquette, rules and regulations, values, culture and ethics of Germany for the benefit of aspiring jobseekers. Career guidance should also be introduced to highlight job opportunities in Germany.	Tertiary & vocational education Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment	
Practical knowledge taught at universities is not up to standard to acquire job opportunities abroad.	Update job-specific training that is in line with the technological advancements in destination economies.	Tertiary education	Medium and long term
	Encourage compulsory practical experience through internships in private and public companies.		

Gap	Action	Sector or authority	Time period
Knowledge gaps in handling of technological devices used in overseas countries for specific jobs should be given to all the applicants prior departure	Introduce practical knowledge on the handling of different equipment and technical devices in the final year of all technical courses and programmes. Provide all aspiring migrants with basic training on modern technological applications prior to the departure	Ministry of Education and tertiary education	Medium and long term
Soft skills are also inadequate for aspiring migrants to face interviews. Communication skills, ethics and country-specific cultural and value system awareness are needed. Migrants' soft skills, such as personal relationship management, organization, critical thinking, self-presentation and teamwork, needs to be levelled up. Soft skills training is needed for students at technical colleges and universities.	Provide training options to aspiring migrants before they apply for jobs or before they depart (like a finishing school). Introduce soft skills in the curriculum of schools, tertiary higher education institutes and vocational training.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment and collaborate with the private sector	Continuous
2. Need for work experience			
There is need for opportunities for gaining experience before migration. Those who have experience of at least 2-3 years have better opportunities at getting recruited than newly qualified individuals	Develop a plan with sector-based associations and relevant line ministries to employ graduates of TVET, universities and hospitality training centres to work with those sectors to get required experience of 2-3 years and also a system to re-employ them when they return home.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment Ministry of Higher Education Employers' Federation of Ceylon	Continuous and long term
3. Creating pathways			
Provide demand side information and upgrade Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website. Currently, the website does not provide an up-to-date data base, user-friendly browsing or sufficient guidelines.	Collaborate with a software service provider for a more user-friendly service. An app and an alert service would be useful.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment	Short term
There is need to connecting employers with migrants through a database to register the job seekers for skilled migration and provide knowledge on the requirements to be fulfilled	Create an information system that is available in the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment website. Link jobseekers and employers through a website.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment	Medium term
Most of the foreign employment agencies cater to the Middle East countries.	Capacitate licensed foreign employment agencies to enter new markets and facilitate through Sri Lanka Foreign Missions in destinations for their efforts.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment and Ministry of Foreign Affairs	Short term and continuous

Gap	Action	Sector or authority	Time period
Sri Lanka is catering mostly to the opportunities in the blue-collar, skilled and semi-skilled job categories.	Establish a pathway through the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment for the professional category to seek foreign employment through websites and awareness through the main media. Establish government-to-government MOUs to channel opportunities for the professionals and skilled jobseekers. For example, structure mutually beneficial migration through bilateral labour agreements.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment in collaboration with foreign missions and embassies to link up with relevant government authorities and other entities in the destination countries.	Short term and long term
Currently, migrants are primarily dependent on agencies, personal contacts or migration consultants for navigating administrative work and use of technology in the application process.	Establish migration counselling desk and a portal with country-specific links that will include cultural, ethical and value systems for day-to-day survival in a specific country, to be established by the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment. Provide guidance to potential migrants on visa processing and fulfilling other requirements. Make available online services and capacitate the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment officers to serve prospective migrant workers' needs and help them to make informed decisions on migration. The Bureau can direct them to choose the legal paths for migration.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment	Short term and continuous
Special guidance is needed for potential migrants in the professional category, such as accounting and finance, engineering (chemical, civil, energy, electrical), business management, hospitality industry-related occupations. Currently, this category is primarily using personal routes or student visa for migration.	Create a dedicated unit for the benefit of potential migrants in the professional category. Suggest the need of intervention of the Government in this sector to avoid misleading, exploitative nature in fee collection by the private entities and issues face at the destinations by skilled, professional categories. Make final-year students of local universities and technical colleges aware of the career paths and opportunities in overseas countries and provide them with necessary soft skills to face job opportunities in these countries. This could be implemented through career guidance units in these institutions.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment Career Guidance units of tertiary education institutes	Short term and long term

Gap	Action	Sector or authority	Time period
4. Advocacy and lobbying			
Image-building in the destinations markets	Lobby and advocate Promote recruitment-based MOUs and bilateral agreements with new destinations and continuous monitoring, discussions with signed parties to open up opportunities for Sri Lankans. Expedite the process of skill recognition agreements with the destination countries to recognize the NVQ and SLQF by these countries. It will help Sri Lankans enter more labour markets.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment	Short term
Currently, the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment is primarily focused on Gulf countries with established formal links and a network of foreign employment agencies establish in the country to cater to job market in these specific countries.	Seek assistance of the overseas Sri Lankans in countries to promote Sri Lankan workers through networking, campaigns, image-building etc. Use the newly established Unit for Overseas Sri Lankans in collaboration with the Foreign Ministry to implement and monitor such activities. Establish Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment's operations and relationships with Europe, North America and Asian-Pacific countries. Or establish relationships with relevant authorities in countries to obtain updates on available opportunities. Focus the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment on Australia and New Zealand to provide details about opportunities and awareness about their job visa process. Connect with the federal and central government websites for job opportunities for Sri Lankan migrant workers, such as smartmoveaustralia.gov.au. Encourage foreign employment agencies to set up operations to cater to job opportunities in Europe and Western countries as well as other Far Eastern countries. These agencies must register with the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment in collaboration with foreign missions and embassies to link up with relevant government authorities and other entities in the destination countries to establish links.	Short, medium and long term
5. Research and follow up			
Follow-up and continued research on policies and labour market trends in the destination countries are needed.	Conduct continuous internal research and follow up through embassies and government-to-government interactions.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment	Medium and long term

Gap	Action	Sector or authority	Time period
6. Other special recommendations			
Creating awareness on services provided by the Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment and to avoid malpractices such as illegal routes, using visit or student visa to gain entry are needed.	Conduct rigorous marketing campaigns. Promote awareness through mainline media of television, radio and social networks.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment	Immediate and continuous
A strategy for the health and care sectors is needed. With the ageing populations in destination countries, job opportunities in this sector are high and most lucrative.	Establish an action plan for recruiting, training, providing local experience and migration opportunities for the sector. Improve the language skills, soft skills and English technical knowledge of aspiring migrants. Enhance skills match through skills recognition and skills development.	Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment Ministry of Health Ministry of Higher Education Collaborate with the Faculty of Nursing, University of Colombo	Short, medium and long term
There is no migration strategy that seeks to contribute to the economy.	Incorporate migration into economic recovery strategies and ensure coherence. Establish migration as a main source of employment and foreign exchange earnings.	Ministry of Finance, Economic Stabilization and National Policies Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment Ministry of Labour and Foreign Employment	Medium and long term

► References

- Al Jazeera. 2021. "Saudi Arabia Announces Changes to Kafala System", 14 March.
- Amnesty International. 2006. *Protect the Rights of Migrants in South Korea*.
- Angenend, Steffen, Nadine Knapp, and David Kipp. 2023. *Germany is Looking for Foreign Labor*. German Institute for International and Security Affairs.
- Bayut. n.d. "Everything You Need To Know About the Golden Visa UAE."
- Buchholz, Katharina . 2021. "This Chart Shows South Korea's Population Is Ageing and Shrinking." World Economic Forum, 3 March..
- Centre for Economic Performance. 2012. *Immigration and the UK Labour Market: The Latest Evidence From Economic Research..* London School of Economics and Political Science.
- CIPD (Chartered Institute of Personnel and Development). 2023. *Labor Market Outlook - Views From Employers*.
- Dubai Online. n.d. "UAE Population 2022 - Total, Nationality, Migrants, Gender."
- EURES. n.d. "Labour Market Information: Italy." European Commission.
- . 2022. "Italy Is Looking For You!" July.
- Farag, Mona. 2022. "Oman's Latest Employment Rules for Foreigners Explained", Gulf News, 3 September.
- Federal Office for Migration and Refugees. 2023. *Migration Report 2020: Key Results*. Bundesamt für Migration und Flüchtlinge.
- Finotelli, Claudia. 2022. "Migration and Migration Policy in Italy", 4 April. bpb.
- French National Institute of Statistics and Economic Studies. 2023. "Immigrants By Country of Birth."
- General Authority for Statistics. n.d. "Labor Market Statistics Q4, 2022." Government of Saudia Arabia.
- GIZ (Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit GmbH), and ILO. 2015. *Labour Market Trends Analysis and Labour Migration from South Asia to Gulf Cooperation Council Countries, India and Malaysia*.
- Government of Australia. n.d. "Eligibility Assessment."
- . 2022. "Australia's Population by Country of Birth." Australian Bureau of Statistics, 26 April.
- Government of Canada. 2022. New Immigration Plan to Fill Labour Market Shortages and Grow Canada's Economy", 14 February.
- Government of Oman. n.d. *Oman Vision 2040*.
- Government of United Arab Emirates. n.d. "Percentage distribution of Employed Persons (15 years and over) by Nationality, Gender and Occupation."
- . 2008. *The Abu Dhabi, Economic Vision 2030*.
- Government of United Kingdom. 2014. *The Future of Work: Jobs and Skills in 2030*.
- . 2016. "Immigration Rules Appendix Shortage Occupation List."
- . 2020. The UK's Points-based Immigration System: Policy Statement", 19 February.
- GrabJobs. 2023. "Top 15 Most In-Demand Jobs in France in 2023."
- Gulf Research Center. n.d. Population By Country of Citizenship (Selected Nationalities) and Sex.

- . 2013. *The Demographic and Economic Framework of Migration in Kuwait*.
- . 2018. "Oman: Population By Country of Citizenship (Selected Nationalities) and Sex."
- Gupta, Vikash. 2023. "A Guide on Jobs in South Korea for Foreigners." Joy of Korean.
- Hayakawa, Chizuko. 2019. "Japan's Recent Dynamic Developments in Immigration Law and Policy", *Open Journal*.
- Horii, Maya, and Yasuaki Sakurai. 2020. *The Future of Work in Japan: Accelerating Automation After COVID-19*. McKinsey & Company.
- Hudson, Chris. 2017. *Singapore Immigration and Changing Public Policies*. Asian Studies.
- ILO. n.d. *Decent Work Country Programme Sultanate of Oman - 2018-2020*.
- . 2022. *Skills Needs in the Oman Labour Market: An Employer Survey*.
- IOM (International Organization for Migration). n.d. *World Migration Report 2022*.
- . 2021. *Kuwait Country Strategy 2020-2024*.
- Jung, Bongsoo. 2022. "Korean Immigration: The System for Employing Foreign Workers", LinkedIn, 8 October.
- Kallukaran, Davis. 2021. *Oman Vision 2040*. Crowe.
- Kim, Cynthia. 2022. "Korea Inc's Foreign Labour Crunch Puts Older Workers Back in Factories", Reuters, 16 August.
- KNOMAD (Global Knowledge Partnership on Migration and Development). n.d. "Bilateral remittance matrix 2021".
- Krogstad, Jens Manuel, and Ana Gonzalez-Barrera. 2022. "Key Facts About U.S. Immigration Policies and Biden's Proposed Changes". Pew Research.
- MacroTrends. n.d. *Australia Net Migration Rate 1950-2023*.
- . n.d. "France Net Migration Rate 1950-2023."
- . n.d. "Kuwait Net Migration Rate 1950-2023."
- . n.d. "South Korea Immigration Statistics 1960-2023."
- . n.d. "Uae Net Migration Rate 1950-2023."
- Mallory. n.d. "Information Technology Jobs and Descriptions."
- Middle East Institute. 2010. *Omanization Policy and International Migration in Oman*.
- Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan. n.d. "Visa."
- Morris, Anne. 2023. "Shortage Occupation List 2023."
- Nasrallah, Tawfiq. 2021. "Expats Form Less Than 40% of Oman's Population", Gulf News, 17 May.
- OECD (Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development). 2020. *International Migration Outlook 2020*.
- . 2021. "Changing Skill Needs in the Japanese Labour Market." In *Creating Responsive Adult Learning Opportunities in Japan, Getting Skills Right*.
- . 2021. *International Migration Outlook 2021*.
- . 2022. *International Migration Outlook 2022*.
- Planning and Statistics Authority. 2020. General Population, Housing and Establishment Census 2020. Government of Qatar.

- RGF Professional Recruitment. 2021. "Salary Trends, Hiring Trends and the Most In-demand Jobs in Japan", 12 February.
- Robinson, Kali. 2022. "What Is the Kafala System?" Council on Foreign Relations.
- Salary Explorer. 2023. "Best Paying Jobs in France 2023."
- Schengen Visa News. 2022. "70,000 Jobs Remain Unfilled in France's Travel & Tourism Sector, WTTC Says."
- Shingler, Benjamin, and Graeme Bruce. 2022. "In a Tight Labour Market, This Is Where Canadian Workers are Going", CBC, 23 August.
- SLBFE (Sri Lanka Bureau of Foreign Employment). n.d. "Foreign Job Vacancies."
- . 2021. "Annual Statistics of Foreign Employment 2021." Statista Research Department. 2023. "Breakdown of Foreign Workforce Numbers in Singapore in 2021, by Work Permit."
- Statistics Canada. 2022. "Immigration As a Source of Labour Supply."
- . 2022. "Immigrants Make Up the Largest Share of the Population in Over 150 Years And Continue to Shape Who We Are As Canadians."
- Tapp, Luke, and Pamela Macdonald. 2021. *Qatar Labour Law and Immigration: Recent Reforms*. Pinsent Masons.
- Teo, Joyce. 2022. "24k More Nurses, Healthcare Staff Needed by 2030 as S'pore Ages", *The Straits Times*, 5 October.
- The Korea Times*. 2022. "Number of Foreigners Staying in Korea Decreases 3.9% in 2021", 1 January.
- Times of Oman*. 2022. "Omans Expat Numbers on the Rise Since October", 13 February.
- UN DESA (United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs). n.d. "Economically Active Foreign-Born Population By Occupation, Age, Sex and Urban/Rural Residence."
- . n.d. "International Migrant Stock 2020." Accessed February 2023.
- US Bureau of Labor Statistics. 2022. "Projections Overview and Highlights, 2021–31."
- Victoria University. n.d. "10 In-demand Careers for the Future."
- Wage Centre. n.d. "Shortage Occupations in France."
- Wikipedia. n.d. "Immigration to France."
- World Bank Group. 2022. *Towards a National Jobs Strategy in Kuwait: Executive Summary*. October.

ILO Country Office for Sri Lanka and the Maldives

202-204, Bauddhaloka Mawatha, Colombo 07, Sri Lanka

Tel: +94 11 2500539 Fax: +94 11 2500865

Email: colombo@ilo.org

www.ilo.org/colombo

ISBN: 978-922-0399-15-6



9 789220 399156